

Hist 320 The Greatest Leaders in History

Numbered Transcript

HIST 320 • Lord Andrew Roberts

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Lecture 1: Foundations and Pericles

At a glance — In an interview format, Roberts sets out the course on great leaders and begins with the foundations of leadership and Pericles of Athens.

- 1.1 Dr. Roberts, it's a pleasure to have you here. As we start your series, can you please give us a brief outline of what to expect over the next eight hours?
- 1.2 Yes, I'm going to be talking about great leaders and what made them great and the pitfalls they had to negotiate and navigate. I'm going to really try to start, at least, to answer a question that I was first asked in 1981 when I was sitting my Cambridge University entrance exam, which was, "How can one person lead a hundred?" I suppose in a sense, the rest of my whole life and career has been spent trying to answer that question from 1981, and I'm hoping that I'm going to have a chance to do that today.
- 1.3 I think that an important part of all of this is for people please to remember that these are not the eight greatest leaders in history. Everyone will have their own list of that. We're not talking about Alexander the Great or FDR or Abraham Lincoln. We're just talking about the ones that I think I know about because I've done personal research in them. So please don't think that if I'm not mentioning your favorite leader in history, that I'm somehow dissing him or her. I'm not. And of course, every nation has its own great leader. Virtually every single nation in the world. The Mongolians will have Genghis Khan, the Turks will have Atatürk, and so on. These are just the ones that I'm talking about, are just the ones that I think I know about.
- 1.4 I'm going to ask lots of important questions, I think. How important is oratory, for example, in order to touch the hearts of the people who are the followers? How important is the vision thing, as George H. W. Bush put it? Do great leaders have to be ruthless? We're going to ask all the way through these next eight hours whether ruthlessness is an essential feature of leadership or whether or not it just crops up on occasions and is not an integral part of being a leader. When do leaders first recognize that they have the potential to be great leaders? Does it suddenly come up upon you? Is it something that, as I believe, comes on you in your 20s, usually? A fascinating number of these leaders we're going to be talking about, they have this self-realization moment, and I'm interested in talking about that.
- 1.5 Can leaders have friends? Do they need to have a sense of humor? Is sexual morality an important part of great leadership? There are lots of really interesting aspects that I think the lives and careers of these great leaders who we're going to be talking about throws hints and signposts and light upon the answers. I suppose another aspect would be courage and sincerity, to what extent are those important as well. Lots of questions.
- 1.6 That's excellent. Now, this is more of a personal question we'll turn to. You are touted by many as one of the greatest historians alive today, and you've written extensively on many great leaders—Julius Caesar, Napoleon. I suppose the line of inquiry here is, what

sparked this fascination with great individuals, great leaders? And maybe asked a different way, why is it that you do what you do?

- 1.7** I do what I do because it's the greatest job in the world. Who wouldn't want to have the opportunity to spend your life researching and writing history books? It's just the most wonderful thing to be able to do. Admittedly, a huge number, including me when I started off, are subject to the three occupational hazards of an historian, which is pundatory, pedentary, and penury. But I have managed now, at least, to get past those and to be able to write history books. It's a wonderful thing to be able to do, needless to say.
- 1.8** Lovely. Now, I suppose this is a bit of an ancillary question, but what do you hope to teach those taking this course? What would you like to get across?
- 1.9** Well, a large number of the answers to those questions that we posed just now, of course. But also, I suppose it's important to remember that although we're talking about war leaders, in fact, many of the lessons, many of the most important lessons of the lives of these eight great leaders, can be incorporated into the everyday lives of anybody who aspires to be a leader. You don't need a war in order to be a great leader.
- 1.10** Admittedly, it's going to be difficult to be considered one of history's great leaders if you're, I don't know, Prime Minister of Luxembourg in a time of peace, for example. That's not necessarily going to happen. But if you can learn what made a great leader in wartime, you can also apply those lessons to being a great leader yourself in peace time.
- 1.11** Excellent. Now, on that note, why don't we begin with our first great leader? Can you tell us who Pericles was and why we should be interested in him?
- 1.12** Yes. Pericles of Athens was the greatest of the statesmen of the golden age of Greece, the fifth century BC. He was a strategos, and that means a leader, essentially, a general. Also, of course, because Athens was a great naval power, that also meant being an admiral. But it goes beyond that, and this is something actually that's going to come up a lot over the next eight hours because it doesn't just mean being a soldier and sailor. It also means being a diplomat and a political leader. The strategi were elected, 10 of them every year, in Athens. The great thing about Pericles was that he was elected year on year from 461 BC to 429 BC, so for over 30 years. As a result, and also as a result of his charisma—we're going to talk about charisma and the creation of charisma later on—but he undoubtedly had it. He was able to parlay that capacity and electoral success and charisma into being the first citizen of Athens.
- 1.13** That's how he's described by Thucydides, a key figure also over the next hour, the greatest of the early historians. In many ways, a lot of people would say the first historian. Some people might call Herodotus the first historian, but I think of Herodotus as being a bit of a travel writer who made things up. So he's not essentially the first

great historian. That was Thucydides. And he wrote his History of the Peloponnesian War, which is one of the great works of history. And if anyone viewing this or anybody in the audience wants to read one book coming out of this set of lectures, except obviously from my books, I would love them to read, and I know that they would enjoy reading, Thucydides' History of the Peloponnesian War. What he said, even though he was himself a politician of Athens at the time and also elected a strategos, was that Pericles was the greatest of them. This was also supported by Hans Delbrück, the great German philosopher, who said that Pericles was one of the greatest statesmen of world history, soldier statesmen of world history.

1.14 Now, you'll no doubt delve into this particular topic, that being destiny, the importance of destiny, once we get to Churchill. But I wanted to ask you this question as it relates to Pericles. So, Herodotus and Plutarch both noted that Agaste, that being Plutarch's mother, had dreamt before, several nights before he was born, that she would bear a lion. And in fact, if we fast forward a couple hundred years, Philip of Macedon had the same sort of vision before Alexander the Great was born. The line of inquiry here is, well, I think, a rather simple one. Are some people born great leaders? Is it just destiny that they become great men and women?

1.15 The belief that you are being specially chosen by destiny —and it's not just Winston Churchill, also Napoleon believed that there was a star, a special star, that was following his life—this sense that you are specifically being marked out for greatness is very helpful, of course, because it gives you an enormous sense of self-confidence. But no, nobody, in my view, is born to greatness. The number of kings and queens who are born to be king and queen, and yet later turn out to be disastrous, is slightly testament to that. But also the fact that you don't have great babies, as in children, who are clearly charismatic and so on. It's not really a thing. So, no, I think there are going to be lots of ways to attain greatness, including, obviously, discipline and hard work and luck and lots of things that we're going to be talking about, risk-taking, an element of ruthlessness, and so on. But the idea that you're just marked out at birth for greatness is an incorrect idea, in my view, anyhow.

1.16 Wonderful answer. Now, turning back to Pericles and speaking about greatness, what were some of his greatest achievements?

1.17 Well, what Pericles really did was to turn the Delian League, which was an alliance of Greek city-states, very often islands, of course, in the Aegean Sea, but led by Athens, into—which was set up in 477 BC as a way of countering the threat from Persia —he turned that into an empire, essentially. An empire where, after 454 BC, tribute, what was known as tribute, which is basically cash, gold, silver, and so on, was sent by each of the city states to Athens. They spent it building the Parthenon, this wonderful and beautiful temple on the Acropolis, and also building a huge fleet that could dominate the Aegean, protect Athens and the Delian League from Persia, and also threaten Sparta, the other great power that was on the Peloponnese.

- 1.18** He was a key figure in the creation of the glory that was Greece. But he was also somebody who pushed forward the concept of democracy to its logical conclusion at that time. Because the navy was so important for Athens, it didn't have a large standing army, but it had the [inaudible] navy. That was a force for democracy because, of course, you needed lots of people, lots of free men, to pull the oars of the ships of the navy. And what he did was to advance the social standing of the citizen and made sure that citizens could take public office. He allowed the great occasions of Athens to be witnessed by the people. He was very much a man of the people. One of the reasons, of course, that he was reelected as strategos year in, year out.
- 1.19** Now, the Athenians had a system of ostracism, where every year they would vote. They would write down the names on little shards of pottery called ostracons, the name of somebody who they wanted to be exiled from the city for 10 years, to be banished. We know from archeology that there have been a lot of these shards that have been found with Pericles' name on it. He was constantly fighting an internal battle domestically in Athens to make sure that, because he was the first citizen, he wasn't essentially ganged up on out of feelings of envy and resentment. This is another aspect that we're going to come to a lot over the next eight hours, is the sense of envy and hatred on occasion that can be engendered by the greatness of others. And yet, he never was ostracized. Cimon, one of his political enemies, was ostracized in 461, so he didn't come back into politics until 451 BC. He was a very clearly, hugely impressive politician, as well as being a statesman and a great strategos.
- 1.20** Now, speaking of Sparta, Pericles did believe that war with Sparta was inevitable due to Sparta's envy of Athens. Now, was he right about that?
- 1.21** Well, this is one of the great questions of history. Is war ever completely inevitable? The great historian Graham Allison wrote a book called the Thucydidean Trap. He's talking about the United States and China today. But the Thucydidean Trap was essentially the argument put forward by Thucydides, that war between the two leading powers, the great military power of Sparta in the Peloponnese and the great naval power of Athens in Attica, were bound to go to war simply because they were envious of each other and they were at such a pinnacle of strength that there was no alternative to war. It's a very depressing thesis, needless to say, and one that, especially if it did extend to United States and China, could be the end of all of us. So it's an important one to try to grasp, but the arguments put forward by Thucydides are particularly powerful.
- 1.22** If I could just add, there are moments. The wonderful thing about Thucydides is he's the first historian who argues that things happen because of other things, because of other natural events and political events and so on. He doesn't just say, as earlier historians did, that wars broke out because the gods wanted it to and so on. He actually is a practical figure who believes in rationality and logic. These things, obviously, are an essential part to understanding why Greece was great.

- 1.23** But he also tells specific stories. There's the Megarian Decree, for example, in 432, which the Spartans put out, that states that its allies in its empire can't trade with Athens. And this, of course, with a great trading nation like Athens, is a *casus belli*, a classic example of how to start a war. So it's not because of what the gods wanted, it's because the Megarian Decree was announced. And Thucydides has a number of these moments in history. The Melian Dialogue is another one which is a debate about imperialism versus nationalism and so on, that explain why the Athenians did what they did when they eventually did go to war with Sparta in 431 BC.
- 1.24** That makes quite a bit of sense. Now, turning to Pericles himself, what was, in your estimation, his greatest strength?
- 1.25** I think his grand strategy, as well as the building up the Delian League and also promoting democracy. He had this grand strategy of taking advantage of what were called the long walls, which were the walls that had been built by Themistocles years earlier to defend against a Persian attack and to build them from Athens to the Piraeus, to the seaport, which essentially what it did was to turn Athens into an island. It had the capacity of doing that. And yet, when the Spartans came to Attica and destroyed the farms of the people, of the Athenians who were living there, of course, the Athenians naturally wanted to go out and fight. But Pericles prevented them from doing that.
- 1.26** And this is one of the many great aspects of Pericles, is he was able to tell the people things they didn't want to hear and to persuade them. And this is the great thing about democracy, is it's all about discussion, debate, persuasion, logic being used to choose the right path. Again, aspects that we will come on to a lot over the next eight hours. Pericles was a prime example of a statesman telling the people what they didn't want to hear and persuading them to follow his policy, which later turns out to be the correct one, because any number of politicians can just follow opinion polls. It's the easiest thing in the world. But greatness comes from not doing that and from following your convictions.
- 1.27** There's a marvelous line of Winston Churchill's when he was told that he needed to keep his ear to the ground, i.e., do what the populace was saying. And he said that he didn't think that the British people would look up to someone caught in so ungainly a posture. And that is the difference between a politician who just follows opinion polls and somebody who, like Churchill, like Pericles, does what's right.
- 1.28** Now, for many years, Pericles was involved in wars with Sparta and in various city states within Greece. So the question has to be asked, was Pericles a ruthless individual?
- 1.29** He was not a ruthless individual, but he could be ruthless at times. The things he did to, for example, there was a city-state called Chalcis, which was in Euboea, close to Attica. When they came across a trireme, which was one of the ships of the Athenian navy,

which was unable to protect itself, they massacred everybody on board. This, of course, was essentially a declaration of war against Athens. When Pericles came to defeat the people of Chalcis, he expelled them all from their land.

1.30 There was another occasion when an uprising of a city-state called Histiaea took place, and he brought 2,000 Athenian settlers and settled them on the Histiaeans' land. So this is, this is tough stuff. But frankly, war in fifth-century BC Greece was very often a war to the death. And you have, as I mentioned, the Melian Dialogue earlier. That was an uprising against Athens, where they actually put to the sword all of the males of military age and sold everybody else, the women and children, into slavery. You didn't cross Athens except at your peril, frankly. And it was in the context of a war and general wartime conditions that were extremely ruthless. So, yes, he was ruthless, only when he had to be. But nonetheless, I don't think he could necessarily be called a ruthless person, but he understood that sometimes statesmanship does require ruthlessness, and we're going to be seeing also a lot of that in the next eight hours or so.

1.31 Most certainly. Now, when we talk about Pericles and when we study him, there's often another name that's brought up, and that is Aspasia. Could you tell us who Aspasia was?

1.32 Aspasia was his girlfriend, his lover, his common-law wife, not his actual wife. So, this is another area, of course, where sexual morality comes into play, although sexual morality was very different in fifth century BC, of course, than it is today. And they had an illegitimate child. They were very much in love. But they also—and this is the important aspect of it, really, I suppose—had a social circle, a milieu, a group of people who tended to be the witty, the charming, the intelligent people of Athens—the elite, I suppose, is what you'd call them today—who therefore drew, and people included Phidias, the architect of the Parthenon, and one of the great artists of the day; Anaxagoras, the philosopher who taught Pericles; and others of the cleverest, essentially, of people in Athens.

1.33 As you can imagine, that created envy amongst the people who were not of their intellectual caliber, and it was a political problem for them, including the fact that Phidias was imprisoned at one point. Aspasia was accused of demoralizing, as in unmoralizing, the young women of Athens, and lots of other of their friends were picked on. Some were ostracized because their, Pericles' enemies knew that they couldn't actually bring down Pericles himself, but they could attack his family. And one sees actually in history quite a lot of this kind of thing, especially blaming women. Aspasia was, as was blamed, as I mentioned. You get that with Henrietta Maria, the wife of Charles I. You get that, of course, with Marie-Antoinette, the wife of Louis XVI, with the Tsarina Alexandra of Russia, wife of Nicholas II. Essentially, the way to try to damage the regime is to imply political power to the wives of the actual people who are powerful. It's as old as history.

- 1.34** Right. Well, we can think about this final question as it relates to Pericles as a bit of a capstone to this session. The question is, what should be on Pericles' epitaph?
- 1.35** Well, I have a great line from his funeral speech. In 431, when the war broke out, the Peloponnesian War broke out, he was able to give this wonderful oration to the people of Athens, talking about the dead of that first year of the war. They hadn't been particularly successful in that first year of the war. They'd done some rampaging in the Peloponnese, trying to attack Sparta from the sea. It wasn't hugely successful, but nonetheless, they had lost men. And so, standing there in the Forum—at Agora, it's called in Athens—Pericles gave one of the greatest speeches of human history, and it's in Thucydides.
- 1.36** There's a great debate, of course, amongst historians about whether or not he actually said the exact words that Thucydides ascribes to him, puts into his mouth. But whether he did or didn't, in a sense, doesn't matter, because as far as history is concerned, it is his speech, and he did, and he gave it, and it was a brilliant oration. Not only, of course, explaining to the parents of the dead soldiers why they died and what they were fighting for, but also explaining the inherent difference between democratic Athens and autocratic Sparta. The sense of openness of the city is a tremendous thing, and the openness and, essentially, the quality of the citizens, as opposed to the stratified hierarchical level of Spartan society, and constantly praising the wonderful attributes of the fallen heroes.
- 1.37** Even now, it's an extraordinary thing. This is over 2,000 years ago. You read that speech, and especially when you think, with regards especially to the Second World War, of course, about the victory over Nazi Germany, you can see—not that I'm for a moment equating Sparta with Nazi Germany; they're absolutely not the same things at all—but you can see a sense of pride in country, of belief in democracy, of true pride in the sacrifice that was made by these young soldiers that is not in any sense just a factor of life in 431 BC. It has a universal impact, and that's why I do recommend people to read it. You asked for the quotation, and it's this.
- 1.38** "Our form of government does not enter into rivalry with the institutions of others. Our government does not copy our neighbors, but it is an example to them. It's true that we're called a democracy, for the administration is in the hands of the many and not of the few. But while there exists equal justice to all and alike in their private disputes, the claim of excellence is also recognized. When a citizen is in any way distinguished, he's preferred to the public service, not as a matter of privilege, but as the reward of merit. Neither is poverty an obstacle, but a man may benefit his country, whatever the obscurity of his condition."
- 1.39** Now, that's boastful. Of course it is. He's boasting about his city, but it's true. This is the other great advantage. He had a wonderful sense of calmness in the face of danger. There's a moment in 430 BC, the year after the funeral speech, where Pericles is leading an attack, and just before it happens, an eclipse takes place. Of course, in the

ancient world, eclipses had nerve-wracking, seemingly a message from the gods and not a good one. And he was able to, through logic, through explaining why eclipses take place, to calm his men and to send them into battle not thinking that the gods had turned against them because the sun had eclipsed. So yeah, he's a very great man and one of history 's greatest soldier statesmen.

- 1.40 Wonderful. Now, why don't we open up to the audience for questions?
- 1.41 Thank you. Yes, absolutely. Who's going to ask me some incredibly difficult question that I'm not going to know the answer to?
- 1.42 Doctor, when you mentioned a great statesman 's craft and a politician can differentiate between the public's desire in the moment and what he thinks is the right decision, you mentioned Winston Churchill. When do you have, as a leader, to follow your nation's desire and, at the same time, follow your own ideas without becoming tyrannical and taking it in your own line of vision and becoming very, well, against democracy?
- 1.43 Yes, that's a very good question. The answer is, of course, it alters and changes throughout history history. If you are a successful leader who's able to persuade the people, then that 's one thing. But as you say, if you insist on your point of view being the one that's followed, you're in danger, obviously, of being ostracized in ancient Greece or thrown out of office, as happened to Winston Churchill in 1945. There's always a balance that needs to struck between the will of the people and the great leader who has to put that into effect. That's part of the fascination of history, is to see when one is uppermost against the other.
- 1.44 Hi, Dr. Roberts. You mentioned how a belief in providence or destiny or the supernatural can be useful in endowing a leader with a decisive level of self-confidence. You mentioned Napoleon and Churchill having these beliefs, and I don't know if that was true of Pericles as well, if he believed he was chosen by the gods. But in any case, just in a more general sense, do you think the fact that we live in an age where ideas like that are derided and this notion of the supernatural and providence is rejected, does that actually—is an inadvertent effect of that to make it harder for great leaders to arise?
- 1.45 I think that you're right. Of course, we do live in an age where people don't believe in destiny, providence. We believe in luck and chance, of course, but we don't tend to believe that we are specifically chosen. That can be an extremely dangerous thing. I mentioned Napoleon and Churchill; that helped them. But Adolf Hitler also believed that the reason that he survived the July 1944 bomb plot was because providence had taken a hand and, instead of being blown to smithereens, he just had his trousers shredded. You have this sense that can be positive or negative, as in Hitler's belief. But there are still plenty of people in modern-day world who believe that they are the chosen ones for particular tasks. But it 's a—of course, that will be helpful. But not

Pericles. Pericles was, if anything, like a number of these leaders that we're going to be talking about, actually quite agnostic when it came to belief in the gods. He was criticized for that as well, of course. I mean, that was one of the many things that his enemies tried to use to bring him down.

1.46 Thank you, Dr. What would you say was his greatest attribute?

1.47 I think oratory. We've talked about his strategic insights and so on. But ultimately, of course, we don't have any tape record scenes of what he sounded like, and we only really have Thucydides to read what he actually said. But obviously, he must have been a tremendous orator, not least because you would have several thousands citizens of Athens who would be drawn up in the Agora to listen to him and to be able to continue a speech of the length of the funeral speech and persuade enough people to be quiet enough in an enormous place like the Agora. When you visit Athens, you see how big that place is. To command without a microphone or a megaphone or anything like that, the attention of the populus was a tremendous thing.

1.48 Oratory, as we will come on to a lot over the next eight hours, is essential. It's the way that a leader can speak directly to the hearts of the people. It hasn't really, in that sense, changed tremendously much in the last 2,000 years. There were tricks of the trade, of course. People went to Greece in order to learn rhetoric, in order to speak in public. Several of the tricks of the trade you still see used in public discourse today in great speeches. He was obviously an absolute master of those. Now, that's not to say there haven't been great leaders who are useless at oratory. Napoleon wasn't particularly good, for example, at public speaking. You can become a great leader without being a great public speaker. But boy, it's a help if you are one.

1.49 Hi, Dr. Roberts. A question relating to the inner circle of many of these leaders, including Pericles. How important do you think for many of these leaders, for example, including Napoleon with his marshals, was having a relationship with a close group of people he could trust and who he could rely on? And how defining was that to their success and eventually their legend?

1.50 I'm so pleased you asked me that question, not least because my present book that I'm writing is called "Napoleon and his Marshals. " So it's obviously something that I'm thinking a lot about at the moment. And yes, for Pericles, having people around him like Anaxagoras and Phidias and Aspasia and so on, many others, of course, was an enormous help because what great leaders need is people that they can bounce ideas off. When they tend to go wrong, and we'll see this a great deal as well, is when they just get yes-men. That's always a bad thing. You don't want too many people around you who are dependent solely on you for their jobs because they tend to wind up turning into sycophants. You want people who you've known for a long time who are genuinely friendly, who've come up with you, and who you know are going to tell you the truth.

- 1.51 That's not necessary that you automatically do whatever they say. Part of being a leader is not doing what your friends suggest on occasion, but you need to have objective analysis given to you. When, in the case of Stalin, for example, he winds up killing a large number of the people in his own cohort, the quality of the advice that he gets is inevitably much less. Pericles was somebody who, and you get this with Winston Churchill as well, who actually appointed no men. He appointed people who he knew would disagree with him because he knew that it would sharpen his arguments. When you have internally the right arguments, you can then go out into the press and into politics, into parliament, and put those arguments with even greater strength because you know that they've been tested. This is an essential—it's a very good question that you asked because it's an essential part of leadership.
- 1.52 There's a great quote, which I've got here about the envy that comes from being out of that circle. This is the drawback with having inner circles, is that people who are out of the inner circle hate it and sometimes, therefore, malign the people who are in it. There's a great line, which, again, is from the funeral speech, where he says, "These glories may incur the censures of the slow and unambitious, but in the breast of energy, they will awake emulation, and in those who must remain without them, an envious regret. Hatred and unpopularity have fallen to the lot of those who aspire to rule others." It's the case throughout history. The key thing is not to be part of the slow and unambitious, but instead to be part of the people who have got the energy.
- 1.53 You touched on the differences between Athens and Sparta. Do you think that the system of government, how society is structured, strongly impacts the quality of leadership available to it?
- 1.54 Yes, it undoubtedly does. There are so many different types of democracy, of course, that the qualities for a leader to rise up in one kind of democracy are not necessarily the same as in others. You see this throughout history, and you'll also see it today in modern politics. But there are some things that actually don't change terribly much. I think if Pericles were able to use Twitter, for example, he would have been very good at putting out tweets that were able to encapsulate his ideas in 240 characters or fewer. There's one in particular that he was stating in the funeral speech, which, again, I've got here. Let me just quote it to you. Now, this necessarily wouldn't fit into 240 characters or fewer, but nonetheless, he says, "For the whole Earth is the tomb of famous men. Not only are they commemorated by columns and inscriptions in their own country, but in foreign lands there dwells also an unwritten memorial of them, graven not on stone, but in the hearts of men."
- 1.55 Thank you, doctor. I wanted to ask, I came across the phrase, "If you do not doubt yourself, you shouldn't lead." I wanted to know how that relates to Pericles and how it also relates to the other leaders that we're going to talk about today.
- 1.56 Oh, yes, self-doubt is vital. If you don't have any at all, then you are obviously not being very well advised. Every policy has more than one outcome. The key thing is that once

you've decided on a policy, then you mustn't show self-doubt because that's going to naturally be picked up by your followers. So, doubt yourself as much as you need until such time as you have to decide. At which point, self-doubt does need to be put to one side because otherwise it's going to seem like weakness.

1.57 You see this a lot in the leadership of various members of the Allied High Command during the Second World War. People like Lord Alan Brooke, the chief of the Imperial General Staff of Britain during the Second World War, he confides to his diaries huge numbers of doubts, deep doubts about whether or not various operations are going to come off. But when he's speaking to his staff and to his men, there's no doubt whatsoever that there's going to be victory. You see this with General George Marshall, who we're going to be talking about, and of course, Winston Churchill and FDR. Privately, Winston Churchill told his wife, Clementine, the night before D-Day, that he feared that the following day, the seas of Normandy were going to run red with the blood of the young men who were going to be charging ashore. That showed enormous doubts. Not so many, not so much doubt that he wasn't going to go ahead with the operation, but just doubts about what might happen if the operation went wrong. But again, in public, especially on that particular day when he was speaking to the House of Commons, you see no doubt at all in him. I think that is, it's the quintessence of leadership, that.

Lecture 2: Caesar's Command

At a glance — Julius Caesar — why he matters and what his command reveals about leadership.

- 2.1 Now, Dr. Roberts, turning to Julius Caesar, the first question we should answer here is, why should we study Julius Caesar almost 2,000 years after his death?
- 2.2 Over 2,000. Yes, he was the greatest of the Roman generals, but he was also a great lawgiver. And this is important. You remember we talked about strategos being the job of being a military, but also a political and diplomatic leader. Well, in that sense, Julius Caesar was the greatest of the ancient world's strategi. He was able to fight these enormous campaigns, the one in further Spain in 61 BC. Then after that, he fought in Gaul, modern-day France and Belgium, and then Germany. He invaded Britain twice, and then he fought from 49, January 49 BC, through to his eventual victory at the battle of Munda in 45 BC, a series of campaigns against his political enemies in Rome. And this was the most extraordinary thing, the Roman civil war, because over those four years, he fought in Spain, in Macedonia, in Africa, and ended up with this extraordinary victory in Greece.
- 2.3 So you have a war that's essentially being fought around the Mediterranean. And so he's this extraordinary soldier. It was said of him by, I think, Pliny the Elder, that he fought 50 battles more than anyone, including Marcus Marcellus, who fought 39 battles. He won all of them, apart from two. And in the case of those two, he wasn't so badly defeated that he wasn't able to counterattack and win afterwards. You know, any football team or basketball team that played 51, 48, lost two, is a pretty impressive organization. And that is essentially what Julius Caesar is. He, of course, eventually becomes, is assassinated by his senatorial colleagues. So, you know, it doesn't have a happy ending, this. Quite a few of these great leaders don't have happy endings, but nonetheless, he is the one against whom pretty much all future conquerors and military commanders base themselves.
- 2.4 Now he's also a dictator. Now, none of the other people that we're going to be talking about in this lecture series are dictators. But dictatorship in ancient Rome had a very different connotation. The word dictator meant that you dictated the laws, not that you had gigantic concentration camps and massive totalitarian states like the phrase dictatorship means to us in the 20th-century and 21st-century context. So that's why we still study him.
- 2.5 Now, you've mentioned many battles he's fought in, and I suppose the question here is, well, what drives the appetite for conquest on the part of individuals like Julius Caesar?
- 2.6 Well, in his case, it was the whole concept of Roman imperium, of the idea that unless you were moving forward a bit like the shark, unless you're moving forward, you're dying. And there was very much a sense of that in ancient Rome. They believed that they were extending a form of Roman civilization to barbaric peoples. Not always the

case, needless to say, but nonetheless, it's a common trope to imperialism, of course. But he also, the way in which they structured their, what was called the *cursus honorum*, which meant how you got on, in, up in society, in the social scale, was very much, especially in the early part of the *cursus honorum*, based on military attributes.

- 2.7 And he was very, very brave. He was personally tremendously brave. He won the civic crown, the *corona civica*, at the siege of Mytilene, and that, he did that through his personal courage. It was a bit like the Victoria Crosses in England. So you have very much a sense of the men admiring and respecting somebody who is brave themselves in battle. And also, he didn't ask his troops to do anything that he wasn't willing to do himself, and that's a really important aspect of leadership. He shared their lack of comfort and so on, on campaign—not once he'd become a dictator, but early on, in his early days, he established himself as a soldier's soldier.
- 2.8 So you would define that as his leadership style. Leading from the front.
- 2.9 Leading from the front. But he also had a very canny sort of politician's idea of how you use promotions, how you use plunder, how you use propaganda. I'm sure we'll come on to that later. How you give praise, all of that. He was very well immersed in the sort of the dark arts, shall we call it, of leadership.
- 2.10 Now, when we think about Julius Caesar, we see him as a conqueror. But you'll note, of course, in your books, that he is a phenomenal writer. And how important is literary ability in becoming a great leader or just in great leadership in general?
- 2.11 It's useful. It's important if you've got it. Winston Churchill, of course, being the other great example, he had, he wrote no fewer than 37 books. This was—he was broke all the time. He always spent much more money than he had. He literally was in the red, financially, until after the Second World War, when he signed the contract for his memoirs of the Second World War. Then finally he had money. He spent it on the first of 47 racehorses. So he really was the last of the great spenders. But in order to do this, he wrote 37 books and he wrote 800 articles and so on. And he'd started off as the best-paid war journalist, war correspondent, in the world at the time. So Churchill is a great example of somebody who was very good at writing. A lot of them aren't, frankly. A lot of them allow others to write their autobiographies and so on.
- 2.12 An exception to that is Napoleon. His proclamations were extraordinary and his memoirs were the top-selling, along with, actually, Harriet Beecher Stowe's *Uncle Tom's Cabin*. They were the 19th-century biggest bestseller, his memoirs. So, yes, you know, sometimes they are great writers, and Julius Caesar was the classic example of that. His commentaries are about his own campaigns, are both great Latin—you know, they're very good to read as history, but also amazing propaganda. And so a lot of what we know about him does admittedly come from him and therefore can't automatically be trusted any more than Napoleon's memoirs can be trusted.

- 2.13** But in fact, there's a great line. He refers to himself as Caesar all the way through. Anybody who refers to themselves in the third person is always a little bit suspect. It's a sort of classic sign for megalomania, third person writing. But he says, "Caesar's arrival brought hope to the soldiers and refreshed their spirits." He comes out very well from his own commentaries, I must say. But we do have lots of other people, of course. There's Cicero's letters and Sallust and Suetonius and Plutarch. So it's not just him that we based the estimation of him as being one of the great leaders in history.
- 2.14** Could you talk about the Egyptian campaign, his commentary on that?
- 2.15** Yes, he, of course, had to go to Egypt in order to destroy the Ptolemaic forces, which he did successfully. In the course of it, he fell in love with—insofar as anybody in history genuinely falls in love with somebody that they need politically—Cleopatra, and certainly had a great fling with her. She was supposed to have been brought to his headquarters wrapped up in a carpet, which everybody, for some reason, finds romantic. I think it's about the least romantic thing; imagine to be wrapped up in a carpet. Can you imagine? Anyhow, he writes about that and also so many other parts of his life. Essentially, it does come from him. But the great thing about the Egyptian campaign is that writing about King Pharnaces of Zela in 47 BC, he uses the phrase, "I came, I saw, I conquered," which is, of course, the one that we all know.
- 2.16** Now, he didn't always do as well as he did in Egypt, the classic examples being the British invasions of 55 and 54 BC, which weren't hugely successful. Later on, of course, the Romans did conquer Britain, but in those first two invasions, they didn't get hugely far but, in terms of propaganda, they were amazing. And people in Rome were enormously thrilled, really, at the idea that Roman soldiers had gone beyond the known world, as it was at the time, really, and captured these misty islands that were supposed to be full of silver off the northwest coast of Europe. And it really did sort of show the capacity and power of the Roman Empire.
- 2.17** Now I want to turn to Caesar's, shall we say, mannerisms, or his charismatic nature. He's renowned historically as being a very charismatic leader. How important is charisma in the realm of leadership, and how can one foster it?
- 2.18** Well, what it does, essentially, is to accrete to power and success. There are very few people who are charismatic but complete failures, and who fail again and again and again, and are yet still considered to be charismatic. It's an interesting thing that we mentioned earlier about how nobody's born charismatic. You don't get charismatic babies. But there are certain things you can learn about charisma, and it's an artificial construct. And actually, a classic example of this is the evil use of charisma, with Adolf Hitler, for example. Adolf Hitler would never be photographed wearing spectacles because he felt that it meant that it would detract from his concept of being a superhuman, a sort of Aryan superman. He would, of course, have people like Joseph Goebbels and Leni Riefenstahl, Albert Speer, doing the architecture, who would organize the films and the rallies and everything that would try to add to his sense of

charisma. He would stare at people and not blink, which you would have thought that that's a sort of game that eight-year-olds grow out of. But nonetheless, it was a way of trying to, you know, impose his will on people.

- 2.19** So these are all forms of the artificial construction of charisma. But beyond that, there's also the sense of charisma, such as, such as Julius Caesar had, and Pericles as well, and several of the other people we're going to be talking about, which comes from a natural, what the Romans called *auctoritas*, which meant a natural authority that does not come from the votes of parliaments or the claim of the people, but comes from one's own personal capacities and the recognition by other people of those capacities. And that is something that is innate, essentially. It's not artificially created. It's something that will let—Napoleon, of course, also had it—that will make people want to follow you, not out of curiosity, but out of a sense of your own personality and character.
- 2.20** Maybe a tie-in question to charisma, and it being natural to Julius Caesar, was his upbringing. Can you talk about his upbringing and how exactly that fostered his ability to be a great leader?
- 2.21** Yes, he had an aristocratic mother, which is true also of Pericles, who came from the upper classes. Napoleon, of course, had an American mother, but an aristocratic father. Several of the other people that we're going to be talking about didn't come from the upper classes, I hasten to add. But he had also, Julius Caesar had an education, an upbringing, that was geared to try to teach leadership. He was sent to Greece, for example, to study rhetoric. You remember we talked about how Greece was considered the *ne plus ultra* of rhetoric. Well, his parents sent him as a young man to learn rhetoric.
- 2.22** Actually, it's interesting what happened, because it relates to the concept of ruthlessness, because on the boat going over, on the ship, actually, to Greece, Caesar was captured by pirates. And they recognized that he came from a rich family and so they ransomed him. And he got on very well with the pirates individually. He charmed them. He was an immensely charming figure. He could deploy charm like a weapon. And he charmed the pirates. But he did say to them, "By the way, I'm going to come back and capture you all and put you all to death," which doesn't sound like a terribly charming thing to say, needless to say. But nonetheless, that's what he told them. And they'd have done well to have just killed him on the spot, but they didn't. They got the bounty, they got the money for him and the ransom, and then he did go back and he did capture them and he did put them all to death. He had them crucified, but because he liked them, he had their throats cut first. So that's a classic example, isn't it, of ruthlessness in action.
- 2.23** And then he went on and learned his rhetoric in Greece. So, yes, you do have this person who has been very much trained to be a leader and to take his first steps on this thing, the *cursus honorum*, which was the ladder of success that took you from being

essentially a subaltern in the army all the way up to being consul, of which there were elected two every year, who were the sort of chief executives of the Roman Empire, Roman Republic, should I say.

2.24 Now, you spoke quite a bit about his military successes. Quite a number of them you've documented in your books, of course. Was military success Caesar's sole claim to fame?

2.25 No, certainly not, because the strategos has to do more than just be a successful military leader. They were expected to be politicians and diplomats and so on. And so, with Caesar, although he was this great conqueror and commander, he also rebuilt Rome. He started to drain the Pontine Marshes. He instituted land reform, whereby his soldiers would get land in conquered areas and also in parts of Italy. He recreated the financial system, the treasury. You know, this is the lawgiver side of him. Now, obviously, as he made himself dictator for life, so that created that envy and resentment that we've already spoken about, which led essentially to his murder on the Ides of March in Rome in 44 BC.

2.26 But it wasn't just envy, it was also the sense that, as dictator of Rome, he was essentially a king, and Rome was a republic and was proud of being republic. And the senators considered themselves to be the protectors of the republicanism of Rome. And so he had got so high that they felt that the only recourse was to assassinate him, especially before he went off to Persia, because they feared that the fact that he'd won 48 out of 50 battles meant that he was going to crush the Persians and come back with the wealth of Persia, which would essentially make him king.

2.27 I want to just touch on this concept of envy for a second. So it seems that you're suggesting here that envy is an inevitable part of being a great leader. If so, are there any methods you can think of, of how a great leader can mitigate the deleterious effects of envy?

2.28 Yes. What really happens is, as you say, a natural result, the envy and resentment of the people who, as we've already called them, the slow and unambitious. They envy and hate the people of energy. And Julius Caesar was the classic example of the person of energy. What Caesar's nephew and, sorry, great-nephew and successor, Augustus, managed to do—Octavian, who later became emperor Augustus—was not to actually declare himself emperor, but instead to stay what's called *primus inter pares*, where you—so you're the, you're the first among equals, but actually you are the one who has the *auctoritas*, that sense of authority, which means that you are the top person in the Roman Empire. So although others might call you, might call you emperor, you yourself just call yourself the first of the state.

2.29 And that was designed at least to try to mitigate this sense of envy that had led to the death of Caesar, amongst other things. So, yes, you try to show some kind of humility. We'll get on when we talk about President Eisenhower, actually, it's very interesting about his strong sense of personal humility. And there's a wonderful quotation that he

came out with, which is to be seen in Abilene, in his hometown in Kansas, where it's brought home very much that he was somebody who felt humility. By complete contrast, Julius Caesar felt no humility whatsoever.

- 2.30** Now, that didn't mean that he didn't allow his men to, his soldiers, to take the mickey out of him. There was a rumor that went by, went round, that he had had a homosexual affair with the king of Bithynia. And he was bisexual, and this was a classic thing, when they were marching off on their campaigns, the soldiers would sing songs, essentially about Julius Caesar's sex life with the king of Bithynia, which he denied happened. But nonetheless, he let them do it because it was, in a sense, a kind of contract with the men that you let them treat you—you would never allow this from officers, by the way, or generals, but you allow them to treat you as a friend. You allow them to josh with you. The Duke of Wellington's soldiers would say, "Oh, there's old hooknose." You know, he had a big hooked nose, and they would take the piss out of his nose. And he didn't mind that. Napoleon would have the men shout, "Where are our new uniforms?" And "I'm hungry. What are you going to do about it?" That kind of thing. And he would josh back with them. But as I say, that was a way of essentially establishing the auctoritas without undermining these great, great generals. And in public, it would happen in public, but never ever with the officers and the generals.
- 2.31** That particular point there is quite interesting now, because you're touching on an element of Caesar that I don't think many people know about. And that's the personable nature of Julius Caesar. The fact that he was seemingly an approachable person to the masses, to the soldiers. How important is being personable to the common man? How important is that to great leadership?
- 2.32** Well, it's quite in a democracy, of course. It's not so important if you're not requiring their support. And Rome was in no sense a democracy, of course, but it was an empire based on military success. And so a natural rapport with the soldiers who did come to worship him was a very positive thing, partly, as I mentioned, because he won the Victoria Cross equivalent, partly because he would wear a different colored cloak in battle, which we don't know what color it is, unfortunately, but it was a different colored cloak from everybody else. So you're drawing attention to yourself, which, by the way, is an extremely brave and dangerous thing to do.
- 2.33** Other people would do that. Murat, Napoleon's marshal, would wear all sorts of rather gaudy, over-the-top clothes which would draw attention to himself. Admiral Nelson, as we'll no doubt discuss later, wore all his medals and decorations during battles. That didn't end well. And so you sometimes get that—Winston Churchill wore, he rode a gray, a white horse, in the battles of the North West Frontier, and I think also at the Sudanese campaign. So you have people who draw attention to themselves. Extremely dangerous, as I say, in battle. But nonetheless, that kind of flamboyance can also go down well with the troops.

- 2.34 This was a question I asked with Pericles, and of course, I'll ask it again with Julius Caesar. Was he a ruthless individual, or just ruthless?
- 2.35 Yes, he was, and to a greater extent than Pericles. As I think we established, Pericles was capable of ruthlessness, but was not a ruthless man. Julius Caesar was a ruthless man. He would not allow anyone to stand between him and getting to the top, frankly. He was ruthless in battle as well. We already established that he crucified all his pirate friends with their throats cut. That obviously is a mark of ruthlessness. But also, when he saved the province in Greece from the attack by King Mithridates of Pontus—extraordinary man, Mithridates III of Pontus. He would poison himself on a regular basis so that his body would build up enough antibodies that, if an enemy tried to poison him, he wouldn't die. So he was able to poison himself with the amount of poison that would kill an elephant, and it wouldn't kill him in the end. Actually, he had his head chopped off, and obviously, there's no amount of antibodies that you can build up in order to do anything about that.
- 2.36 But when he rose up against the Romans in 74 BC, Julius Caesar was politically ruthless in saving the province because he took no orders from the people above him. He should have, but he actually acted entirely on his own initiative, and that's something that we'll be talking about, of course—the moments when you need to do that. There was a Belgian tribe that massacred a legion, a Roman legion, in 53 BC, and he ravaged, completely ravaged, the lands of the tribes afterwards. He was pretty tough after the Vercingetorix uprising of 53 BC, as well. If you crossed Julius Caesar, you could expect to have some pretty unpleasant consequences.
- 2.37 And of course, his argument for that was the argument that you get again and again—Napoleon in Pavia, where he came down very harshly on the Italian city of Pavia in 1796. And what he argued was that, "Look, if you are particularly tough and harsh and ruthless, then that actually, although it's hateful for the people of Pavia, actually for the whole of the rest of the Po Valley and anywhere else you're likely to go to, it will encourage them to surrender quickly and it will therefore save their lives and mean that you're not going to besiege their towns and ravage their country as well. So throughout history, you have this sort of explanation for ruthlessness that only morally goes so far. Needless to say, it's not a particularly ethical stance to take, that you have to be ruthless in order to stop yourself from being ruthless afterwards, but historically, it has proved to be right, and the Roman empire did, after all, last many hundreds of years.
- 2.38 You'd spoken a little while back about Caesar's leadership style. It incorporated natural charisma, promotions, sharing the spoils with soldiers. Now, one thing that he liked to implement as a technique was shame. Can you explain how that worked?
- 2.39 Yes, this is a policy that is, it's sort of risky because it can easily backfire, of course, but with Caesar, what he would do is, if a legion behaved badly, he would not suck up to it, which is what a certain number of leaders throughout history would do, try to placate it

and so on. He would shame it. So a classic example being the 10th Legion, which mutinied, and he had them all drawn up and he called them civilians, not comrades, not military comrades. They were just mere civilians. They were just not worthy of being thought of as soldiers, because they'd mutinied. And they hated that. It went to the heart of their self belief. And as a result, they actually asked that he decimate the legion, which is to take one man in 10 and kill them, which he didn't do. He reconstituted the 10th, and it fought very bravely after that.

2.40 And this was something that Napoleon, who was a huge admirer of Caesar, and we're going to see a lot, actually, over the next few hours about how each leader learns from previous leaders, and then hands on the style and techniques to future leaders. It's very interesting. There's a sort of apostolic succession, and one of the parts of it is Napoleon learning from Caesar. And what Napoleon did with a regiment that broke and ran in battle—I mean, men run in battle, that happens, but they mustn't do it too early and, if possible, obviously, it would be great if they didn't do it at all, but they must reconstruct themselves immediately afterwards and hopefully go back into battle and so on. But if a regiment just quitted the field and was essentially cowardly, as opposed to just being forced back off the battlefield, Napoleon would have them drawn up just like Caesar did and would shame them.

2.41 And he would say, "You must burn your flags. We're going to not reconstitute this regiment because it has so badly shamed itself in battle." And they would automatically have the same response, where the concept of shame would work for them to make sure that, if they weren't, if the regiment was allowed to survive, it was always so much braver at the next battle. So this is something. It's understanding the psychology of the men, of the troops, that both Napoleon and Churchill—sorry, well, Churchill had it as well, actually—and Caesar had. And it comes from Napoleon reading Caesar's commentary about what he had done to the 10th Legion.

2.42 What was Julius Caesar's greatest victory?

2.43 The greatest of all of the 50 of them was the Battle of Pharsalus in the August of 48 BC. What he essentially did was— so this was in the civil wars—what he essentially did was to anchor. He had about 22,000 infantry, 1,000 cavalry. He was opposed by a force that was twice as big as that, which also had 7,000 cavalry. So, you know, the odds were not good at Pharsalus. Also, it was a completely flat plain, which meant that he wasn't going to be able to use topographical tactical advantage, which he was very good at in wars. And what he did was to anchor his left flank against the river Enipeas, and he put his cavalry on his right flank, and hid part of his reserves that he could then throw into the struggle on the right flank, which was the key one, because the infantry was in the center. And he was able to turn back the original cavalry attack on his right flank and then threw in the reserves at the key psychological moment.

2.44 Again and again, these great leaders have a sense of timing, which, not just in battles but in politics as well, which will come through. And also an appreciation of what's

called in German the *Schwerpunkt*, and in French the *point d'appui*, which means the key moment, sorry, the key place in the battlefield that needs to be taken successfully. And if it is, you can then do other things. You can turn cannon, you can turn flanks, and so on. Many of these great war leaders have a sort of almost sixth sense, an appreciation of the *schwerpunkt*, where it is and the timing necessary to take the initiative. You get it with Napoleon at the Battle of Austerlitz, his greatest victory, in December 1805, where he spots something called the Pratzen Heights as key to the battle, and he sends the Soult's division up onto the Pratzen Heights at the key moment of the battle. So that's a classic example of what I mean by this sixth sense. Now, it's not a sixth sense, as in, it sort of descends on you. It comes as a result of a lot of experience, a lot of hard work, a lot of reading, especially of history, a lot of devotion to the concept of learning how warfare works. But it is something that actually all of the great leaders that we're going to be talking about today definitely had.

- 2.45 Now, you just spoke about Caesar's greatest victory. Are there any defeats or a defeat that stand out in your mind? And how did he react to that?
- 2.46 Not really, no. As I say, there are only two of them, and on both occasions he was able to counterattack. The capacity for counterattack is also a really important aspect. We'll come on to the Battle of the Bulge later on in this series of lectures. But that's a classic example of a German counterattack being then held, and then the counter-counterattack. But the capacity for counterattack is a very important one in history. The idea that, yes, you've taken the punches, but nonetheless, you can slightly catch your enemy off-guard if they're moving forward and exploiting the victory too extensively. That comes again and again in the stories of these people. So you don't take setbacks as being definitive. You use the setbacks that have befallen you in order to counterattack.
- 2.47 Caesar was a template for many subsequent leaders, wasn't he?
- 2.48 Yes. Well, the very word "caesar", of course, was used later by the Russians in the word *tsar*, the Germans in the word *kaiser*, Germans and Austrians in the word *kaiser*. It sort of meant this—to have your own name become the actual defining word for greatness and success and conquering power and so on is obviously an example of why you're going to be taken as a template, and he was considered by Churchill to be the greatest man. Churchill thought Napoleon was the greatest man of action since Julius Caesar, thereby, of course, implying that Julius Caesar was as great or greater.
- 2.49 And so, yes, there are various aspects of Caesarean victory that one can think of. You know, the eagles, which have been used again and again throughout history by regimes and countries. The legions, the standards. The whole concept of Caesarean victory is one that other regimes really, pretty much throughout history, have always tried to emulate. And as we mentioned earlier about the apostolic succession, there are so many people who looked up to Julius Caesar, not always successfully, needless to say, because lots of them didn't have the capacities of Julius Caesar and the *auctoritas* and

the charisma and the military capacity and so on. But he has been seen historically as the sort of greatest of the great.

- 2.50** So we talk about the leaders that took inspiration from Caesar that came after him. Is there anyone that Caesar took inspiration from?
- 2.51** Well, he read about Alexander the Great, and so that would have, of course, been his own template. So there you also see the apostolic succession working like that, from Alexander the Great. Alexander, of course, went further. He went to, well, to the gates of India, of course, but he didn't have to fight so many major battles. He fought a lot of minor battles, skirmishes, a few major battles, but really, it was Julius Caesar when it came to this number. Napoleon fought 60 battles in all. I visited 53 of those. Sorry, 54 of those battlefields. He won 47, drew 7, lost 7. So it isn't quite these. The football team would do very well with that kind of number, but it's not quite as great as Julius Caesar.
- 2.52** That's an interesting point you've mentioned there, around going to historical sites of battles. Why do you do that as a historian? What do you gain from it?
- 2.53** Well, I always think that any military historian that fails to actually visit the scene of a battle that they write about is a bit like a detective not bothering to go to the scene of the crime, of the murder, that he's trying to solve. You know, you have to be there. When you see the topography of a place, and you go to the actual places where the generals were standing when they took their decisions, you can understand so much about a battle, because battles are all about topography. So when you go, for example, to the battlefield of Salamanca, which I do recommend everybody does go to, my gosh, it's the most beautiful part of the world, apart from anything else there in Spain. And there's the upper arapile and the lesser arapile, and arapile, meaning small hill. And it's only when you go there and you can see the way in which you can see some parts of the battlefield from one, and some parts from the other, but the lower obscures the view from the upper, for example, that you can understand why Wellington was able to make the split-second decision that he did to attack Marmont in the way that he did.
- 2.54** So, oh, yes, you've got to go to battle. We've mentioned earlier Austerlitz, Napoleon's greatest victory. It's when you stand on the Žurán Hill that you can see the Pratzen Heights and why the Pratzen Heights are going to dominate the whole of the right flank of his battle. And please don't believe the Ridley Scott movie of Napoleon that claims that the Russians and Austrians were defeated by Napoleon firing cannons through the ice. Those lakes have been very extensively dived on. They found one cannon and a couple of breastplates, and that's all that happened. That was not how that battle was won. It was by a much more brilliant strategic maneuver of Napoleon, which you can only really understand, I think, unless you're brilliant at looking at the maps, contours or maps. Actually, the best thing to do is to go out to Bohemia, in the Czech Republic, which I've done several times now, and love doing, and work out the walking of the battlefield. It's true of pretty much every battlefield. It will tell you something that it's difficult to pick up just looking at a map.

- 2.55** If we could give this particular lecture a title, we would probably call it, in your words, of course, "Julius Caesar: The Embrace of Risk." Could you talk about why that would be the title and the concept of risk in Julius Caesar's success and in leadership as a whole?
- 2.56** He was immensely audacious. Audacious primarily, of course, on the battlefield. But I'll come on to his audacity in politics as well. Essentially, the greatest moment of risk came in the January of 49 BC, when he crossed the Rubicon. And the reason that that phrase, "crossing the Rubicon," has entered into the discourse is because, once you cross that river, without the permission of the Senate, your life was forfeit. So he was not just risking the campaign and his troops' lives, but his own as well. And you were essentially acting in a treacherous way to the Roman republic, and he did it. And anybody who saw him and knew him would have known that he was going to do it, because all the way through his career, he took audacious risks.
- 2.57** It's a risk to cross the English Channel, of course, to invade a country that you know virtually nothing about, apart from sort of trading reports. It's a risk to go as far as he did into Germany, not too far like Emperor Augustus did, where he lost the legions at the Teutoburg Forest, but enough to win the victories that he needed. He, as we mentioned, fought the Pompeian forces all around the Mediterranean. In many of those moments, he took risks. I mean, the Battle of Pharsalus itself, you're fighting against a force twice your size. That in itself, being willing to give battle there, was a risk. And so, there was this audaciousness about him that he then translated into politics with the various political reforms that he instituted in order to change Rome.
- 2.58** And, of course, we have no idea what would have happened had he not been assassinated on the Ides of March. He probably would have attacked Persia. But every Roman attack on Persia before then and since was a complete disaster. So it might have been that he was drawn into Persia in the same way that Napoleon was drawn into Russia in the 1812 campaign, for example, and he might have been defeated. But knowing Julius Caesar as we do, there's also the extraordinary possibility that this audacity would have paid off yet again, and he would have conquered Persia.
- 2.59** Well, perhaps a capstone to the session now is a question around the greatest lesson we can take away from Julius Caesar. In your estimation, what would that great lesson be?
- 2.60** These weren't all mad risks that I mentioned. They were calculated risks, but they were risks. Napoleon learnt from Caesar the concept of audacity. In fact, he writes to Marshal André Masséna in 1809 in the German campaign, "Audacity, audacity, always audacity." And that is a recurring feature of greatness. So, yes, I thought we'd call this session the embrace of risk, because that is really what Julius Caesar is all about. But once he has embraced it, and once he has established himself as dictator for life, in those months between his victory at Munda in 45 BC and his assassination in 44 BC, he set in motion a series of great reforms that allows him to be considered a lawgiver and as well as a soldier, and therefore, the ultimate strategos of the Roman Empire.

- 2.61 Wonderful. Let's open up to the audience now for questions.
- 2.62 Hi, Mr. Roberts. One of the things that distinguishes Pericles and Caesar is that Pericles, especially how you described him, arose in a sort of more defensive context, from the threat from Persia in the east and Sparta in the south, whereas Caesar sort of emerged in Rome as it was expanding and the republic was expanding. How do you think these different leaders in these sorts of contexts, like, for example, nation builders versus those who save civilization from external threats, are portrayed differently? And how do we now see them differently so many years after their deaths?
- 2.63 A very good question. Yes. I mean, you have to be able to do both. And this is part of being the strategos, is to see whereabouts the likely threats are going to come from and how to defend against them. The people who are on the offensive, as Julius Caesar was for most of his career—in fact, almost all of his career—require a different set of skill sets. And what we are trying to do in this lecture series is to investigate both of those sets of skills and the techniques necessary to be successful in both of them. I think that, with regard to Pericles, he was so certain of his grand strategy being the correct one, and obviously, he must also have been so eloquent in being able to explain that grand strategy to his people, that these two things came together to be highly successful.
- 2.64 But you still have people, after his death—he died of the plague in 49 BC—and by 416 BC, i.e., 13 years after his death, you have other leaders, classic example being Alcibiades, who take the defensive role that Pericles had set out for Athens and turn it completely on its head. And they go off on the offensive, in this case into Sicily, in a campaign in Sicily in 416 BC, which turns out to be a complete disaster. And so, when the people of Athens essentially ditched the Periclean strategy for the Alcibiadean strategy, they lose the war. By 404, the Spartans have won the war, quite largely because the Sicilian campaign had killed so many Athenian soldiers.
- 2.65 Thank you, Dr. Robert. So, slightly building on the previous question, how much do you think our view of Caesar, and our sort of view of his success, builds on the success of his successor, Octavian?
- 2.66 Another very good question. Yes, an awful lot, because it was very much in Octavian's interests to present his great-uncle as being a god. Effectively, he was, like Augustus, was turned into a god. And gods, by their very nature, can do no wrong. And if you ascribe wrong to a god, you aren't just committing a political offense, you're committing heresy, which is an awful lot more serious. It also meant that it was in the interests of Octavian Augustus to put out the propaganda from some of the greatest writers of the day—Virgil, of course, being the classic example—that this was preordained, that Julius Caesar was a preordained genius who was victorious after again and again.

- 2.67 But we don't have to just take it on Virgil's words. We can look at those other people that I mentioned earlier, Sallust and so on, to recognize that. And, of course, huge amounts of archeological factors that point out that these battles did take place in the places that we thought they did. They must have. Caesar must have been victorious, because otherwise he wouldn't have then been able to have gone on and taken on the Pompeians in Spain, for example. And so there is enough of history to ensure that we are not being subjected to some just gigantic Augustan con job.
- 2.68 Thank you, Doctor. Caesar was a risk-taker. And one could say that trust is a great risk. His—
- 2.69 What is it? Sorry?
- 2.70 Trust.
- 2.71 Trust.
- 2.72 His assassination was effectively a betrayal, and one, if I'm not mistaken, many believe was coordinated by his protégé. Where is the place of trust and, I guess, distrust, and maybe even paranoia in great leadership?
- 2.73 Yes, and it's an occupational hazard for a dictator to be paranoid. It's not just Stalin who becomes paranoid, of course. It's a natural human reaction, I suppose, in a sense, to having complete power. But the interesting thing was that Caesar was not paranoid. He was warned by Calpurnia, his wife, and by a soothsayer on the way to the senate that day, on the 15 of March, 44 BC, not to go. And yet, he placed his trust in his auctoritas, of course, but also in his friendship for people like Brutus, which turned out, of course, to be wildly misplaced. But yes, paranoia does descend on many of his descendants. The Julian family has more than its fair share of paranoids—Nero, of course, being the classic example of it. So, yes, I suppose, in a sense, one of the attributes of greatness is to be able to recognize when you're being paranoid or when they genuinely are out to get you, which is not something that Caesar was able to do.
- 2.74 Is it more difficult for contemporary military leaders, generals, to be ascribed this status of great, given the dynamics of modern battle? So, for someone like Caesar or Alexander or even Napoleon, they fought these set-piece battles that were usually decided in a day or perhaps two days, whereas modern warfare is often fought over potentially 1,000-km stretch over three months or more, made up of lots of small engagements. So does that affect the perception of greatness?
- 2.75 It very much does, yes, absolutely. We'll be coming on to talking about Eisenhower and General Marshall and so on, where engagements do carry on for long periods of time. The First World War battles, you know, you can have a single battle that will go on for months. And that's one of the reasons why we don't really think that there were that many great generals of the First World War. That is one of the reasons. The period, actually, interestingly enough, when battles tended to go on for more than one day,

comes about halfway through the Napoleonic wars. So Napoleon's early victories in Italy, in the 1796 to '97 campaign, are one-day battles, by and large. Then you get on to, by the time of the 1809 campaign, there are fewer and fewer one-day battles. And after that, you have ones that do go on. Wagram, for example, is two days. But by the time you fight, Napoleon fights the battles at Dresden and Leipzig, they go on for three or four days.

2.76 And yes, you're right, it's much more difficult to ascribe that kind of greatness to these attritional battles. And there's a very good book by Cathal Nolan called *The Allure of Battle*, in which he points out, actually, battles are not that important in the long view of campaigns and wars, that a country can lose a battle on a single day. But ultimately, if that country is still producing more men and materiel and has got an economy that is stronger than the opponent's, actually, it can still wind up winning the war. You see this obviously, in the Second World War, to a degree. So, yes, it's an aspect, an attribute, I suppose, of modern warfare, that it's much less likely for you to be able to pinpoint the individual and say, "This is a great man." You have some people, General Grant, for example, in the American Civil War, who very clearly is. He's able to fight tactically, he's able to fight at divisional level, corps level, and army level, successfully. But there are very few great generals of the modern era who can do that. Duke of Wellington also managed to do that, of course. But yes, this is an aspect of it.

2.77 Looking back at the status of a leader or a nation, you can see, I kind of get the sense that there are two strategies, one more expansive and conquest driven, another one more conservative and maybe more conservative. Does that play a big role on the legacy a leader leaves back? Because I get the sense that the more expansive and conquest driven leaders get more of a folklore behind them. And, on another note, does that strategy play a big role on how sustainable the empire they leave back, how long they maintain what they built?

2.78 I think that you can get great leaders who are admired because of the defensive capacities, not ones who are going out on any great plan to conquer, like Alexander the Great or Napoleon or Julius Caesar. And by the way, a lot of Napoleon's wars were actually defensive wars. Of the 5, of the 7 wars of the coalitions, 5 of them were declared on Napoleon. Napoleon only started two of them. But nonetheless, he's seen as the conqueror because, when he responded to these wars that were declared against him, he then went on and conquered the country that had declared war against him. So. But what we mustn't do is forget the great leaders who are acting defensively. There are so many examples, of course, but we admire, of course, not politically because of the Second World War, but in the First World War, Marshal Pétain, for his defense of Verdun in the First World War, and also Georges Clemenceau, his prime minister, in that extraordinary defensive war.

2.79 The defensive maneuvers, actually, of the Duke of Wellington in the Peninsular Campaign are as impressive as his offensive maneuvers. The blitz during the Battle of

Britain, which we'll come on to with Winston Churchill, is essentially the defensive battle against the threat of Nazi invasion of Britain. And he's universally admired for that. Kutuzov in the 1812 campaign in Russia is, to this day, hugely admired in Russia, and deservedly so for the way in which he acted defensively. And I think also, actually, you could add Marshals Zhukov and Rokossovsky and Konev in the opening scenes of—not the immediate scenes of Operation Barbarossa, but 1942 and 1943, before they go back onto the offensive after the victories of the summer of 1943.

2.80 So, yes, I think you can be a great leader in defense. That's essentially what Pericles was, of course, in the opening two years of the Peloponnesian Wars. And you don't have to be doing what Julius Caesar did, which was to sort of ride his horse through the triumph at Rome, in order to be considered a great leader.

Lecture 3: Napoleon's Noble Narrative

At a glance — Napoleon, set against the importance of the French Revolution.

- 3.1** Beginning now with Napoleon in this session. Let's begin with the importance of the French Revolution. The question is, how important was the French Revolution to Napoleon's sense of self?
- 3.2** It was absolutely crucial, central. Napoleon said later that in order to understand somebody, you have to look at the world when they were 20 years old. This will come up quite a lot, I think, in future discussions that we're going to be having, because when you're 20, or in your early 20s, people have a sense of the *Weltanschauung*, of what the world is about. This very much happened for Napoleon. He was 20 when the French Revolution broke out. He was, up until that point, a virulent Corsican socialist, to the point that he was actually very anti-French, which is extraordinary, considering that he became Emperor of the French. But he wrote rather emotional short stories about massacring the French. He was an early supporter and an extreme supporter, a Jacobin, of the French Revolution. He believed in the concept of meritocracy, of equality before the law, of these various big ideas that had been swirling around amongst the intellectuals, of course, for the previous 30 or 40 years, but were suddenly about to be put into place, in particular, meritocracy.
- 3.3** Because, for the first time in French history, you were no longer going to be of the rank and status of your father or grandfather. You were going to be able to get whatever rank and status your own abilities commanded. That's why when one looks at the 26 marshals of the French army appointed by Napoleon, no fewer than 13 of them were the sons of barrel coopers and innkeepers and peasants and indoor servants and so on — people who, in the past, would never have been able to have got to the stage of Marshal of France.
- 3.4** That's great. The point that you've made here on meritocracy, I think, is important for the next line of inquiry, and it's with relation to Napoleon's childhood. Could you speak a bit to that?
- 3.5** Well, although he was an aristocrat, actually, Corsica didn't really have an aristocracy. He had the quarterings, as it's called, because your coat of arms is cut into quarters. He had the quarterings of an aristocrat. And because his father was able to prove that he did come from an aristocratic family, he was able, therefore, to get free education in French schools paid for by the king. That was also very lucky because they didn't have much money. They boasted that the Bonaparte family never needed to make its own olive oil or wine. They had enough in the way of vineyards and olive trees to be able to consume their own products, but they didn't have much disposable income. His father was a very middling-ranked lawyer. But his father was a great reader. Essentially, Napoleon was born in a library. He had this Enlightenment background. He was a

follower of Pasquale Paoli, the great Corsican Nationalist leader. And as I say, it wasn't until the French Revolution that he put his Corsican Nationalism to one side and considered himself to be French.

- 3.6** Now, one thing that we notice when looking at Napoleon is that he was incredibly popular amongst his men. The members of the Grand Army absolutely loved him. What did Napoleon offer to his men that other commanders at the time, his contemporaries, Napoleon's contemporaries, did not offer their men?
- 3.7** Immortality. Not actual immortality, because an awful lot of them did die during the Napoleonic Wars, but the concept that what they were doing was going to resonate throughout history, that they weren't just going to be forgotten as the vast majority of people were and are forgotten, but actually they were going to be doing things that historians were going to be interested in hundreds of years later. In that case, of course, they were proved right, or at least as far as I'm concerned, they were proved right. The way he did that was to appeal to a sense of history. Of course, most people weren't educated at all, but one, they had a sense of the French past, and he appealed to it. He made it clear that—he says at one point, the way to enthuse the men is to "electrify their souls." The way that he electrified their souls was to equate what they were doing to the great moments of the French past. And this was an unusual thing for soldiers of the day, and it was an incredibly powerful thing. It went down immensely well with them.
- 3.8** It's interesting, this point here I'm thinking of now, is that we mentioned Caesar and his ability to be a man of the people. So members of the Roman military would joke about Caesar. And is it the case that Napoleon also had the common man's touch?
- 3.9** Totally. Oh, yes, yes. He was able to interact with his men on a personal basis in a superb way. When they stopped for bivouacking in the evening, for example, so the men would be able to sleep the night, he would invite the drummer boys around the campfire. He would make sure that his sentries outside his tent got given wine first. Why one would want to have drunk sentries, God alone knows. But nonetheless, he would make sure they were kept with food and wine. And he would, in battle, actually, if he saw something brave taking place, he would go and unpin his own légion d'honneur and put it on the brave soldier. And that meant, as well as obviously having this medal that the Emperor had touched, it would mean that the chap would have a pension for life, which was tremendously helpful, needless to say, financially, because these soldiers were not overtly, terribly well paid.
- 3.10** Those kind of things, of which there are many more—his sense of proclamations. I mentioned earlier, he wasn't much of a public speaker, but he had the most fantastic capacity when it came to the written word and with his proclamations, such as the famous one before the Battle of the Pyramids in 1799, when he said, "Forty centuries look down upon you." Classic example of tying in what the soldiers were about to do in the battle the next day to history, in this case, obviously, the ancient history of Egypt.

- 3.11** Now, this capacity for humility on Napoleon's part, is this something that is unique for him amongst his contemporaries, or were there other military leaders during that period that also demonstrated that humility?
- 3.12** I wouldn't call it humility. I'd call it, as you did, a common touch, an ability to interact. He wasn't a humble man. He was, if anything, vainglorious and boastful and very full of his own achievements, a hugely egotistical figure as well. But he was, as you say, somebody who could relate to the soldier. As we mentioned with Julius Caesar being personally brave, he himself had also been very personally brave in the siege of Toulon. In fact, he'd been wounded in the side by a British pike in the siege of Toulon. So the men knew that he wasn't asking them to do things he wasn't willing to do himself. That was an important aspect of his leadership. A lot of the other leaders, especially on the coalition side, men like the Duke of Wellington or the Archduke Charles of Austria, were of such elevated social status that it would have been considered *infra dig* to try to equate too much with them. Yes, if they were in a group, you'd have, "Oh, look, there's old Bony, or or old hooknose, Wellington." But nobody tried to do that on a one-to-one basis. Whereas, of course, Napoleon did allow that with his troops, but not, as I mentioned earlier, with his officers in a way that would in any way seem that they were getting over-familiar.
- 3.13** Now, just continuing the point on humility, you've pointed out that he's obviously not a humble man. He's quite grandiose in how he portrays himself. Napoleon has a reputation for being short. Now, was he actually short? If so, did that mean that he had a Napoleon complex or some sort of Napoleon syndrome?
- 3.14** There is such a thing as the Napoleon syndrome, but Napoleon didn't have one. He was, apart from anything else, not short. This is one of the great misconceptions of him. He was 5 foot 6, which is exactly my height. Exactly. Yours, too, I think, as well, Vincent. We're not short, are we? No. Also, by the way, of course, for a Frenchman of the 18th century, when people were shorter than they are in the 21st century, that, too, was another reason why we don't think of him as short. The reason that people have thought of him as short is because the British caricaturists, men like Thomas Rowlandson and James Gillray and others, George Cruikshank, always presented him as short because they wanted to denigrate him, to make him out to be a morally smaller figure as well as physically. And that caught on. But yes, as we know from his height, *vis-à-vis* the other males of his time and class and background, he wasn't short.
- 3.15** Could you speak to Napoleon's capacity for compartmentalization?
- 3.16** Yes, this is a very important aspect of his leadership capacity. You do see it in other leaders as well. But in Napoleon, it was really brought to an extraordinary apogee. He was able, wherever he was, completely to concentrate on the one thing that mattered at hand, completely regardless of what was going on around him. This allowed him to work tremendous schedules and much harder than anybody else around him. He was — a couple of examples. On the eve of the Battle of Austerlitz, his great victory, where

he had any number of important things that he needed to do, he did them. But then he went back to his tent and wrote the rules of a girls' school that he wanted to set up in Saint-Denis.

- 3.17** In 1812, when he was in the Kremlin and it had caught fire and part of it burned down and he had to move out, and this is well into Russia, of course, hundreds of miles into Russia —you can imagine, you're in the middle of the 1812 campaign with the burning Kremlin and so on —he wrote the rules for the Comédie-Française. And he also, just before another battle, was able to send a letter to the prefect of Genoa telling him not to take his mistress to the opera. I mean, this is the most incredible capacity for compartmentalization. And it did mean, as I say, that he was able to concentrate the full range of his brilliance, his genius, onto whatever was happening at the time, regardless of outside interferences.
- 3.18** Now, we can talk about his immense levels for mental concentration, compartmentalization. Was Napoleon a good public speaker? Was he a gifted orator?
- 3.19** No, it's an interesting aspect. He did have to give a few speeches in public. He gave one in 1804 on the presentation of the Eagles to the Army, and they all slightly fell down flat. At the time of the Brumaire coup in 1799, his military coup which brought him to power, everybody else was giving speeches around him, but words slightly failed him on that occasion and on others. So, he was fine on the one-to-one conversation, and a highly intellectual man. I mean, he enjoyed conversations with astronomers and physicists and physicists and chemists and so on, and men of letters and that. But in large groups or big audiences, he didn't shine, which is slightly unusual amongst great leaders.
- 3.20** It is. I suppose the next line of inquiry here attached to this is, well, how did he inspire so many people if he wasn't a good public speaker?
- 3.21** Through his proclamations, through his orders of the day, through his newspapers. He set up the Moniteur and various other newspapers that were essentially propaganda sheets for his army. He exaggerated wildly the number of enemy troops killed and minimized the number of his own troops who were killed and wounded in the same way that, frankly, people have done throughout history. But he was somebody who was able, as I say, to electrify the soul of his troops.
- 3.22** Now, we spoke about the term strategos, and you'd made very clear that that term does not refer solely to an individual being a soldier. Can you speak to this term as it relates to Napoleon being a lawgiver?
- 3.23** Yes, he was somebody who, when he came to power in the Brumaire coup in 1799 and appointed himself First Consul of France, saw his duty from that moment on, certainly until the Austrians effectively declared war on France in 1805, as being that of a lawgiver. So he completely changed the education system of France, for example, bringing in the concept of the lycée, raising up the Sorbonne University. Both, of

course, of these are still in existence today. You mentioned the légion d'honneur. He instituted that and he made it open to people of all classes, another example of the meritocracy that I mentioned. Of course, when it came to infrastructure, the roads he built, when you go and have your romantic weekend in Paris, you will cross over one of the four bridges over the Seine and see the enormous reservoirs and the beautiful buildings of central Paris, largely down to the architectural achievements of the Napoleonic era.

- 3.24** Then you also have the Banque de France, which was the thing that essentially ended the runaway revolutionary inflation in 1799. It was set up in 1800. That gave stability to the French franc, still in existence today. The Cour des Comptes, which vets French laws, still meets every Wednesday today. You have these major, what he called blocks of granite that he dropped onto the French state. And as I say, many of them are still around. The most important of them, of course, by far, is the Code Napoleon. Up until his coup, the laws of France were a hodgepodge of some of them ancient French law, some of it Roman law. They had something like 420 different systems, different ways that law was interpreted. 420. Some were regional, some were city. As I say, some went back 1,000 years.
- 3.25** And understandably, this was a tremendously inefficient way to go about business because you didn't know who you could sue, essentially, and didn't know under what system you'd do it anyhow. So he brought in a single code, and that's something that extended actually beyond the empire. The Rhineland was still using it in 1900. It's the basis of much European law today. It can be seen in the legal system of Louisiana, even up until this day. The Code Napoleon, one body of laws, was instituted by him. Now, he didn't sit on all of the commissions to draw it up, but he sat on half of the meetings, and it all was published in one volume, and that was an extraordinary achievement. So he was a great lawgiver and builder, but of course, it all was completely dependent on his victories on the battlefield, ultimately.
- 3.26** Now, Napoleon's achievements as a lawgiver speaks to a grand vision. I guess the question here is, what was his moment of self-realization?
- 3.27** Well, with so many of these people that we're going to be talking about, it happened in his 20s. It was when he was 27 years old and he had won the Battle of Lodi in Italy, in northern Italy. He had been made a general at the Battle of Toulon, and he had, in the year before Lodi, had fired on French civilians, putting down a counterrevolution in Paris, killing about 300 people. It's called the Whiff of Grapeshot in the October of 1795. But the thing that made him great was his command of the army of Italy in the March of 1796, because that allowed him, at this incredibly young age, only 27 years old, to embark on a series of lightning strike campaigns against the Austrians in northern Italy.
- 3.28** At Lodi, which took place in the May of that year, he managed to win a battle against much larger Austrian forces by essentially crossing a bridge. You can still see where the

bridge is at Lodi. Very long, very thin bridge. The Austrian grapeshot fire had cleared the bridge several times, and he tried to get over it. Various members, marshals of his, tried to get over it. There was much bloodshed, but he also managed to, because he was an artilleryman, to rejoin where the batteries were to fire at the batteries that were firing on the bridge. And he sent a cavalry force about 20 miles south of the bridge to attack the Austrians from behind, and he won this famous victory.

3.29 And that was the moment at which he later said he knew that he wasn't just a soldier, but that he was a successful general. And he got this sense of self-belief. So when he entered Milan, about five days after Lodi, and captured it from the Austrians, he entered as the Napoleon that we know of, the one that Stendhal writes about in *Chartreuse de Palma*, this sense of a man who knows where he is. We mentioned earlier, of course, about his sense of destiny, this idea of his lucky star being above him. That comes from Lodi.

3.30 With Winston Churchill, it was when he was 25 years old in the Boer War in 1899, when he escaped from the Boer prisoner-of-war camp. He had to cross 300 miles of enemy territory. At one point, he had to hide down a mine shaft. When his candle guttered out, he could feel the rats scattering over his face. A truly horrible moment. He was being followed by a vulture for a few miles, too. But when he finally got to Durban, he was acclaimed as a great hero, and that was his moment of self-realization that he was a hero of the empire. And with Stalin, Stalin was 28 when he robbed a bank in Tiflis. And about four or five people were killed in the course of the bank robbery, but he got away with the equivalent of \$6.4 million in today's money. And suddenly, all the other Bolsheviks who'd rather looked down on him because he was an outsider, he was a Georgian, he wasn't a native Russian and so on, spoke of him and treated him with a great deal of respect because he was able to rob banks. And that was his self-realization moment. And you do get it with lots—I'm sure, with the future sessions, we'll be talking about other people's self-realization.

3.31 Certainly. And this concept of self-realization also leads into adversity. And we can talk about martial conflict. Can you list some of Napoleon's great campaigns or battles, particularly the Battle of Waterloo or even the Russian campaign?

3.32 Yes. Well, he started, of course, with the 1796 campaign that I mentioned in Italy, which was a blitzkrieg campaign, which he did incredibly well. Then he went off to Egypt in 1798 and conquered Egypt, went into Syria, went past Gaza, in fact, went through Gaza, and got up to Acre, which is in modern-day Israel. And he was forced back from there. It was his first setback, his first defeat. He left Egypt, in a sense, in having been defeated there. But that's not what the French back in France were told when he arrived there in 1799 and was willing, was able to, overthrow the directory government, this corrupt government of France. He then went off to, as First Consul after this coup, to fight the Austrians and cross the Alps, thereby getting behind the

main Austrian army and cutting it off from its lines of communication, defeating it at the Battle of Marengo in the June of 1800.

3.33 Then there was this big gap where he did all the lawgiving things that I mentioned earlier, or most of them at least, and set them in train, certainly. Until the 1805 campaign, when the Austrians declared war on him, and he went off and won the Battle of Austerlitz, this extraordinary victory, where he was able to spot the key place, the Schwerpunkt, at the key time. Actually, the mist was just—when you go there, you see the mist in the valley, and it gets burnt off by the sun. At the key moment was when the Russians and Austrians didn't see that there was Soult's Corps hiding in the mist before it suddenly charged off with a —so the sun of Austerlitz was something that entered the Bonapartist myth from then on. Then there was the 1806 campaign against the Prussians, which was won at the Battle of Jena. There was peace then with Russia in 1807 because the Tsar didn't want Napoleon as an enemy after this string of victories. The Austrians went to war with him again in 1809. All this time, of course, the British were at war with revolutionary France, from long before Napoleon came to power all the way through, with only a one-year gap in 1802, 1803.

3.34 If Napoleon had stopped there, when he was master of Europe in 1807, at the time that he signed the peace treaty of Tilsit with the Tsar, then he—who's to know? There might be a Bonaparte on the throne of France today. However, the Austrians, as I say, went to war with him again in 1809, and he was drawn by that stage into a long, vicious guerrilla war in Spain, known as the Peninsula War, Spain and Portugal, which was to cost him a quarter of a million men. Even that, he could have survived, perhaps, if he hadn't, in 1812, invaded Russia. He did this partly because the Russians had started to trade with the British, and he was always trying to cut off European trade with the British. That's also why he invaded the peninsula. But also because he recognized that the Tsar had fallen out of this friendship with him that had begun at the Battle of Tilsit, at the peace of Tilsit. And so he invaded Russia.

3.35 Now, it sounds like a classic sort of Napoleon syndrome, Napoleon complex thing to do, to invade an uninvadable country, essentially. Everyone is told on their first day at Sandhurst Officers Cadet School in Britain, the number one rule of war is never invade Russia. But he'd seen that Charles the 12th of Sweden had done it, disastrously as it turned out. He knew he had an army twice the size of the Russians. He had no intention of going. He'd already defeated the Russians twice before at Austerlitz and also at Eylau and Friedland, in fact, three times before. He had an army that was so enormous—615,000. It was the same size as Paris at that time. And so, he was able, he believed he'd be able to just fight a three-week campaign, 50 miles or so inside the Russian border, have a decisive battle against the Russian army, win it, and that would be the end of the war. That is how all the wars, apart from the peninsula war, had gone up until that point.

- 3.36 But what he didn't take into account was that the Russians were going to retreat further and further back into their country, use scorched-earth tactics to destroy everything that the French army could possibly eat on their advance, and occasionally fight battles such as those at Smolensk and Borodino, which would be expensive for the French army. Ultimately, he was drawn all the way into Moscow. Now, he had enough time to go back. In fact, his plan was to return from Moscow to Smolensk, and he had more time to do that than it had taken him to get from Smolensk to Moscow. But he was drawn into a battle at a place called Maloyaroslavets in the October of 1812 and wasn't able to take the route back that he wanted, upon which time, of course, the blizzards of the Russians came in, and they were, and together, of those 615,000, only about 90,000 men returned back over the River Niemen that they crossed in June of 1812. So it was an absolute crushing defeat, and that was the reason that, ultimately, you get on to the 1813, 1814, and ultimately, the Waterloo campaign.
- 3.37 Now, I want to stick to the retreat from Moscow for a second here, particularly the decimation, the fact that it was a tremendous defeat for Napoleon and the French. How important is leadership in the face of catastrophic defeats?
- 3.38 Vital, because if you are to—every commander, apart from even Julius Caesar on two occasions, gets defeated sometimes. And Napoleon was defeated seven times out of the 60 battles that he fought. And so you have to be able to come back from that. Or the other alternative is do what Winston Churchill managed to do in 1940, which is after the obvious defeat at Dunkirk—his phrase, "Wars are not won by evacuations" — to persuade the people that, yes, they've lost the battle, but they certainly haven't lost the war. Charles de Gaulle, of course, was able to do that in his great speech of the 18th of June 1940 from London. So you persuade your populace that, yes, you've been punched on the nose, but you are not down and out.
- 3.39 The way that Churchill managed to do that, really, was to persuade the British people that they hadn't been defeated by coming up with lots of reasons why there was a chance that they were going to be able to beat the Germans, the blockade of Germany. He said that there weren't going to be very good harvests in Europe in 1940. He said that France was going to stay in the war, which, of course, it didn't. It was forced to capitulate in the middle of June 1940. Each of these arguments he put forward, lots of them were just grasping at straws, but they were enough, especially when put in this immensely eloquent phraseology that Churchill used to persuade the British people that they had not lost. That is an essential part of leadership, if you want to continue the struggle, is to, in the face of all the facts, to persuade the people that you haven't lost. Napoleon managed to do that for another two and a half years after the retreat from Moscow, even though, as I say, he'd lost the vast majority of the Grande Armée in the snows of Russia.
- 3.40 Now, I've asked you this question in the previous two sessions on Pericles and Julius Caesar. The question is, was Napoleon a ruthless individual or was he ruthless?

- 3.41** He was, on occasion, undoubtedly ruthless, yes. The classic example, well, I mentioned Pavia, the Italian city that he treated immensely harshly after their uprising in 1796. But actually, the most ruthless thing he did was at Jaffa in modern -day Israel in 1799. What happened, essentially, was that a large group of Turkish soldiers, many of them artillerymen, about 3,000, some historians think more, gave their parley, gave their promise not to bear arms against the French Republic again. Three weeks later, this was when they had been captured and defeated at, in Gaza. Sure enough, three weeks later, they were captured again in Jaffa, having borne arms against the French Republic. The 18th century laws of war were a lot harsher than ours. Of course, it's the Middle East, which also didn't have quite the same rules of law as in Europe, and he basically executed them all. And it's a great blot on his reputation, essentially. Whether he thought of it as a war crime or not, certainly the British did, and most anti-Napoleonists did. And yeah, it was an act of extreme ruthlessness.
- 3.42** Now, we've spoken about Napoleon as the military strategist, the military genius, as well as the lawgiver. Can you speak about Napoleon, or speak to Napoleon as Napoleon the romantic, particularly around Josephine?
- 3.43** Yes, he was romantic. His letters to Josephine, especially soon after they got married in the March of 1796—in fact, he only had a holiday of 24 hours before he had to go off to Italy to command the army, and she stayed in Paris—the letters are profoundly erotic. They're basically all about sex, really. They're great. They really are. I do recommend the Napoleon's love letters to Josephine. He was a man in a sort of passionate love with his wife. She wasn't in love with him at the time, unfortunately. She was having an affair with a Hussar called Hippolyte Charles. When he found out about it, he then embarked on an affair with Pauline Fourès, who was the wife of one of his officers. Then he embarked on a series of affairs with what I, in the biography, when I wrote the biography, I counted up to 27 mistresses. So he definitely got his own back on Josephine and more.
- 3.44** But he always thought of Josephine as being his lucky star, not that star of destiny, but as being lucky for him. And so when he was forced to divorce her because he wanted children, and she couldn't have any, and then he married the daughter of the Emperor of Austria, the Archduchess Marie Louise, that was also the same time that the luck turned against him. As you'll remember, there were no great victories after 1812. There were just a series of defeats. So in a sense, he was right. When he was married to Josephine, he was doing well. When he divorced her, the luck ran out, essentially. You can see why that superstition was to lodge in his mind.
- 3.45** Fascinating. Now, this question might get me into a bit of trouble, but is it true that Napoleon requested that Josephine be unwashed for a couple of days before returning?
- 3.46** Yes, I'm afraid it was. Let's move on to the next question.

- 3.47 Not a problem.
- 3.48 Just solely because I'm not sure that great leadership requires anything to do with this. Thank you, Vincent.
- 3.49 No problem. Well, maybe we can talk about your books for a second, particularly one book on Napoleon that sold over 500,000 copies.
- 3.50 I'm glad you got that right.
- 3.51 Absolutely. Happy to do so. Now, why do you think that today we are still so fascinated by Napoleon?
- 3.52 I think it probably is because of his charisma. He clearly had a huge amount of charisma. Charisma doesn't die with you. It carries on. We love the extraordinary story, the ups and downs, the Josephine story, the fact that he came from an island, was exiled to an island, died on an island. He was a person who people wrote about. He had a great number of admirers, Hegel included, for example. He was an intellectual, proper intellectual. He became a member of the Académie Française on the basis of his intellect as much as anything he was doing as a statesman or politician.
- 3.53 And yet at the same time, he was this great soldier. I think he was a master of iconography, the hats, the David painting of him crossing the Alps, the way in which he presented himself as essentially a Roman Emperor, as you say, with his hand in his toga. You have all of that, and you have these things that still last as a result of his lawgiving, the list of which I gave earlier. So, yes, there's just so much about the Napoleon story that is still fascinating to people today.
- 3.54 On this particular line of how we view Napoleon today, how do you think the French view Napoleon, the current French?
- 3.55 Well, he has a—it very much depends where you are politically on the map, on the French political map, with the way in which you see Napoleon. On the right, they see him as a national leader, as a great conqueror, as somebody who extended liberté, égalité, fraternité, and meritocracy, and so on across Europe. On the left, they see a much darker side of Napoleon, which is undoubtedly there. The Code Napoleon was profoundly sexist. It kept women in thrall to their husbands and fathers for their lifetimes. He was—the French didn't give women the vote until 1946. It really is a society that is tremendously different from what was going on in the English-speaking peoples at the time. He also, of course, reintroduced slavery to Haiti at the time of the victory over the Haitian uprising. Now, he abolished slavery as well in 1815 when he came back from Elba. But that whole colonial period of French First Empire history is a particularly unpleasant and vicious one. So as far as the French are concerned, there's a political divide when it comes to Napoleon.

- 3.56** Now, just keeping on the Napoleon in contemporary, you're no doubt one of the most impressive historians of Napoleon. I'm wondering if you have any views on the Napoleon movie, the recent one that was put out, and historical accuracy of the movie.
- 3.57** Yes, it's 3 hours, 27 minutes, I think, in all, that movie, of which 27 minutes are historically accurate. The military side is fun to watch, undoubtedly. I mean, the whole thing is fun to watch, the uniforms and the beautiful dresses and the palaces, and there are some set-piece battle scenes that are good fun to watch. But one never really understands why on Earth anyone would ever follow Napoleon, considering what sort of brooding, ill-tempered chap he is, as played by Joachim Phoenix. Also, the military side has things like Napoleon leading cavalry charges at the Battle of Waterloo and firing at the Pyramids. It has exploding cannon balls, for example, in various battles which didn't exist at the time. It's difficult, at least for an historian like me, to enjoy a show. My wife has vowed never to go to a history movie with me ever again, because all I do is go [inaudible], "Oh, no, no, no."
- 3.58** I've written a bit about the inaccuracies, which did rather spoil it for me, as did the hilariously terrible screenplay. But I just think that, if I'd been given \$300 million to make a movie, one of the things I'd have done is to hire a historical consultant, which Ridley Scott clearly didn't do. In fact, he actually hates historians. He said in an interview, "Effing historians, what do they know? They weren't there," which is, of course, true. We weren't there, but hundreds of people were there at Napoleon's career who wrote about it, who you can read.
- 3.59** Now, one of the themes that we don't really touch on, you may have touched on it in a previous question from an audience member, was the role of secondary figures within the inner circle of a great leader. One of the things that's really impressive about Napoleon was his mastery of logistics and record-keeping. Could you speak to his chief of staff?
- 3.60** Yes. Alexandre Berthier was one of the great chiefs of staff of history. Everybody admired him enormously. He had an absolute steel-trap mind, a great brain for where all of the troops were throughout the empire. He also had a very good filing system explaining, that made sure that he was right. They would be going along on a road in the Emperor's carriage, and Berthier would be writing out orders and handing them through the window to the aide de camp who would grab them at the gallop, grab them and take them off to wherever they needed to go. It was an incredibly efficient organization, and it only came to an end in 1815, when Berthier either fell out of the window or was pushed out of the window or possibly committed suicide. We still don't know which, but he wasn't there, therefore, at the time of the Battle of Waterloo, and he was desperately needed as chief of staff.
- 3.61** But to pick up on that whole aspect of the entourage, he was a good picker of men, Napoleon. He was able to choose these 26 marshals, apart from anything else, of whom at least 20 were really proficient soldiers, actually maybe more than that. He had

somebody called Cambacérès who was the person who ran France when he was on campaign. Actually, this guy was a homosexual. It's easy to assume that everybody back in earlier years were bigoted against homosexuality. For Napoleon, that didn't matter in the slightest. He was an absolutely superb Arch-Chancellor, and this guy ran France, essentially, when Napoleon wasn't in Paris. There were other important members of the entourage who were very successful and very impressive. However, what he tended to do was to appoint his brothers and sisters to important roles, almost all of whom were complete morons, and sometimes traitors as well as morons. It was a great tragedy, really, that he appointed brother after brother to throne after throne, who then either turned against him or turned out to be completely incompetent, when he could have actually put in other members of his entourage. But he ultimately trusted, or thought he could trust, his family more than anybody else.

- 3.62** Now, we have just spoken about his entourage. Can we speak a bit about his rivals, particularly the Duke of Wellington?
- 3.63** Yes. He only fought one battle against the Duke of Wellington, Waterloo. Wellington was fighting in the peninsula for most of the Napoleonic Wars until 1815, when he fights his one battle against Napoleon. But it turns out that all the battles that he fought in the Napoleonic Wars were tremendously good preparation for coming up against Napoleon at Waterloo. They had a bit in common. They were both born on islands, of course. They both came from the aristocracy. They both had lots of brothers and sisters. Their brothers helped them in early years. They were born in the same year. They had a little bit in common. But when it came to defensive maneuvering, Wellington was an absolutely genius strategist. That's what the Battle of Waterloo is all about, is a highly impressive and intelligent defense.
- 3.64** Now, you're noted as saying, well, in fact, it's been well documented that Napoleon slept for four hours a night. I wonder if you can speak about the day in the life of Napoleon, what he got up to on a daily basis?
- 3.65** Yes, well, he would have cat naps occasionally. He also loved long, hot baths where he would have the newspapers read to him and he would send out dispatches and so on from his bath. He had that in common with Churchill, who also used to dictate through the door to his secretaries when he was having a bath. He hated missing any part of the day that, where he could work, essentially. He hated eating for more than a quarter of an hour per meal. He would have—it was very un-French, if you think. Imagine, you could eat or drink anything you like, and he had the whole thing wrapped up in a quarter of an hour. What's the point of being an Emperor of France? He would have spits where chickens were being roasted all the way through the day, 24 hours a day. Whenever he was hungry, he would just have a chicken brought to him and eat it and carry on working because work was the thing.
- 3.66** He was putting in 16 hours a day, working weekends the entire time. He had four secretaries who each worked for six-hour sessions, and they would take over to take his

dictation. He wrote 33,000 letters. Well, he sent—33,000 letters have been published. He might well have written a few more. But this man was an absolute total workaholic. You had to be, in a sense, to run an empire of that size, pretty much the whole of Europe, for well over a decade.

- 3.67** Now, I want to come to the final question of this session, this being the capstone question. It's with regards to the greatest lesson we could take away from Napoleon and his life.
- 3.68** Appeal to history. Appeal to electrify the men's souls, as he put it. Try to make your followers appreciate and understand that they're not just living out their own quotidian lives, but actually contributing to something that is greater than them and which will be spoken about for hundreds of years after they die. That's what Napoleon managed to do. Of course, as you said earlier about books and films and so on, he was right.
- 3.69** Fantastic. Why don't we take it to the audience now for questions?
- 3.70** Hi, Dr. Roberts. One of the interesting periods of the Napoleonic Wars that I'm fascinated by is his reign and rule over Spain, and, let's say, to put it mildly, the difficulties of that. In your book on Napoleon, you mentioned one of the reasons for him having invaded Spain in the first place was to recover some of the navy that he lost at a battle of Trafalgar. Could you speak to both the impact of the Battle of Trafalgar—the fact that he lost the entire French Navy, essentially—and then broadly, the role that the absence of the Navy played, generally in his defeat and in his strategy across the continent?
- 3.71** Yes, you're quite right. The Spanish, what he called, or at least what was called the Spanish Ulcer, was one of the things that led to his downfall and the loss of the quarter of a million men in Spain. He essentially invaded Spain after the invasion of Portugal in order to put his brother Joseph on the throne of Spain, which, as I mentioned about his brothers, was a disastrous move because his brother was a useless king of Spain. It's interesting how, despite being born on an island, he didn't really have an advanced sense of the sea, of what ships could do and couldn't do. He never really mastered the difference between leeward and windward, for example. He expected his admirals to be able to fight anywhere and take on the Royal Navy and defeat it and so on, which proved to be impossible. He was always asking too much of the Navy, at the same time as often taking guns off naval ships and using them on land, which also, of course, made the French Navy's job more difficult.
- 3.72** The Battle of Trafalgar, which, of course, we're going to be talking about in the Nelson session a great deal, was a complete disaster for the French. But of course, they were a land-based empire, apart from the expedition to Egypt. Essentially, the Napoleonic Empire was a European land-based empire, and it was the British who controlled the seas. It's been nicknamed "the war of the whale against the wolf," because the whale and the wolf never get a chance, really, to engage with one another until Waterloo,

when Napoleon and Wellington come together for their one battle. Napoleon, it's thought, saw Wellington through his telescope, but that's the closest they got. And of course, Wellington won. So you have this sense of the —I've been looking down at the concept of destiny a little bit already in this series, but that is the moment of destiny, where you bring these two commanders together for the one and only battle that they fight against each other.

- 3.73** Listening to his everyday life, I was thinking about how he would be as a father. It comes to my mind, seeing all these great leaders, and I cannot but wonder, their children, were they great leaders? And do we know of any children who are great leaders of great leaders? And if so, and if not, why is that?
- 3.74** He was a loving father to the king of Rome, but he died when the king of Rome was 11 years old, and he hadn't had much of a chance to see him anyway because the king of Rome had been taken away from him when he was four years old, when Napoleon went to Elba. He had some illegitimate children as well, by these various mistresses that I mentioned earlier. And one of them, actually, Alexandre Walewski, became the Foreign Minister of France under Napoleon III, who was Napoleon's nephew. But I wouldn't call him a great leader. I think he was also Foreign Secretary of France as well. So he was as good a father as he could be. With regard to fathers and sons, it is a very interesting thing. In a sense, of course, Churchill had a great father. Lord Randolph Churchill was a very successful British politician. He became Chancellor of the Exchequer. We'll probably be talking about him later on. But that is an example of somebody who manages to survive the terrible incubus of having successful parents. But otherwise, you're right. He very much is the exception that proves the rule.
- 3.75** What do you think motivates leaders and the great leaders that you talked about, and to what extent do you think an idea of legacy or a quest for immortality is behind that?
- 3.76** Yes, I think it very much is. I think the sense that you want to be remembered for all time. Julius Caesar would be very happy to know that we're sitting here 2,068 years after his death, still talking about him. It's a drive for immortality that is there for a lot of them. Also, of course, Napoleon wanted to make France great again. Nelson wanted to save his country from invasion. Marshall and Eisenhower wanted to extirpate Nazism from the European continent and the human soul. There are lots of good, proper, upstanding reasons why these people want greatness. Napoleon wanted to extend the advantages of the French Revolution right the way across Europe. But ultimately, the drive comes from inside.
- 3.77** Hello, Dr. Roberts. Building on the previous question before here, there's an idea that you're not fully mature until you have a child and care for a child. What is the impact of having children, caring for children, on a leader like Napoleon or other leaders?
- 3.78** Well, I would take exception with the idea of not being fully mature until you've had a child. My wife is very mature, for example, but she hasn't had a child. I think that the

way in which some people do try to hand on their legacies to their children, the classic example being Napoleon, who actually divorced this lady luck figure in Josephine and tried to establish his dynasty with the Arch-Duchess, was a very important political moment, of course, for Europe. It was something that he believed would bring the Austrians into an alliance for all time. But as it was, it only lasted two years. Because ultimately, the retreat from Moscow, which killed, as we mentioned, around 400,000 men of the Grande Armée, was a much more important fact in European history than who's married to who.

Lecture 4: Nelson's Navigation

At a glance — Horatio Nelson and the qualities of naval leadership.

- 4.1 Now, Andrew, beginning with this fourth session, we're going to be speaking about Horatio Nelson, and I just want to speak now on the essence of his leadership technique. Can we talk about that?
- 4.2 Yes, it was essentially huge amounts of aggression. Annihilation was what he was after in his battles. In order to do that, he recognized the importance of always retaining the initiative. Because in battle, the enemy always has a say. In any moving entity like a battle, you have to take into account what the enemy is doing. What Nelson needed to do, wanted to do, succeeded in doing in many of his battles, was just to close down the enemy's options when it came to counterattack. You see this again and again. You can fight a war of annihilation, essentially—which is what the Battle of Trafalgar is all about, and some other earlier battles, like the Battle of the Nile—at sea, in the Napoleonic period, much more easily than on the ground, because in a normal military campaign on land, you are able to withdraw.
- 4.3 A classic example being the Battle of Wagram, where the Austrians withdrew in very good order off the battlefield in a way that Napoleon wasn't able to chase them. At sea, on the other hand, you can sink a ship and thereby drown everybody on board. Or if you capture a ship, you capture absolutely everybody there. So the chance of withdrawing from the battlefield, unless you're actually just going to sail away as fast as possible, and even when that's attempted, sometimes Nelson had frigates that could outmaneuver and chase. So you're having a—instead of fighting a battle that can go 75% , 25%, actually at sea, it's 100%. Therefore, Nelson was able to, and always wanted to, absolutely annihilate the enemy in a way that was very often much more difficult in land warfare at the time.
- 4.4 Now, would you say that this aggression that characterized Nelson was also a character shared by his contemporaries and other military leaders at the time?
- 4.5 They tried it, of course, absolutely. I mean, as a naval captain, you were expected to sink or capture the vessel you were fighting against, but they didn't always succeed. The thing about Nelson was that he was just an absolute predator when it came to naval warfare.
- 4.6 Now, what bred this predatory nature on Nelson's part? What was his childhood like?
- 4.7 Well, he went to sea at the age of 12, which is tremendously young, of course. He became a midshipman at 12 years old. He was born actually in the same year as, sorry, the year before Napoleon and Wellington. So he was much the same kind of contemporary. But he started in the Navy much earlier than they started in the army. And he didn't get a bad education. He was on board ship, of course. He didn't have a

series of teachers, but he was an autodidact, which is a very important aspect, actually, to leadership. Teaching yourself is very often a more effective way of learning than being taught at university, for example. Winston Churchill is the classic example of this. He didn't go to university. He was entirely self-taught. I like to say that he had to be self-taught because he went to Harrow. People who are self-taught, like Nelson and Churchill and many others, have a drive to them, a drive to their acquisition, their need for knowledge, their acquisition of knowledge, which is set apart from other people who go to more conventional educational backgrounds, and therefore, essentially, their essays are marked by other people rather than themselves.

- 4.8 Now, on this point on education, how important is a good education in becoming a great leader?
- 4.9 It's less important than you'd imagine. Some people do. Pericles had a very fine education. As we learned, he learned philosophy from Anaxagoras. Caesar, of course, had his rhetoric that was taught to him by the Greeks. But Churchill taught himself as a young subaltern up on the northwest frontier, never went to university. Margaret Thatcher went to Oxford, but she read chemistry rather than any of the leaders of the past used to read, like the classics and so on. It's useful but not absolutely essential, so long as the leader knows how to learn and has the impetus and the desire and the drive to learn, especially, of course, from the past.
- 4.10 Can we move now to Nelson's self-realization moment? What was this exactly?
- 4.11 This was at San Juan. You remember how I said that it very often happens in your 20s? He was 21 when he was placed in charge of an expedition up the San Juan River in South America, and he had to capture the fort and hold it. He had to hold it, I think in the end, it turned out for months before he was relieved. It was a classic adventure story, basically. Things that could go wrong, with the men getting malaria and the Spanish counterattacking and the town having to be besieged and all that thing, showed his capacities, even as young an age as 21, and he was victorious there, and he came away recognizing that he had this capacity for greatness.
- 4.12 Right. So this notion of a realization of a capacity for greatness, is this something that you would say that is inherent to many great leaders?
- 4.13 Well, the self-realization when they show it, yes. But there certainly has to be the moment where they have done something special, something that their contemporaries might not have been able to have done, something like the capture of the Bridge at Lodi that Napoleon pulled off, or the escape from the prisoner-of-war camp that Churchill undertook, or Caesar getting the Civil Crown. There has to be something that marks them out, that shows that they are impressive vis-à-vis their contemporaries. And as I say, this very often happens in their early- to mid-twenties.

- 4.14 Interesting. Now, thinking about naval warfare, you've mentioned the gritty nature, or at least you've intimated the gritty nature of naval warfare in that period. Could you describe the nature of naval warfare during Nelson's period?
- 4.15 What it was like to be in a battle, you mean?
- 4.16 Absolutely.
- 4.17 Yeah, horrific. Utterly horrific. It would be hell on Earth. Because what happens is essentially you're in a wooden container that's floating, and it is loaded down with huge amounts of gunpowder and also cannon, many more cannon than are found on battlefields. The statistics are pretty extraordinary, really, because when one thinks, at the Battle of Waterloo, which was about five miles wide, it's four miles wide, I'd say, and a mile deep on either side, you have 256 guns that Napoleon had and 152 that Wellington had. You add those together. Then at the Battle of Trafalgar, which is fought over much the same geographical area, you have 2,600 guns that the French and Spanish combined fleets have, and 2,100 British guns. There are literally over 12 times more pieces of ordnance, things that can kill you, essentially, in the same space. You have a six-pound cannon ball is about that big, 12-pound about that big, 24 pounds big enough to actually take down a mast of a ship. Plus, of course, you've got grapeshot for if you attempt to actually board a ship. Those can be used from what are called carronades that can be wheeled around on the deck.
- 4.18 So, I mean, these are horrifically awful things just with regard to the shot. You also, of course, have sharpshooters up in the rigging of the enemy ships, and you have splinters. And so a shot that hits the side of a ship will send splinters, sometimes that's six foot long, swirling around inside the decks. So the people who are fighting, who are trying to man the guns, sometimes up to eight people per gun, will be hit by flying splinters that can very easily kill you, even if you're not actually hit by shot and shell, which is why on ships like Nelson's ship, the HMS Victory, the floors were all painted red so that the blood wouldn't show because there was so much blood that can be expected in a naval battle. So you needed unbelievable guts, frankly, to fight in one of those battles. But again, once you're on a ship, you have no alternative. There's no chance of running away. And also, just to make things even worse, sailors in those days, most of them couldn't swim. So if your ship sank, the best thing you could do was to hang on to a piece of the flotsam and jetsam, otherwise you drowned.
- 4.19 Perhaps to contextualize this in a modern setting with relation to the brutality of naval warfare during that period, is there any form of combat today, or maybe in the last 100 years, that is similar?
- 4.20 Well, naval battles in the last 100 years, the Battle of Jutland was a terrible thing to be involved in. If you got a direct hit from a shell at the Battle of Jutland, it would be monstrous. In the Falklands, of course, people were killed and drowned. You have people catching fishing fire in the Battle of the Atlantic. If you were on an oil cargo

vessel, if you fought in the battle up on the Arctic convoys, of course, and hit the water, you were dead within a minute. So, yes, naval warfare is something that requires unbelievable guts, frankly.

- 4.21 Now, on this point of having guts and the brutality of naval warfare, was Nelson unscathed by his affairs of being a member of the naval service?
- 4.22 He was highly scathed. Yes, he lost an eye and an arm. Absolutely. He felt that, therefore, he wasn't going to be preferred in the admiralty. He writes about this, saying, "What use is the admiralty going to have for a sailor with only one eye and one arm?" But of course, it didn't harm him in the slightest. He didn't continue with the boarding of vessels. But to all intents and purposes, it didn't hold him back at all. If anything, it proved, as we've mentioned before, when it comes to leadership, that he was willing to go into harm's way, that he was willing to take risks alongside his men. That was very obvious from the fact that he only had one eye and one arm as a result of his wounds. But by the time he had been wounded so devastatingly, he was, of course, in that officer's position where it was strategy and the tactics of the battle, and that he wasn't actually personally required to jump onto enemy ships and fight.
- 4.23 It's safe to say that his physical disabilities, if we can call it that, were not a hindrance to his leadership capabilities?
- 4.24 Not at all.
- 4.25 It maybe even accentuated it.
- 4.26 It might have helped him in that it did prove to everybody. I mean, he was beloved in the naval service, absolutely beloved. I think one of the things was that they recognized that he had made these profound physical sacrifices in fighting alongside his men.
- 4.27 Now, can you think of any other historical leaders that have had physical disabilities that they've had to deal with as a leader?
- 4.28 None of them, of course, are as onerous as to lose an eye and an arm. General Kutuzov, who we mentioned earlier, the Russian commander in the 1812 campaign, had lost an eye fighting the Turks many years earlier. You did tend to have some of those, but they are massive personal setbacks. And great leaders do have to overcome setbacks, not just physical ones like Nelson. But you have, well, Stalin was exiled to Siberia. Churchill, as we heard earlier, was made a prisoner of war. Charles de Gaulle was made a prisoner of war twice in the First World War. There are other setbacks that you can name. I suppose, Winston Churchill, as an orator, had a lisp, of course, which he got over in his youth. But having terrible things happen to you is part and parcel of great leadership, if you're capable of overcoming them.
- 4.29 Obviously, there was a large deal of bigotry, male chauvinism, against Margaret Thatcher when she was starting out in politics. The capacity to turn what seems to be a weakness into a strength, which is what Margaret Thatcher did eventually manage to

do, is in and of itself an attribute of leadership. The key thing is not that you've suffered a setback, as it were. The key thing is the way in which you respond to it and try to turn it into a strength. You see that again and again in these various leaders. There was a moment when Sulla, the Roman dictator, threatened to exile Julius Caesar, and he managed to escape exile. But it was a massive setback to his career at the time.

4.30 Now, when thinking about Nelson, can you list the battles he was in? And of course, the Battle of Trafalgar being maybe his most famous?

4.31 No, I can't really list them. I can mention two or three of the really great ones because there are very many of them. But the Battle of Copenhagen in 1807 was a very important one. Britain had allied with Denmark, and Napoleon invaded Denmark because of that. The key thing was to try to save the Danish fleet from falling into the hands of the French. But that proved to be impossible, so we had to try and sink the Danish fleet. It required a very tough engagement in the course of which the British Commander, Sir John Jervis, later Earl of St. Vincent, ordered Nelson to break off the engagement. And Nelson deliberately, it's said by putting his telescope to his blind eye, but I think that there might be a certain amount of apocryphal exaggeration to that story, but nonetheless, claimed that he couldn't see the signal.

4.32 Now, these signals are massive. They go right the way around the ship. They are made of different colored flags, which can be seen a long way off. And so it's not possible, really, to believe Nelson's story about this. But nonetheless, because he didn't break off the engagement, the British won the battle. There's a long history of insubordination, of course, especially with regard to great leaders. We mentioned the one about Mithridates, king of Pontus, and Julius Caesar. But essentially, the truth about insubordination is that it's only ever forgiven if it comes off. If it's successful, then people are willing to turn a blind eye to the insubordination. If not, you're in terrible trouble. That makes sense, doesn't it?

4.33 Absolutely. Now, thinking about the wars or the naval battles waged by the British Navy at that point in time, why was it the case that the British Navy was superior to the navies of other nations?

4.34 Partly, it was just spending. The British were spending something like 40% of GDP on the Royal Navy alone. A totally extraordinary thing, considering how little GDP we're spending on the Royal Navy today. It was, in that sense, the senior service where money was thrown at it because, of course, we were under existential threat of invasion. Napoleon had an army of well over half a million men placed in seven major camps on the Channel coast, hoping to invade from 1803 to 1805. It was money well spent in that sense. But also the training was far better, because the Navy was constantly at sea, bottling up the French Navy in their ports. It was at sea 24 hours a day, and therefore the men had much better chance to train. We were able to fire off broadsides twice as fast. We could fire three broadsides in the same space that a

French ship could fire off two. So, there's a real sense that that is, obviously, in a battle, the key thing is how often you're able to fire off accurate broadsides.

4.35 And also, there was a sort of tradition, a morale, a sense of superiority, that the Royal Navy had at that time. Their leadership as well, not just St. Vincent, who I mentioned earlier, and Nelson, but a whole series, a whole slew of admirals, were highly competitive with one another. There was a great rivalry amongst them. And so, they all wanted to be the next Nelson, as it were.

4.36 I'm glad you brought up the Earl of St. Vincent. We talk about him as it relates to Nelson. So the Earl of St. Vincent was noted as saying that Nelson had a sort of animal courage, and it was noted that Nelson knew no fear. Is that true?

4.37 Well, he certainly had an animal courage. Actually, in the rest of that quotation, in fact, it's not very nice about Nelson. He said that the man had no moral character, which we'll probably come on to in a second, about his personal predilections. But it's certainly true that he knew no fear. This is very common amongst great commanders. Not to know no fear whatsoever, that's very rare, in fact. But to have immense personal courage is seen again and again. By the way, courage is not a morally good thing automatically under all circumstances. Hermann Göring was a very courageous pilot in the First World War, for example. It doesn't make him a good person. It's a bravery you can see again and again in history as being a morally neutral concept. It's a wonderful thing to have, of course, but it doesn't make you a better person.

4.38 Is there anyone or any leader you can think of in history that knew no fear? Legitimately was a wild man, in essence?

4.39 Well, that is really Nelson. That's the thing that one sees in Nelson. I mean, Nelson had this concept of the war of annihilation and the constant aggression. You do see it in certain other leaders, General Patton in the Second World War, for example. Some people ascribe it to General Custer, obviously with far less happy outcome, ultimately. But they're not always the people you want to follow, people who know no fear, because they will sometimes, of course, take on enemies who they jolly well ought to fear.

4.40 Given this aggressive nature and the perception of Nelson having this aggressive nature, is it safe to say that he had a death wish? Is that true?

4.41 It's claimed by historians, absolutely. The basis of it is his actions on the morning of the 21st of October 1805, the morning of the Battle of Trafalgar, because he writes letters that very much seem to be goodbye letters, certainly to his mistress, Emma Hamilton. He then dons all four of the stars that he's been awarded, orders and decoration and so on. So he puts on every medal he's got. It looks like a Christmas tree by the time he steps out onto the deck. And that in itself, especially when his rigging, the rigging of HMS Victory, becomes entangled with the rigging of the French flagship, Redoutable, becomes an extremely dangerous place to walk along the deck with all these orders

and decoration. It's almost grabbing the attention of the sharpshooters that are placed in the masts of the French vessel.

- 4.42 I myself don't think that he wanted to die. I think that the reason that he was decking himself out was because he thought it would be good for the morale of his troops to see him there and to appreciate all the public acclaim and the honors and declarations he'd been given because he had been a successful sailor. It's a way of, yes, drawing attention to yourself, but not in such a way that you also want to draw the attention of a bullet.
- 4.43 Now, in that bit there, you spoke a little bit about the Lady Emma Hamilton. Could you speak more about the predilections of Horatio Nelson?
- 4.44 Well, unlike the 27 mistresses of Napoleon, he fell head over heels in love with this immensely beautiful woman. If you want to know how beautiful, you only, when next you're in New York, go to the Frick Gallery there and that wonderful museum, which has the George Romney of the, I think, 21-year-old Lady Hamilton. She's an absolute gorgeous woman. She was a good friend of Queen Caroline of Naples, Maria Carolina, not Caroline Bonaparte, obviously, and was a useful person to him politically because of that. But she was also a huge distraction to him. I mean, he's writing to her constantly, but somebody who he genuinely loved. If you're looking for a real love story, I think it's the equivalent, really, of Napoleon and Josephine.
- 4.45 Now, is there a general that is comparable to Nelson?
- 4.46 Well, I mentioned Patton. I think George Patton has the same killer instinct, the same predator drive, a desire for annihilation. We're going to be talking about him, I'm sure, a bit with President Eisenhower. But there is, in Patton, that sense of aggression. I recently wrote a book with General David Petraeus, the commander of coalition forces in Iraq and Afghanistan. He said that one of the orders that he put out during those wars was, "In the absence of orders, work out what they should have been and then pursue them aggressively." That's a great order, really. It's something that Nelson would automatically have appreciated because, of course, when he wasn't able, when he's in charge of 27 ships at the Battle of Trafalgar, he's not able to give orders to any of the other captains of the ships. He can give general orders by the flags that we mentioned earlier, but can't tell individual captains what to do. But through his, essentially, his *auctoritas*, the authority that we mentioned earlier, through his charisma, through the meeting he has a few days before the Battle of Trafalgar, he's able to tell his senior officers, the captains of the ships, that the thing to do is to work out what you should have been ordered and then carry it out aggressively.
- 4.47 How did Nelson view the war with the French?
- 4.48 Through a very powerful ideological lens. He hated the French Revolution, everything it stood for. He was a believer in the British Constitution, of course, and his father was a vicar in Norfolk, and Nelson was a believer, a Christian believer. So he hated the

atheistical side of the French Revolution, who had abolished Christianity by law and had closed down the Catholic Church and so on. In that sense, he hated what was going on. Plus, he was an English patriot who thought it was part of an Englishman's duty to sink French ships. So all three things came together, political, religious, and patriotic, should we say, or nationalistic, at least, to create somebody who really hated the French.

- 4.49 Now, the thing that stands out about Nelson, as well as all the leaders that we've already touched on, is this ability to inspire others. And Nelson was, of course, incredibly popular amongst his men. There's a term that's often bandied about—the Nelson touch. Could you talk about that?
- 4.50 Yes, the Nelson touch essentially means charisma. The term comes from that meeting that I mentioned earlier, a few days before the Battle of Trafalgar, where the captains of the ships come together, and he starts to speak to them. From the memoirs of one of them, he says that, essentially, that a feeling entered the room of such power that they recognized they turned into a band of brothers. That's the phrase, I think, that was used in the letter. And that, obviously, a quotation from Shakespeare, but nonetheless, it was what he felt, and that an almost ethereal sense of togetherness and purpose entered the hearts of all the 27 captains at the meeting. So you have this sense of the Nelson touch. Of course, Nelson dies a few days later with great heroism, saying, "Thank God I've done my duty," his last words. But the Nelson touch, the concept of the Nelson touch, continues, and you have people refer to it even as late as the First World War. Admirals like Beatty and Jellicoe, they talk about and they think about the Nelson touch.
- 4.51 Was Nelson inspired by any leader prior to him?
- 4.52 Well, yes, he was inspired by other naval commanders, especially the ones who had been victorious in the Seven Years' War. He was only five when the Seven Years' War broke out. Fifteen, therefore, obviously, when it ended. Sorry, 12 when it ended. He had this sense of looking up to the great leaders of the past. He served out on the West Indies squadron at the time of the American War of Independence, when there was a great fear that Britain might lose its Caribbean colonies to the French. He could see those successful leaders there. As I say, he was an autodidact, as well as receiving a perfectly reasonably good education as a midshipman. He was a reader of history. So many of these great leaders are readers of history. I mentioned Napoleon Bonaparte, essentially, growing up in a library, reading about Alexander the Great and Julius Caesar. Winston Churchill did as well. In fact, none of these leaders who we're going to be talking about just took no notice of history. They all tried to learn from history. They saw themselves in many cases as analogous to historical figures of the past.
- 4.53 Now, a line of inquiry here that we've touched on in the past three sessions was, again, on ruthlessness. Was Horatio Nelson ruthless?

- 4.54 He was, yes. In 1799, actually the same year that Napoleon was undertaking that terrible act of ruthlessness, killing the Turkish artillerymen in Jaffa, Nelson was in Naples, and he put down a Jacobin uprising in Naples of extreme pro-French Revolutionary rebels, essentially, who were attempting to overthrow the Bourbons of Naples. He captured 300 of them and hanged them. Hanged them, actually, from the yardarm of, many of them, of his own ships, including an Italian admiral. Actually, I once lectured on Nelson in the New York Historical Society, and a descendant of that admiral came up after me to remonstrate that I hadn't been harsher on Nelson for having done this to his ancestor, with some reason, I have to say, because it was a pretty tough thing to have done. Now, these people had been found guilty by the Neapolitan courts, by the Bourbons. But nonetheless, for the British to carry out such a wholesale hanging of rebels was something akin to a war crime.
- 4.55 Now, we've spoken about the Earl of St. Vincent's opinion of Nelson, at least a small bit of it. What were the views of Nelson's contemporaries of Nelson? Or maybe stated differently, his peers, rather than his contemporaries?
- 4.56 Well, his peers started off —a lot of them started off quite doubtful about him because he was very egotistical. Many of them thought he was boastful. The King, King George III, thought his character was most disgraceful because of his infidelity to Lady Nelson. But they all came round, some of them after the Battle of Copenhagen, a lot after his victory in the Nile. What he essentially did at the Battle of the Nile, also sometimes known as the Battle of Aboukir Bay, was to sink Napoleon's fleet, the fleet that had taken him from Toulon to Alexandria, and which Napoleon obviously wanted to be able to take the army back from Alexandria to Toulon. Well, that wasn't going to happen, owing to the fact that Nelson, through an absolutely brilliant maneuver, managed to get a portion of his fleet in between the French fleet and the coast, the Egyptian coast, whilst the rest of the fleet, the two-thirds, came in from the seaward to place itself beside the French. Essentially, what happened is he got on both sides of the French navy and sank it.
- 4.57 In fact, funny enough, in the Alexandria Museum and in the Cairo Museum, you can see swords and musket balls and anchors and so on. They've been doing an extensive marine archeological dig, essentially pulling up bits and pieces from the battle. It's wonderful to see muskets and so on. That brought over an awful lot of people, as you can imagine, to Nelson. He became a peer of the realm as a result of the Battle of the Nile. Then, of course, you have, there are other engagements. You then have Trafalgar, where he dies at the height of the victory. One of the captains comes to tell him that he has actually completely destroyed the Franco-Spanish fleet. He dies with almost a halo of national greatness. Then we stick a 143-foot column statue up in the middle of London in 1843. So yes, as far as his reputation today is concerned, it really could hardly be higher. The Royal Navy celebrates its Trafalgar Night on the 21st of October every year, and he stands out as by far and away our greatest naval hero.

- 4.58 Excellent. Now, we've spoken about the mixed nature of the views that his peers had of him and the fact that he was loved by his men. What were the views of Britons during that period, the common man?
- 4.59 Again, absolute hero worship once he'd won the battle with the Nile. Then after he dies at Trafalgar, you have all of the panoply of hero worship, the porcelain mugs, the glasses that have his inscriptions on, the medals and commemorative pottery and ballads that are sung and so on. You name it. Books about his death have printed that explain exactly the whole chronology of the battle. There are some things that are still immensely moving for an Englishman, at least, where the moment comes as battle is about to be drawn.
- 4.60 Pasco, his flag officer, asked whether or not he'd like to send a general message to the fleet. Nelson writes, "England confides that every man will do his duty." Pasco says, "The word confides would have to be spelt out. Would it be possible instead to say expect?" And in flags, of course, spelt out letter for letter. Nelson says, "Yes, that's fine. Rig it up as quickly as possible." And so the HMS Victory goes into battle with these flags telling the entire fleet. And it's not just flag officers who are able to read flags. Obviously, a lot of the men can as well. And then when they are decoded, they are called out to a ship's companies. So every man going into the Battle of Trafalgar knew that Lord Nelson was ordering them to do their duty. I don't know, I'm getting a tingle down my spine right now even telling you about it, really.
- 4.61 In the last session, we spoke about how Napoleon is viewed by the modern French. What about Nelson? How is he viewed by the general public today in Britain?
- 4.62 There is a bit of a mixed stance because he did not oppose slavery when he was in the House of Lords. He died, of course, in 1805, and slavery was abolished in 1807. Or at least the slave trade was abolished in 1807. Slavery itself across the colonies wasn't abolished until 1831. But long after his death. But he hadn't been a proponent of abolition, which has led one historian to call for his column to be pulled down in Trafalgar Square, which just shows how wide our views of history is in Britain today. But otherwise, he's still recognized as somebody who saved his country from invasion. Had we lost the Battle of Trafalgar, there would have been a guillotine going up in Trafalgar Square or whatever it was called at the time. It obviously wasn't called Trafalgar Square at the time, rather than that column.
- 4.63 We do recognize that there have, historically, been a series of attempts to invade this country. We think of the Spanish Armada in 1588. We think of the—actually, there was a pretty serious attempt in the 1780s. There was Napoleon's army, of course, at the Boulogne and elsewhere in 1803 to 1805, ended by the Battle of Trafalgar and Austerlitz as well. There was a pretty serious attempt in 1940 as well. You have this long panoply of invasion threats against Britain. It's only natural that we should consider somebody who saves the country to be one of our greatest heroes.

- 4.64 Now, you've called this particular session "Horatio Nelson: The Retention of the Initiative." Why name it that?
- 4.65 Because that's what he does. He retains the initiative at the Battle of Copenhagen. He doesn't break off the engagement, even though he's under direct orders from his commander-in-chief to do so. At the Battle of Aboukir Bay, the Nile, he doesn't allow the French who were at anchor to escape. The initiative has to remain with him. He goes on either side of them. At the Battle of Trafalgar, he undertakes a fairly risky maneuver, which is to split his force into two parallel attacking lines and break the combined fleet, breaking it off into three sections which he can destroy piecemeal. In none of those, or in any other moment of his career, does he allow the enemy to recapture the initiative. That is a sign of his capacity for aggression and a sign of his desire for annihilation of the enemy. The great truism that the enemy always has a say in whatever's going on—there's a line about "everyone's got a plan until you get punched on the nose"—that is true, but it's not the case with Nelson.
- 4.66 Would Mike Tyson have been a fan of Horatio Nelson?
- 4.67 He'd have loved him.
- 4.68 Now, coming to the final question of the session here, what is the single greatest lesson we can learn from Horatio Nelson?
- 4.69 I think it's partly that. It's partly this idea of retaining the initiative. Another aspect of him is the belief in the impossible, in taking on much larger enemies. The British fleet had 27 ships of the line, including frigates and so on. But the Franco-Spanish fleet had 33, had 500 more guns and so on. So, the inherent belief that the fighting man was going to be superior, that was partly down, as I mentioned earlier, to the fact that they were able to fire three broadsides in the same time that it took the enemy to fire two. And there's a quotation from the Elder Moltke, the great Prussian strategist, who was said only to have smiled twice in his life. The first time when he heard that his mother-in-law had died, and the second time when he was told that the city of Liège was impregnable. The fact was that Moltke didn't believe anything was impossible, and neither did Horatio Nelson.
- 4.70 Outstanding. Absolutely outstanding. We can move to the audience now for questions.
- 4.71 Dr. Roberts, would you say there's a personal cost that comes with being a great leader?
- 4.72 A personal cost? Well, absolutely. I mean, in Nelson's case, of course, he lost his eye and his arm. There's a very deep personal cost, but I think you mean on a larger moral and human sense, there is, yes. Friendship is very difficult. Normal people like the idea that they are able to have friends who they can interact with naturally and normally. That's quite difficult. If you're at the absolute pinnacle of society in the way that Julius Caesar, who was murdered by his friends, or Napoleon, it's very difficult, really.

Sometimes with Winston Churchill, he had enormous problems where a friend, classic example being Bob Boothby, lets him down terribly during the Second World War, and the friendship is over, fractured and then over.

- 4.73 So, yes, there are personal costs. The family costs are usually high. There are lots of great leaders who are simply not able to put in the time necessary with their children to have a normal family life because the requirements of their time is so massive. It's undoubtedly the case that you can't live a normal life if you're a great leader, but they find different ways of getting round that. But nonetheless, there's no point in pretending that a great leader is just a normal person who happens to have an unusual job. That's not the case. It's that they are unusual people who are, who make themselves unusual on purpose in order to do a great task. Frankly, the friends and family have to take second place.
- 4.74 Thank you. So the leaders that you've talked about today, they share some obvious traits like ruthlessness and charisma, being students of history. But there are traits that you've talked about that are perhaps unexpected, and they appear to have in common as well. For example, they all appear to be romantics. Obviously, Hamilton with Nelson, Josephine with Napoleon, and I believe Julius Caesar before Cleopatra had quite a genuine soft spot for Brutus' mother. So, would you say that this is a trait that these great leaders have in common? To what degree do you think they were empowered or maybe disempowered by this trait?
- 4.75 I think that romantic is an interesting word to use for some of these people. They have a streak of romanticism to them, undoubtedly. But I'm afraid lovers are thrown to one side just as much as anybody else when it comes to the ruthless drive to succeed. Napoleon didn't listen to any of the 27 mistresses that he had. He was not affected by their views on anything at all. Winston Churchill was genuinely romantic. That's a proper love story with Clementine, as is Margaret Thatcher and Dennis Thatcher, in fact. And George Marshall's love of his wife, as well, was a very pure thing. But overall, the romantic side of these people—Stalin wrote poetry, for example. He thought of himself as being quite romantic. We wouldn't do that today in any way whatsoever. I think quite often, these are a slightly self-deluding aspects of many of these great figures.
- 4.76 Lord Roberts, thank you. To what extent is the story of leaders also the story of team building or building teams? Churchill had the paladins, Napoleon had his marshals. I just wonder what your thoughts were on that, please.
- 4.77 And of course, the Band of Brothers of Nelson. Yes, it's tremendously important. The choice, being a good chooser of talent, is central to all of this. Caesar was very good with his centurions. He was able to size up a centurion very quickly and to work out whether or not the man would come up to his standards and to promote him, if so, and to move him on to something else, if not. Yes, being able to be a good judge of character, essentially, is an important aspect of this. You see it in democratic politics, of

course, Margaret Thatcher choosing people for her cabinet and so on. They're not always proved right. Marshall Marmont betrayed Napoleon and, as we've established, Brutus murdered Caesar. But overall, to have that capacity to create a team and to give it a sense of morale and purpose is an important prerequisite. We're going to be coming onto that, I think, when we talk about General Marshall and his capacity for being able to hire and fire, essentially.

4.78 There was a mention earlier about, I think, Vincent, you asked about the death wish. There's a true story about the person who went in the carriage with Nelson from London down to Portsmouth on Nelson's final trip where he boarded HMS Victory. The man's name was Isaac Coffin, which isn't the ideal augury that you want when you're getting on board your vessel. So these people aren't, at least he was not superstitious, at least. Some were. Julius Caesar, quite superstitious. If there was any eagle in the sky, he would take that as always a very good sign. As we've heard, Pericles wasn't even put off by an eclipse. Churchill was quite superstitious in various ways. The connections between these leaders is something that I absolutely love.

4.79 I want to ask about trauma. You were talking about and depicting a beautiful depiction, which was a horrific depiction, of what was going on in the ship, and also what happened to Nelson as well. He lost his eye, he lost his arm. These traumatic events, let's say, horrific events, to be in a war where people, all these horrific events happening around you, happened to all of these great leaders. I guess it was something about them that their response to this wasn't one of resentment or something that came to the detriment. But actually, they used it as a strength. Coming from a generation where we're, I guess, we're pretty soft, what was it about them, about their character, that allowed them to transform the trauma into a strength and use that to build a legacy?

4.80 I think you're absolutely right. The horror of taking part in a Napoleonic battle, either at sea or on land, actually, must have been truly devastating. You do get examples of people suffering from essentially the early 19th-century equivalent of PTSD. Marshall Ney, who was in charge of the rear guard in the 1812 campaign, doesn't really perform terribly well after that. In fact, it's arguable that it's down to him that Napoleon lost the Battle of Waterloo. There are some people who take the opportunity to retire back to their estates and don't want to carry on fighting. But all of these great leaders are not like that. I mentioned Napoleon getting stabbed in the stomach, in the side, at Toulon. He also is wounded in the heel at the Battle of Ratisbon. They're in the front line very often. They're not leading cavalry charges as Sir Ridley Scott would have you imagine, but they are within range of a cannonball. There are marshals like Bessières who take cannonball full in the chest, killing him. Marshall Lannes is sitting cross-legged during a battle, and one of his legs is shattered, and he dies seven days later from the trauma of that. At least there's a discussion whether it's gangrene, what he dies of, or whatever it

is, he's in the front line. These guys are leading from the front. Nelson, of course, also killed.

4.81 So, yes, it is an essential feature. It comes, of course, under the general rubric of immense personal physical courage. We're going to be talking about that with regard to Winston Churchill, who fights in five campaigns on four continents. The sheer physical and emotional pressure on these people is immense. Interestingly, actually, with Hitler, although he was a runner, of course, in the, a regimental runner in the First World War, by the time of the Second World War, he is very unlike Winston Churchill, who used to go up onto the roof to watch the blitz, the roof of the Air Ministry to watch the blitz. Hitler very much stayed out of harm's way, except, of course, when the generals tried kill him. He would drive through Berlin with his—his Mercedes Benz had special curtains, so he would be able to close the curtains and not see the devastation, and his people would not see him when he was driving through Berlin. People have different responses. The response of the Führer was try to pretend it wasn't happening.

4.82 Thanks, Dr. Roberts. I was wondering, you briefly touched on how there are calls from certain quarters for re-evaluation of Nelson's status, and obviously, that's part of a broader trend in the West because of changing ascendant moral fashions in academia. I wonder if, on a related note, how important you think it is for a culture to venerate the great leaders of its past in order to facilitate the emergence of new great leaders?

4.83 That's a very good question. May I say the level of questions today has been absolutely first class. It really has been. It's one of the great pleasures of a speaker to know that one's going to be put on the spot intellectually by you lot. Thank you very much for that. The answer is, for me at least, and this might be a slightly politically incorrect argument, is that I do believe in the great men and women of history, that theory that people take decisions that really matter. I think what individuals say and do really does matter. I think that history is only, really, the agglomeration of billions of people taking decisions every day. When you look at Napoleon, for example, in 1812, France would not have invaded Russia in 1812, had it not been for Napoleon. There is a very good argument to say that Britain might not have fought on in 1940, if Winston Churchill hadn't been Prime Minister at that particular time, in the May of 1940, when there were people in his cabinet that wanted to come to a negotiated peace with Hitler then, with incalculable results and consequences for human history.

4.84 So, I think individuals do matter. The idea that history is just about the tides of socioeconomic movement and that individuals don't matter is strictly one for the determinists and the Whigs and the Marxists, but not for sensible historians. The study of the great leaders, I wouldn't be sitting where I am right now talking about this unless I believe that there is a point to trying, philosophically, to understand the relationship between the great leader and the people who are led. Also, I think that it drives us on to—if there's a moral aspect to this —because it drives us on to appreciate that the decisions that we take in life have consequences and are important. If we were all just

part of a human history where we have no control, essentially, over the fates, then why bother getting out of bed in the morning? It really is important that we recognize that we do have mastery over our fate and, therefore, are our moral agents.

Lecture 5: Churchill's Courage

At a glance — Winston Churchill, a figure Roberts has written on extensively.

- 5.1** We begin this fifth session now with Winston Churchill, a man that you've written quite a bit about. Let's begin with this first question. You subtitled your biography of Winston Churchill, "Walking With Destiny." Why?
- 5.2** It was a phrase that he used in his autobiography in his war memoirs, and he was writing about the day that he'd become Prime Minister on the 10th of May 1940, on exactly the same day, entirely coincidentally, that Adolf Hitler invaded the Low Countries. He said of that time, "I felt as if I were walking with destiny and that all my past life had been but a preparation for this hour and for this trial." What I wanted to try and do in that book was to examine that, to look at his sense of destiny, and the way in which everything he had done up until then had indeed been a preparation for being Prime Minister in the Second World War.
- 5.3** He had this driving sense of personal destiny, partly because there were so many occasions in his life when he had come very close to death. He had been born two months prematurely, which, of course, in Victorian England, could easily have been a death sentence. He very nearly died of pneumonia at the age of 11 when he was at prep school. Actually, his doctors on that occasion prescribed brandy that was to be applied both orally and rectally. You might have thought that that would put you off brandy for life, but it certainly didn't in Winston Churchill's case. He nearly died in a plane crash, two plane crashes, three car crashes. He nearly drowned in Lake Geneva. He was woken up at 3 o'clock in the morning, one morning, to find that the house he was staying with had caught fire, and he narrowly escaped death on that occasion.
- 5.4** It's a slight oversight in his career that he never actually had an assassination attempt on him, but pretty much every other thing that could have gone wrong, very nearly did. And that is, of course, all the peace time close brushes with death. In the five campaigns that he fought on four continents by the age of 40, he'd also had bullets whistle by his ear. He once said that there's nothing so exhilarating as to be shot at without result. And Churchill was shot at a great deal without result. He also took part in the last great cavalry charge of the British Empire at the Battle of Omdurman in 1898. Then in the First World War, when he was in the trenches as a lieutenant colonel, he went on no fewer than 30 trench raids across no man's land. Sometimes he was so close that he could hear the Germans speaking to one another in their trenches. And he left his dugout once. And five minutes later, a German whiz-bang, high explosive shell, hit the dugout, direct hit, and decapitated everyone inside. And on that occasion, he said that he felt as if he could hear invisible wings beating over him.
- 5.5** So he very much had this sense of destiny that he was being kept alive, as it were, for this particular hour and trial of saving England. In fact, he told his great Harrow school

friend, at the age of 16, there was a lad called Merlin Evans, and they were talking about what they were going to do in their lives. Winston Churchill said, "There will be great upheavals and terrible wars in our times, and that I shall be called upon to save England and save London." Of course, 50 years later, exactly that happened, and he was. So, yes, he did have a driving sense of destiny. I thought it was the only thing that one could subtitle a book.

- 5.6** That's incredible. Now, he, as you've described, as a man who has cheated death on many occasions, what effect did this sense of destiny have on Churchill as a leader?
- 5.7** It gave him a preternatural calmness under pressure. If you think that you are essentially being saved for a greater thing, when hugely pressurizing events take place where he's captured in South Africa, put into a prisoner-of-war camp, escapes from the prisoner-of-war camp, then lots of parliamentary speeches and duties, and then fighting the First World War, and ultimately, of course, the whole of the 1930s, where he's under tremendous pressure not to denounce Adolf Hitler and the Nazis, which he takes no notice of. Then throughout the six years of war, either as First Lord of the Admiralty or as Prime Minister. Then in the First World War, of course, also as First Lord of the Admiralty. I mean, these are extraordinary pressures, decisions about the use of the nuclear bomb and so on, trying to encourage the British people to resist invasion, the extraordinary pressures and stresses that none of us in this room can begin to imagine.
- 5.8** They happen day in, day out, over years. And yet, he never lost his cool. He never panicked. He never allowed the situation to defeat him. So, yes, I think this sense of destiny gave him this extraordinary calmness under pressure. And haven't we seen that already in this series with Nelson and Napoleon and the two from ancient world? There is a sense that that is one of the absolutely key attributes of great leadership, is to be calm and to not allow your followers to think that you're panicking, however much you might feel nerve-wracked inside.
- 5.9** I want to move now to Churchill's parentage. I'm going to read you a quote. In describing the childhood of one of his forefathers, this being John Churchill, first Duke of Marlborough, Winston Churchill was noted as saying, and I quote, "It is said that famous men are usually the product of unhappy childhood. The stern compression of circumstances, the twinges of adversity, the spur of slights, and the taunts in early years are needed to evoke the ruthless fixity of purpose and tenacious mother-wit without which great actions are seldom accomplished." Churchill's parentage and background, incredibly important to him and within all aspects of his life. How important are your mother and father to your chances of being a great leader?
- 5.10** They can be very important, either positively or negatively. In Winston Churchill's case, he had very glamorous parents. His mother, the American heiress, Jennie Jerome, was one of the great beauties of the Edwardian Age, and she was very gregarious. She had the Prince of Wales as one of her lovers. The Austrian ambassador was another, and

she didn't have very much time for Winston or his younger brother Jack. She hardly saw him. In fact, for the first six months of the year 1884, when he was 10 years old, she only saw him for six hours. And so, you get this very great sense of her being a neglectful mother. Father, Lord Randolph Churchill, a very successful politician, Chancellor of the Exchequer, didn't seem to like Winston or appreciate anything to do with Winston. He certainly didn't think of Winston as a nascent great man. He slapped him down again and again. When he wasn't slapping him down, he was just being negligent.

5.11 He would give a speech, for example, in Brighton. He was only about half a mile away from where his son was at prep school. Didn't bother to see him. Didn't cross his mind. To many people, that might be enough to break them emotionally. Absolutely the opposite with Churchill. He continued to adore and worship his father. When his father died, when his father was 45 and Churchill was 20, he had this driving desire to meet his father's friends, hear stories about them. He then wrote a very long two-volume biography of his father. He adopted his father's political views, the Disraelian conservatism, liberal conservatism, essentially. He adopted his father's speaking style and even the way in which his father stood in public. It was an extraordinary father worship, made all the easier, of course, by the fact that his father was dead and wasn't continually criticizing him any longer.

5.12 But then in 1947, so soon after the Second World War, he actually had a weird experience, what he writes about in a book called *The Dream*, in which he meets his father, his long-dead father, the ghost of his father, essentially, and they have a long conversation. At no point in that conversation does Winston let on to Lord Randolph that he had helped win the Second World War, was a key factor in winning the war. So his father, who, of course, never knew that his son was a success, and had actually got further than he had in politics, also never discovers in this weird ethereal moment that Winston Churchill writes about, his long daydream meeting his father. So, in a sense, it's possible to say that he spent his whole life attempting to impress the shade of his long-dead father. And with his mother, he also worshiped her. And when she died in 1930, he said something that is incredibly moving, I think, something that no son should ever have to say about his mother, which was that he worshiped her, but from a distance, like the evening star.

5.13 Given all of what you've described, it's safe to say that Churchill had a reverence, I should say, to his heritage.

5.14 Oh, yes, of course. You've just mentioned John Churchill, 1st Duke of Marlborough, who was the key figure in the defeat of Louis XIV's attempts to hegemonize Europe during the Wars of Spanish Succession. So, yes, he was the man who fought the battles of Blenheim and Ramillies and Oudenarde and Malplaquet, and won them, and therefore, essentially, blunted this hope of France to dominate the continent. And he saw it very much as one of the parts of these continuing attacks on British sovereignty.

And so, yes, he grew up. He was born in a Blenheim Palace, which is the greatest of all the British ducal palaces. In fact, King George III said, "We have nothing like this," when he went to visit. The royal family doesn't have a palace as grand as Blenheim.

- 5.15** And of course, every brick of Blenheim exudes history. It was built to, by a grateful nation, to thank the Duke for his victory. He just packed it with fabulous artwork, of course, and wonderful suits of armor and weaponry and so on. Whenever Winston Churchill went to stay there, which he did quite a lot, when he was growing up, he would be there with the tapestries of his great ancestor's victory. Of course, history mattered enormously to him. And he also went to school where, every term, they sing the school songs at Harrow, and they are all about greatness, about individuals being victorious and so on. So, yes, history was a vitally important thing to him before he started having to make money, partly because his parents were such spendthrifts. And one of the ways that he made money was by writing history books. One of the reasons I'm proud to be an historian is that Winston Churchill was one.
- 5.16** We'll get to that. We'll get to that exact point around your reverence for Churchill. But one question I'd like to ask you is with regard to his last name. So, Churchill has a double-barrelled last name that we don't really talk about. It's merely Churchill that we refer to him as. Can you speak more to that?
- 5.17** Well, his real name was Spencer Churchill. Winston Leonard was his other Christian name, which he had. He was named after his maternal grandfather Leonard Jerome, the great American financial wizard. Well, as far as you can call somebody who went bankrupt twice a wizard, but nonetheless. He made the money back, which is the key thing, I suppose, of his wizardry. And the surname was Spencer Churchill. And that is the reflection of the marriage between the two great families, the Spencer family of Northamptonshire, from whom, of course, Lady Diana Spencer, the former Princess of Wales, was descended, and also the Churchill family of John Churchill, the 1st Duke of Marlborough.
- 5.18** Churchill is seemingly a man that's had many setbacks in his life. Could you speak to the role of learning from one's mistakes as a part of leadership?
- 5.19** Oh, yes. He made mistake after mistake. It's difficult to know whether or not in modern politics, where you're only allowed to make one or two mistakes, he could possibly have survived. He got the gold standard wrong. We went in at the wrong time and the wrong level. He got women's suffrage wrong. He was opposed to it for years before the First World War. He got the abdication crisis wrong. He supported Edward VIII, who would have made the most disastrous king. He got—primarily, of course, there are other things, but primarily, the Gallipoli disaster. Absolutely wrong. He was completely behind. In fact, it was his idea, essentially, and it was a brilliant idea. The idea was to get the British fleet in the Eastern Mediterranean, from the Mediterranean through the Straits of the Dardanelles and anchor it off Istanbul, then Constantinople, and through the threat of shelling, essentially force Turkey out of the war. If it had come off, it

would have been, to have actually expelled the Ottoman Empire from the central powers, would have been one of the great strategic coups of history.

5.20 But of course, it failed. On the 18th of March, 1915, the Allied fleet, the British and French fleet, was forced to go and turn back because of mines that had only been sewn the night before, in some cases. And then they waited five weeks before unleashing a huge invasion of the Gallipoli Peninsula to the west of the Dardanelles, which also got bogged down pretty much immediately and never achieved its objectives, and in the course of which some 147, 000 Allied troops were killed or wounded, including a large proportion of Australians and New Zealanders. This was a huge setback for him. Even up to the 1930s, he had people shouting, "What about the Dardanelles?" at him at political meetings. A lot of people, even at the beginning of the Second World War, thought that he couldn't really be trusted with strategic command because he had made this catastrophic mistake.

5.21 But the great thing about Winston Churchill, and you don't see it in all politicians, frankly, but you certainly do in him, is that he learned from his mistakes. Once he had seen the right way in every single one of the things I just mentioned, he learned from his mistakes. Indeed, in the 1950 general election, I think it was the '50 or possibly in 1955 general election, more women voted Conservative than voted Labour. He insisted, when he set up Churchill College, Cambridge, that women should be given complete equality, which wasn't known at Cambridge that widely by the mid-1950s. He learnt from his mistakes there. He learnt from his mistakes again and again. In fact, he wrote to his wife, Clementine, in the trenches in January 1916, that "I should have learned nothing if I had not made mistakes."

5.22 But the key one that he really learnt from was, of course, Gallipoli, because not once in the Second World War did he ever overrule the chiefs of staff, as he had done in the First World War, to push forward the Gallipoli campaign. He would sit in front of Alan Brooke and Admiral Cunningham and these other very impressive chiefs of staff, and he would sit there, sometimes breaking pencils in half, and he would shout, and he would slam his fist, and he would employ sarcasm, and sometimes he would cry in order to try and get his way. But if the chiefs of staff said no, and they would not support a particular operation, then he never actually sacked them. He had every right to. If he wanted to, he was Minister of Defense as well as Prime Minister, but he never overruled them and never even threatened to sack them.

5.23 Because what he actually wanted was, like a lot of politicians want yes -men, as we've spoken about earlier in this series, he wanted no-men. He wanted people who would come up with arguments against him, and he would have to, by sheer better argument, win the day. If he couldn't do that, then he recognized that maybe there was something wrong with the operation that he was putting forward. You get one moment in the March of 1944 with a proposed attack on Sumatra that Churchill was very much in favor of and that the chiefs of staff were very much against, where all three of them

said that they would resign if it went forward, and he backed down. But he backed down every time, really, on these great issues, if he couldn't persuade the chiefs of staff. So, he learnt his lesson on that, as well as everything else. And it's a great attribute of a leader to be able to learn one's lessons.

- 5.24 Absolutely. It's certainly a testament to his character. Switching gears a bit now, Winston Churchill is famous for having a black dog depression and drinking quite a bit. Was he a depressive alcoholic?
- 5.25 No, he wasn't. He didn't even have black dog depression. He, on one occasion in July 1911, wrote to Clementine using the phrase "black dog." But at the time, that actually didn't have the manic-depressive overtones that it does. In fact, sometimes Edwardian governesses would write about the children in their care having a black dog day. He was not an actual depressive. He did get depressed on occasion. Of course, he did. He got depressed at the time of the fall of Tobruk in June 1942, the fall of Singapore in the February of that year. But those are moments where any sentient being would have got depressed. They were terrible setbacks for the country. The idea that he had some chemical imbalance which sent him into depression, come what may, is incorrect. In fact, depression, as we all know, is a debilitating illness, especially manic depression. He could not have chaired 900 meetings of the chiefs of staff committee at all times of day and night if he had had a debilitating depressive condition.
- 5.26 With regard to his drinking, he did drink an enormous amount. There's absolutely no doubt about that. He'd start at, well, he'd have some drink at lunchtime. He used to enjoy starting off with a glass or two of champagne, glass or two of white wine, and then red wine with his meal. That's lunchtime. Then he'd have pretty much the same in the evening, but he'd also have a whisky and soda on the go from about 6 o'clock onwards. I once asked his last private secretary, Anthony Montague Browne, wonderful man, about the whiskies and soda. He said, "Well, it's really mouthwash," he said. "It's a tiny amount of whisky that he poured for him, huge amounts of soda. He'd just like to have it there. Of course, the thing is that, if you start drinking those at 6 o'clock and then go through to 2 or 3 o'clock in the morning, which is what Churchill tended to do—he liked staying up very late with the chiefs of staff and working through the problems. They couldn't have an afternoon nap in the same way that he did, so they were always completely exhausted by 2 or 3 o'clock in the morning.
- 5.27 But there's only one occasion in the whole of the Second World War when the people at any of these meetings thought that Churchill was drunk. That was on the 7th of March 1944. What they did on that occasion was, and everybody there, Admiral Cunningham mentions it in his diary, General Burke mentions it in his diary, Anthony Eden, the Foreign Secretary, mentions it. So it was quite clear that the Prime Minister was plastered on that occasion. But what they decided to do was to hold the same meeting the next morning, as though the last one hadn't happened, which is a genius thing when you think about it. He used to drink quite a lot when he went to see Stalin

and the Kremlin. He was very contemptuous. He didn't think Stalin was very good at keeping his drink, and then he could out-drink Stalin in vodka. He was rather proud of that.

- 5.28** But again, when one considers the pressure he was under, It was extraordinary he didn't drink more. There was a great line from one of his friends, the journalist C.P. Snow, who said that Winston Churchill "could not have been an alcoholic because no alcoholic could have drunk that much." There is an element to that. He had a pachydermatous hide when it came to drinking. Rhinocerine. He was right, actually, when he said, ultimately, that he took more out of alcohol than alcohol had taken out of him. And so this assumption that he was both a depressive and an alcoholic is wrong on both counts.
- 5.29** This is by no means an endorsement or a plug, but did Churchill have a favorite brand or vintage of alcohol?
- 5.30** Pol-Roger champagne. Yes, he got on very well with Odette Pol-Roger in the Champagne region. She gave him, very generously, a case of the 1928 vintage until it ran out. Then she started giving him a case of the 1934, every Christmas. But he did drink Hine brandy, but he drank—frankly, if you offered him any brandy, he wasn't going to say no. But yes, he had a good taste in alcohol. But as I say, he didn't allow alcohol to become his master.
- 5.31** Drinking is usually an activity best done with friends. Did Churchill have any friends?
- 5.32** He had loads of friends, yes. He was a man who was absolutely replete with the capacity for friendship. In fact, he had so many friends that he set up a club called The Other Club, which he and his great friend, F. E. Smith, later Lord Birkenhead, set up in 1911. And it 's still going today. I'm very proud to say that I'm a member of it today. It still meets monthly in the Savoy, and it had his closest friends. Then after he died, they elected members who elected members who elected members to the present day. His capacity for friendship with people like T. E. Lawrence, Lawrence of Arabia, Charlie Chaplin, very much people who weren't politicians—there were plenty of friends that he had who were politicians, including obviously F. E. Smith and Lord Beaverbrook and Brendan Bracken, these people.
- 5.33** Sometimes they went too far and presumed, essentially, on his friendship. This is what happened with Bob Boothby, who had been a close friend of his in the 1930s. But when he was appointed to the government in 1940, he was mixed up with a very unpleasant financial crisis scandal, frankly, to do with check assets. Rather than allow him to become an anchor on his ministry, Churchill sacked him, and Bob Boothby never forgave him for that. Alfred Duff Cooper, as well, a wonderful politician and somebody who had resigned over Munich in 1938, also was simply not cutting the mustard by the time he was sent out to Singapore in the aftermath of Pearl Harbor, and he also had to be fired. Sorry, he was also as Minister for Information. So this was heartbreaking for

Churchill because these were friends. They were often people who had stuck by him in the appeasement years. But frankly, it was more important to ensure that the right man was in the right place in an important ministry like the Ministry of Information than that friendship should triumph.

- 5.34** Moving now to his role as a politician and the Second World War, how did Churchill have the foresight to spot Adolf Hitler and the Nazis for what they were before anyone else did?
- 5.35** I think it came down really to three things. The first was, and we've covered it slightly, that he was an historian. What he was able to do was to place the threat posed by Hitler and the Nazis in the overall continuum of British history. He saw it as being simply the latest of, although the most threatening and the most dangerous of, the series of threats that Britain had faced before with invasion—in 1588 with the Spanish Armada, with the Louis XIV threat, which, of course, his great ancestor, the Duke of Marlborough, had defeated, with the threat posed by Napoleon, which, as we have discovered, Nelson ultimately ended with the threat posed by the Kaiser. And he, of course, had fought in the trenches opposing that himself. So he was an expert in all of these. And so he recognized with Hitler, and especially the creation of the Luftwaffe, and the time of the fall of France, where he mentions history in 10% of his speeches. Ten percent of those uplifting speeches, encouraging the British people to fight on in 1940, have reference to history. And so he's able to see this through the prism of history.
- 5.36** The second thing, of course, was that he was a philosemite. He liked Jews. His father had liked Jews. He'd gone on holiday with Jews, very unlike a lot of the upper-class Englishmen of the day. He was somebody who appreciated the extraordinary contributions that the Jewish people have made to Western civilization. And so, he had this early warning system when it came to Hitler and the Nazis that was not vouchsafed to a lot of politicians, frankly, on both sides of the aisle and in both houses of Parliament. That was another thing, his philosemitism.
- 5.37** Then lastly, he'd also come up against fanaticism in his life. Up on the North-West Frontier and in the Sudan, he had seen a form of fanaticism that, frankly, other prime ministers of the 1930s, like Stanley Baldwin and Ramsey MacDonald, Neville Chamberlain, had never seen in their lives before. So he was able to spot that sort of fanaticism. You have all those three things together, and he was in a position, therefore, to be the first, and for a long time, pretty much the only, senior British politician to warn against the threat of Hitler and the Nazis.
- 5.38** Now, Churchill was a man under great stress. How exactly does stress tolerance play a role in great leadership?
- 5.39** Well, exactly that. Yes, he was under massive stress, but he had this sense of inner calm to him where he didn't panic. I suppose if you've been into the trenches, into no man's

land, 30 times, then it's going to take an awful lot to panic you, frankly. He had come face to face, as I mentioned earlier, to death on many occasions, and he had this great inner calm. That is something that we saw with Pericles, we saw with Julius Caesar, certainly true of Napoleon, who would have friends and marshals shot down near him and taken out by cannonballs in battle. It wouldn't faze him because he was able to compartmentalize and to concentrate on the job at hand. So, I think, yes, this is an important aspect of great leadership.

5.40 I want to touch on what—

5.41 It's a marvelous—sorry, if I can just butt in. There's a great example of this with Winston Churchill, where in the House of Commons, there's a confidence motion against him. This is 1942, and there's a chance, therefore, if it went against him, that the government would fall and he would no longer be Prime Minister. He was talking about the A22 tank, which had proved to be completely useless. He said in the House of Commons that when the teething troubles and the major problems of the A22 tank were clear to all, it was promptly rechristened the Churchill. So he was able to make very good gags like that, even during a confidence motion when his whole government's future was in jeopardy.

5.42 I want to touch on something you discussed in the last bit there around his military service. How exactly did his military service affect his worldview and prepare him to be a leader?

5.43 Oh, enormously. Yes. I mean, first of all, of course, he went to Sandhurst and was taught to be an officer and how to hold himself as an officer. He was taught all of the various aspects of military training that you'd expect. He was a superb horseman, apart from everything else. But you sketched fortresses and learnt military history and went on maneuvers and so on. It was a pretty good education. He didn't go to university. He didn't go to Oxford or Cambridge, like so many of his contemporaries. But he did go to Sandhurst and he got a good education. Then, as I mentioned earlier, he was a huge autodidact. When he was up in the North-West Frontier as a subaltern, he read all the great works of the Western canon. It's quite extraordinary, the amount of Plato and Socrates and Gibbon and Macaulay and you name it. The list of great works was something that he really grappled with when he was in his mid- to late-20s.

5.44 And so, through that education at Sandhurst, and then, of course, fighting in these various campaigns—and writing about them at the same time for the newspapers, as a war correspondent, the best paid war correspondent in the world at the time of the Boer War—he was immensely well set up for the time that the First World War broke out, when, of course, he was first Lord of the Admiralty and later on Minister of Munitions. Then by the time the Second World War had broken out, he 'd written lots of history books about war. He'd written his memoirs of the First World War.

- 5.45 He'd also written in that book you quoted, the biography of Marlborough, he was able to write about the concept of coalition fighting, because, of course, Marlborough was in coalition all the way through those wars and was great personal friends with Prince Eugene of Savoy. And so he had been thinking about coalition warfare in an intellectual sense, as well as being involved in it in the First World War. His admiration for Georges Clemenceau was central to this. And of course, when the Americans came into the war, he was coordinating with them with regard to munitions. So all of his past life, as he says, of course, in his war memoirs, in that last paragraph of the first volume of his war memoirs, all his past life had been but a preparation for that hour and that trial.
- 5.46 How exactly did he earn the nickname the British Bulldog?
- 5.47 The British Bulldog dog? Because he looked like one.
- 5.48 Ah. OK. We can move on to the next question.
- 5.49 He also had a few of the same traits as a bulldog, needless to say. Once he'd bitten something, he tended not to let go of it.
- 5.50 Well, I think this brings us to a next question here on who he got on well, on well with. Are there any world leaders that he really jived with?
- 5.51 Oh, very much, yes. Although the word jived, I think, would be something that he wouldn't necessarily have immediately chosen himself. Clemenceau, Georges Clemenceau, who I mentioned just now, was his hero, essentially, and his template in 1940. He had been present in the National Assembly when Clemenceau made the great speech in 1917, saying, "We shall fight before Paris, we shall fight in Paris, we shall fight behind Paris." You can hear that cadence, of course, with, "We shall fight on the beaches, we shall fight on the landing grounds, we shall fight in the fields and in the streets." Georges Clemenceau was one of his great heroes.
- 5.52 He wrote a book called Great Contemporaries, which I hugely recommend to everybody, published in 1937. Wonderful piece of writing. It is a series of chapters about the great men who he knew and how he'd interacted with them. Some of them were quite caustic and make great reading today. Others were much more adulatory. So, yes, there are people who he admired. King Alfonso XIII of Spain, he thought of as being a very brave man. And he wrote in that Great Contemporaries, that "bravery is rightly considered the first of the virtues because it underpins all the others." And so, yes, he was somebody who could draw out people. He was tremendously charming, of course, and he could draw out people and get the best from them.
- 5.53 Now, one thing to note about Churchill, and I want to move now to his skills as an orator, is that he had a speech impediment, yet he was an almost naturally gifted speaker, great eloquence. Can you speak more about this?
- 5.54 Well, I can, but I would take issue with you on the idea that he was naturally gifted, because actually, yes, you're right about the speech impediment, which he did a lot of

work to overcome. He had to say, I can't remember the long sentence, but it's largely about the Spanish ships come sailing and it has lots of Ss and Hs. And he had to say it with pebbles in his mouth in order to try to fight against his lisp, which you can still hear in later life, even in the VE-Day broadcast of May 1945. There's a slight lisp, which soldiers at the time thought that Churchill had because he was drunk when he was making it, but he wasn't. He just had this slight voice impediment, but he had got over it by hard work.

- 5.55** But with regard to whether he was a natural speaker, he wasn't really. Actually, it was learned. In the April of 1904, he was making a speech, and he essentially forgot his lines, and he sat down with his head in his hands, and people worried that he had inherited his father's rare brain disease and that he was going to lose his marbles. But he didn't. He'd just lost his way. And from that moment on, he wrote down the essential kernel of each sentence of his speech and used these notes. They were nicknamed Psalm Form because you get the key point of each of the sentences. And so you can see, therefore, the way in which he uses short sentences.
- 5.56** He was once asked, actually, by his private secretary, what were the tricks of the trade for his great wartime speeches? He told Jock Colville that there were three of them, really. You had to keep your sentences short. Don't use lots of sub-clauses if they're not needed. Try and use short words as well. Don't show off how clever you are by using long words. Use the apposite word for the sentence. Each sentence must make one point. Each paragraph, of course, must make one set of points. He said that, if at all possible, use old English words, use words that come from the Anglo-Saxon, because if the English-speaking peoples have been using them for 1,000 years, they'll know what they mean.
- 5.57** You see, therefore, in the 141 words of that peroration of the great speech of the 4th of June, 1940, the "we shall fight on the beach," his speech, in which he says that they will fight with ever-growing confidence in the air and ending, of course, "we shall never surrender," of that 141 words, there are only two words that do not come from Old English. One of them is the word confidence, which comes from the Latin, and the other is surrender, which comes from the French.
- 5.58** There's a joke there. I won't make it.
- 5.59** I don't know what you're talking about.
- 5.60** Neither do I. Churchill was noted to be quite lachrymose, so he would often cry during public speeches when he would deliver them. Is lachrymosity a good thing or a bad thing in leadership?
- 5.61** It's neither, but you're absolutely right. He was incredibly lachrymose. I counted over 50 times that Churchill burst into tears in public in the Second World War alone. It'd be very off-putting today if Rishi Sunak were just to burst into tears in the House of Commons. You'd wonder what on Earth was going on. But everybody knew that

Churchill was essentially a Regency figure. He was somebody who was, in that sense, very much in touch with his emotions. When Admiral Nelson died, actually, at his funeral, it was a very sexist funeral. There were no women invited to his funeral. But there were 8 admirals who carried his coffin, and all of them were in tears. So, there was a way in pre-Victorian, in pre-Victorian times, that Regency figures were expected to show their emotions. That had died out by the Victorian age. And yet, with Winston Churchill, who I think of as a much more throwback to the Regency period, the way he spent, the way he lived, the way he gambled and so on, it's very much a pre-Victorian figure, and you see that also in his lachrymosity.

5.62 Could you speak to Churchill's relationship with his wife, Clementine?

5.63 Yes, it was a genuine and beautiful love story. He met her at a dinner party in 1908 and fell in love with her immediately, and she with him. And they got married the next year. They had five children, of whom four survived infancy. Essentially, we talked about capacity for a friendship. They were each other's best friends. They also wouldn't have breakfast together. I think that's always a very good idea when it comes to having a strong marriage. They very rarely holidayed together, as well. The kind of holidays she liked and the kind of holidays he liked were completely different, and so they didn't see each other for holidays. So they were very excited and happy when they met afterwards.

5.64 It's not the normal, modern, middle-class marriage, but it certainly worked for them. They were faithful to each other and they loved each other. So it's a rather moving thing. Also, she would be his rock in those moments of darkness that I mentioned earlier, like the fall of Tobruk and the fall of Singapore. She gave him a little bit of—she never gave him military advice, but she gave him a little bit of political advice, usually about people, people who he thought he could trust and she thought he shouldn't or couldn't. And also, gosh, she was an absolute tigress in his defense. When he was sacked by Asquith in the First World War, at least demoted from First Lord to Chancellor of the Duchy of Lancaster, she went round and remonstrated and wrote him a letter, the Prime Minister, a letter. When you read that letter, you would feel tremendously proud to have such a woman as your wife. I actually do have such a woman as my wife. I can see that how fantastically helpful and supportive that 100 % committed support might be.

5.65 Despite his success during the Second World War, he lost the election in 1945. Why was this?

5.66 Well, because we don't have a presidential system in the United Kingdom. He was standing for one constituency, his own constituency, in Essex. But in the other 649 constituencies, you had conservatives, many of whom, of course, had been appeasers before the war, who were not committed to the kind of, what was called the "New Jerusalem" that was offered by the Labour Party, with lots of essentially free stuff and the nationalization of the Bank of England and the mines and so on. The welfare state,

huge extension of social security, and everything that was on offer from the Labour Party at the end of six years of grueling war and the Blitz and sacrifice. So, that was the reason that he lost. It had very little to do with him. In fact, had it been a presidential election, he could well have won.

- 5.67** On the day, and he was expecting to win as well, because wherever he went in the United Kingdom, huge crowds turned out to cheer him, and they would cheer him, but they weren't going to vote for him. He hadn't spotted that until the actual day of the election itself, when his wife, Clementine, said, "Well, don't worry, darling." This is a good example, actually, of her support. "Don't worry, darling. It could be a blessing in disguise." He said, "Well, from where I'm sitting, it seems remarkably well disguised."
- 5.68** Now, we speak, and we obviously know very much about his prime ministership between 1940 and 1945, but we don't talk about his prime ministership between 1951 and 1955. Could you speak more about this?
- 5.69** Yes. He, after the defeat in 1945, he went on very long holidays, painting holidays. In a way, what Clementine meant about "it's a blessing in disguise" was correct because he was completely exhausted. He was in his early '70s by the end of the Second World War. He had thrown everything into it. He was physically exhausted and he really needed a rest. And so he went on holiday, painting holidays, in Italy and Morocco. He wrote his memoirs and so on and was able to recharge his batteries. Then once the Attlee government had run out of steam by 1951, he came back into power, won a general election in the October of that year, and served until 1955.
- 5.70** Frankly, he went on too long. Prime ministers tend to. They love the job, and he certainly did. But he had a stroke in July 1953, and that's when he should have given up the premiership. He carried on. He was actually 80 in November 1954, and he was still Prime Minister. And quite a lot, as you can imagine, of the other members of the Tory party wanted him to go, but nobody quite had the guts to stand up and tell him to go because he'd have told them where to go. So, all in all, it was quite a sad ending to the premiership. He should have probably given up. Actually, the ideal time would have been June 1953, at the time of the Queen's coronation, and before his first stroke.
- 5.71** Could you describe Churchill's leadership style?
- 5.72** Leadership style? Well, pugnacious is an obvious one. The key thing about him, really, was his capacity for this foresight that I mentioned. He was able not just to see Adolf Hitler and the threat from Adolf Hitler and the Nazis, but also before the First World War, he recognized the threat posed by Germany, and he got the grand fleet ready for the First World War to the point when we were able to move the British Expeditionary Force across the Channel without the loss of a single man in that operation in 1914. But he had this foresight that he also showed, of course, after the Second World War, being the first major Western politician to warn against Stalin and the rise of the USSR in Eastern Europe and the threat posed to the freedom of Eastern Europe.

- 5.73** He made that speech, of course, in Fulton, Missouri, in the Iron Curtain speech on the 5th of March, 1946, far earlier than other people were willing to go down that route. In fact, he was attacked and criticized in both Congress and Parliament. The Truman administration distanced itself from the remarks that he'd made about the Iron Curtain. It was only over the next two years that the actions of Stalin made it clear that he had been right all along. So, he got the three big moments of the 20th century—rise of Wilhelmine Germany, the threat of the Nazis, and the threat of Soviet communism—all right, and he was one of the first people to do that. That tremendous foresight, allied to his eloquence and allied to his moral courage in saying these things, even though they were tremendously unpopular, was, and you remember how I mentioned how Pericles, one of the great things about Pericles was he was willing to tell the people that which they did not wish to hear, but which he knew to be right. And Winston Churchill had that as well in spades.
- 5.74** Now, I've asked you this question in the four sessions prior, and I'll ask it here again. Was Winston Churchill ruthless?
- 5.75** He could be. Oh, absolutely, yes. The classic example, I suppose, is his attempts with the Black and Tans, who were British auxiliary ex-soldiers, essentially, who were sent into southern Ireland to try to put down the incipient uprising in post-First World War Ireland. It was a disaster. It led to the burning down of about a third of Cork, the city of Cork. It was terrible, really. Lots of people were killed. That act of ruthlessness was very largely Winston Churchill's. And that's another one, by the way, of the things that he learned from. He was able to admit his mistake there, as so often.
- 5.76** Now, I want to talk about Churchill in the contemporary. So I put it to you now. What do you think Churchill would make of Britain today and the wider world at large?
- 5.77** Well, I think he'd be very happy that we're still, 80 years after the Second World War, a democracy, the 6th largest power in the world in the terms of GDP, and the forefront of supporting Ukraine in its fight against Russian totalitarianism. I think he'd be happy with the fact that we're in the G7 and the United Nations Security Council. He never was much for European integration, political integration. So, although he was very much in favor of the Council of Europe and didn't want the Germans and the French to go to war with one another again, he never supported anything to do with British activity in political integration. So he'd have been quite happy, I think, about the events of the last decade or so. But overall, yeah, I think he'd have been thrilled that we're still a democracy and a functioning one and a Western, pro-American power.
- 5.78** How do you think Churchill would be received today, or maybe even a Churchillian political figure? How would they perform?
- 5.79** Well, I'm not sure that you can drink and smoke in public to the extent that Winston Churchill did. He had what is, I suppose, a very old-fashioned way of, now at least, of expressing himself. I personally think it's absolutely beautiful. It's Shakespearean

language. Lots of it taken, of course, from the King James Bible and so on. But it's somewhat dated, sadly, the form of rhetoric that he used. But as I mentioned earlier about the earlier leader, he'd have been brilliant on Twitter. A lot of those great one-off lines and a lot of his retorts actually are pretty pithy. I think he'd have been pretty good when it came to that. Of course, his capacity for radio broadcasts, which was absolutely superb, he would have had to have tried to master television.

5.80 The trouble with television is that it can sometimes, it's not going to be doing it with us, needless to say, Vincent, but it can sometimes make you appear a smaller figure. That would have been a problem for Churchill. He only tried once to appear on television, and it wasn't a success. He wasn't able to master it. He was 80 by the time he tried it. But if he was somehow magically reincarnated, I think, to today, I think he would very much, because he was a driving political figure, try to learn how to master it and master all of the other things. He'd have been on TikTok and Instagram.

5.81 Now, I'm not trying to get you in trouble with this next question, but I think it needs to be asked. Are there any politicians, English, maybe even international, that hold a candle to Winston Churchill?

5.82 Oh, I think Margaret Thatcher did. Absolutely, yes. She grew up very much revering Churchill. She sat around the —I mean, she was born in 1926, so she was 14 when Churchill was making his great wartime speeches, and she sat around the family radio, and up in Lincolnshire, listening to the speeches with her father and mother and sister, and also with a young Jewish refugee who they took into their home and whose life they saved, essentially. So, yes, I think you look at some of her speeches during the Falkland's War, and the tinges of Churchillian phraseology are never too far away.

5.83 Now, Lord Roberts, you've written extensively on Churchill, and it's clear from the writing that you have a reverence for Churchill. Why is this?

5.84 Well, I'd rather slightly, secretly despise any Englishman who doesn't. He saved our country. Of course, one should revere him. He came top of the poll as the greatest Englishman who ever lived. So, yes, if we were to delve deep psychologically, it might be because I was, I think, probably five years old before I realized that my rather overweight, cigar-smoking, and brandy -drinking grandfather wasn't Winston Churchill. But no, I unreservedly think of him as the greatest of the great men.

5.85 Your biography on Churchill is recognized by 13 newspapers as the best single-volume biography on Churchill, and there's been a lot written about him. How on Earth did you find anything new to say?

5.86 Well, you're right about how many books. There have been 1,009 biographies of Winston Churchill that have been published. So, you're right. There's something hubristic about bringing out the 1,010th. But I was very fortunate because the late Queen, Her Majesty, Queen Elizabeth II, allowed me to be the first Churchill biographer to use her father's diaries. King George VI, of course, met Churchill every Tuesday of

the Second World War. They had lunch together at Buckingham Palace. They served themselves from the sideboard because nobody else could be present, because Churchill trusted the king with all of the great secrets of the Second World War—the nuclear secret, which admirals and generals were going to be hired and fired, which countries were going to be invaded, when and under what circumstances, and so on.

- 5.87** Of course, he hadn't necessarily got on that well with the king, because the king had been very much in favor of appeasement, and Churchill had been very much in favor of King Edward VIII, the king's elder brother, being, staying on as king at the time of the abdication crisis. So, there was a chance that they might not have got on, but they did, and they became firm friends. And in fact, the king was the —he said that he would call him Winston. He called none of his other prime ministers by their first name. It worked, this close friendship.
- 5.88** And after these weekly meetings, the king wrote down everything that Churchill had told him in his diary. I was, as I say, the first person to be allowed to use that. So, that was an enormous and wonderful news source. But there were actually no fewer than 57 sets of papers that had been delivered to Churchill College Archives in Cambridge University since the last major biography of Churchill. I was very lucky that the Churchill family also allowed me access to papers that hadn't been used before. So all in all, there was enough to justify my book.
- 5.89** Now, we're going to move to the final question of this session, the capstone question, as it were. What is the single greatest lesson we can learn from Winston Churchill?
- 5.90** I think it's the anatomy of courage that he shows, both physical courage and moral courage. Not everybody has both. It's interesting that that's the case, but it is a fact of the human condition. But Churchill did. In the Second World War, for example, he would fly within the radius of the Luftwaffe. He'd go up onto the Air Ministry roof to watch the Blitz. He would constantly try to be where the fighting was. He was crossing the Rhine early on. He was—obviously, he wanted to actually be present at D-Day, but the King wouldn't let him. He actually flew 110, 000 miles outside the United Kingdom during the Second World War.
- 5.91** In a sense, he was the person who kept the Big Three, of him and Stalin and Roosevelt, together, because apart from Tehran, Stalin never left the Soviet Union during the Second World War. Of course, FDR was profoundly disabled and found it difficult to go outside the United States, although he did. He went to Yalta and also Tehran, of course, and to Casablanca. But it was really Churchill who flew around the world and kept that alliance together. He suffered four bouts of pneumonia, any one of which could have killed him in the Second World War. It was a tremendous—in his 70s, flying in these unpressurized cabins. He was a tremendously brave man.
- 5.92** But just as important, he was able to, in the 1930s, show the moral courage necessary of saying something that was profoundly unpopular, namely that Hitler and the Nazis

needed to be guarded against and that huge sums of money needed to be spent on defense, especially rearmament in the air. He was shouted down in the House of Commons on occasion. He was lambasted and ridiculed in the press. He nearly had his seat taken away from him by the Conservative party in the autumn of 1938 and early 1939, until Hitler invaded Prague on the 15th of March 1939, and proved Churchill was right and had been right all along in everything that he had said over the previous 10 years when nobody had supported him. That moral courage was the reason that he became Prime Minister and was able to be such an important figure in the ultimate defeat of the most evil dictatorship the world's ever seen.

- 5.93** Absolutely magnificent. A great man indeed and a great leader. Let's take it now to the audience for questions.
- 5.94** Thank you, Lord Roberts. I'd like to track back to what you mentioned about Churchill and his relationship with his wife. One of the arguments put forward in Plato's Symposium is the idea that part of the value of love is this capacity to feel shame in front of the person that you love and who loves you, especially when you make mistakes, errors, but also when you do things that aren't the right thing to do and you make bad decisions. Did this have this element and this dimension to the relationship with his wife impact Churchill that way? And do you think someone in that position of authority and importance, in that case, is that an asset or more of a liability?
- 5.95** Well, Churchill wasn't that good at feeling shame, I have to say. He did have an immensely powerful ego. He tended, like most politicians, to think that he was right about most things. When he was proved wrong, he learned from his mistakes, as we mentioned earlier. One of the people who actually did help him see his mistakes was Clementine. She writes to him in the only letter that she writes to him in the whole of 1940, because, of course, they were living together in Downing Street, so she didn't need to write letters. But she did write on one occasion, saying that he was becoming unbearable to his secretaries and his aides, and that he needed to behave better. That's the kind of thing that a man can take from his wife. Probably not from his political opponents, certainly, or even his political allies. It was a good thing for her to have said.
- 5.96** She was also in favor of female suffrage when he wasn't. That, of course, also led to not necessarily a moment of Platonic shame, but certainly disagreements in the Churchill household. But overall, she really was a very positive force for good in his life and his career. It's not true to say that she actually changed the political outlook that he had on any particular issue, let alone on any military issue. But she gave him that unquestioning support which men need from their wives.
- 5.97** Dr. Roberts, would you be able to talk a little bit more about Churchill's relationship with the late Queen Elizabeth? Did he influence her at all when she became Queen?
- 5.98** Very much, yes. It was a complete love affair from his point of view. He worshiped the Queen. He spoke of her in terms of complete reverence. He thought that she did a

wonderful job. He said that if they had tried to go to all of the studios in Hollywood to find a more beautiful and more elegant person as a queen, they couldn't have done it. He was, of course, hugely affected by the death of King George VI at the very early age. George VI was only in his 50s, and Churchill cried on that occasion. But he very quickly worked out that the Queen was a just hugely wise figure. And he, being the first of all of her prime ministers, he did actually act in the way that Palmerston had acted, sorry, Melbourne had acted with Queen Victoria, and helped her with the experience side of things.

- 5.99** They used to chat about—they had their Tuesday lunchtime audiences as well. But these tended to go on a bit because, although people weren't allowed in, the private secretary stood outside the door and they kept hearing peals of laughter when these audiences took place. They also used to speak quite a lot about racing, of course, because they both owned racehorses. And he did say to the Queen how sad it was that only one person could win, on an occasion when one of his horses beat one of hers. But yes, it was quite unlike the completely ridiculous way in which *The Crown*, the TV series *The Crown*, tried to portray it. It was not like that at all. It was an absolute love fest, as far as he was concerned. She obviously also offered him the dukedom of London when he retired, which she was quite relieved, actually, when he said no. But nonetheless, it was an extraordinary thing for a monarch in the 20th century to offer a dukedom to anybody, let alone an outgoing politician.
- 5.100** You talk about how perhaps the time that Winston stepped back was before he did so. Is it possible for these great leaders to go from being somebody to being nobody? Are you destined to bow out at the wrong time or to meet an unfortunate demise?
- 5.101** Yes, that's a very good question. Some people find it tremendously difficult. Margaret Thatcher was overthrown in 1990, and she was never really able to get over it. It's better if you—historically, of course, it's much better if, like Admiral Nelson, you're killed at the moment of your greatest triumph. But that's not necessarily something that you'd wish for yourself as a great leader. Churchill was still properly sentient and able to work out what was going on until about 1962, but then he had a fall and, by the time of his death in the January of 1965, funny enough, 70 years to the day after his father's death, he was no longer intellectually capable. So, no, it's a sadness, really. Pericles, of course, died of the plague. Caesar was assassinated. It's probably better to go out while you're ahead, if you can.
- 5.102** In view of the fact that Winston Churchill was half American, could you tell us a bit about his relationship with Franklin D. Roosevelt, please?
- 5.103** Yes, it was an absolutely key relationship, of course. The help that the United States was able to give Britain after Pearl Harbor was a war-winning factor, as far as the West was concerned. And so, it was absolutely vital that these two men should get on well. Churchill later joked that no mistress ever studied the whims of her lover more than he had studied the whims of FDR. He was, of course, an aristocrat in the same way that

FDR was an aristocrat. They both came from the center of politics, center-left in FDR's case, center-right in Churchill's, but they overlapped and saw a good deal of common ground. Politically, they both had the same hatred of Nazism, of course, and they got on privately extremely well. Churchill didn't much like the cocktails that FDR used to mix for him at the White House, preferring a glass of champagne. But otherwise, there was a genuine friendship.

5.104 Now, by the October of 1944, once D-Day had taken place and the bulk of the American forces were ashore in Europe, there were enough disagreements that meant that the relationship was starting to fray at the edges. There are about 200 more messages from Winston Churchill to FDR than there are replies from FDR. But nonetheless, when he said goodbye to FDR at the end of the Yalta conference and could see, like everybody else, that FDR was dying, it was a very emotional time for Churchill, and yet one, yet another of the times that he burst into tears.

Lecture 6: Marshall's Military

At a glance — George C. Marshall and organizational military leadership.

- 6.1 In this next session, we are going to move to George C. Marshall. Now, the first question I want to ask you is with regard to Churchill and his view of Marshall. Churchill called George Marshall "the modern Carnot." What did he mean by that?
- 6.2 He was referring to Lazare Carnot, who was the Minister of War during the French Revolution, and also actually, he was one of Napoleon's ministers of war as well. He was a genius at organization. He was the person who essentially put into place what was called the levée en masse, which was mass conscription of the whole nation, getting them into uniform, getting them equipped, and sending them off to fight against the Austrians and Prussians in the 1790s. What Churchill—and he had a tremendous reputation. Carnot was considered to be the great organizer, and he was known as the organizer of victory. And so, what Churchill was doing, therefore, in calling him the modern Carnot, was to make George Marshall out to be the organizer of Western victory.
- 6.3 This is a very fair thing, really. He became the US Army Chief of Staff on the 1st of September 1939, coincidentally, the same day that Adolf Hitler unleashed blitzkrieg on Poland. He then saw the war all the way through to the end, in this key position of US Army Chief of Staff, which, although in one sense, he was only in charge of one area of the chiefs of staff, of the joint chiefs, as they were called, actually, of course, through his auctoritas, his natural authority, he dominated the joint chiefs. He did this also because Hap Arnold, who was the man in charge of the USAAF, the US Air Force, then known as the Army Air Force, because it was part of the army, supported Marshall.
- 6.4 There were lots of dust-ups with the Navy, which I'm sure we'll come on to later. You have this sense of a man who, in September 1939, with the realization that a world war was breaking out, only had an American army of 200,000 men. It was the 14th largest army in the world. It the same size as the army of Romania. He had to build that up as quickly as possible. By the end of the war, there were 16 million Americans under arms. He turned the force from 200,000 to 8 million in the army, and to 16 million overall. An extraordinary thing.
- 6.5 We military historians always say that amateurs talk about tactics, but professionals talk about logistics. Logistics is so much more important. As I mentioned, that book by Cathal Nolan, *The Allure of Battle*, which talks about how important it is, if you want to win a war, to harness the economic power of a country. This is essentially what George C. Marshall did. He was able to create an army out of nothing. When one thinks of how difficult that was, to have got these millions of people trained, to have them equipped, to have them wearing their uniforms, and to send them abroad, and to then also do the

grand strategy, it really was the most incredible task, and it was one that Marshall was the central figure for.

- 6.6** An armored division in the Second World War required 1,600 tons of stuff per day. This is food, this is shells and ammunition, this is obviously fuel, and any number of other things in order to fight effectively, 1,600 tons a day per division. Of course, Eisenhower is in charge of 91 divisions by the time of D-Day. Just imagine the amount of sheer organizational capacity necessary.
- 6.7** This is a tremendous workload you've mentioned here on the part of George C. Marshall. What did this workload have, or what toll did this take on George C. Marshall? Was he exhausted by it?
- 6.8** He was exhausted, but he was an extraordinary hard worker. He used to put in 16 hours a day, every day. But he also had been the Chief of Staff to Black Jack Pershing, the general in charge of the American forces in the First World War, the American Expeditionary Force. That was very good for him because Pershing was also somebody who recognized that you couldn't appear tired. On one occasion, he sat back in his car, and the troops—going backwards and forwards in the First World War—the troops spotted this and thought that he was tired and worried about it because you don't want to be led by somebody who's visibly exhausted. And Marshall wrote to his wife, "I must never appear tired," however tired he genuinely was by this avalanche of work, about how to get a country geared up and ready for war. Of course, he had two years from the attack in Poland to the attack on Pearl Harbor, a little over two years, but not a minute of them were wasted.
- 6.9** In having these discussions around these great leaders, you've pointed out two archetypes in a sense, the great speaker and the great logician, or the great strategist. How rare is it to find a combination of these two in a leader?
- 6.10** It's pretty rare. We have seen a few of them, of course, already, and we'll see a few more by the end of the series. But Marshall wasn't a great public speaker. He was rarely called upon, really. The secretary for the Army. It's not a—apart from sitting in Congressional committees, very occasionally answering questions to the Armed Forces Committee, he's not expected to be a public speaker, but he was very good with words. He gets exactly the right words when needed with regard to orders. He was a courtly Pennsylvanian gentleman. His father was an unsuccessful businessman. I think he went bankrupt at one stage. He was really made by VMI, the Virginia Military Institute, where he was extremely successful, and he took to the military life extremely well. He didn't command troops in battle. As I say, he was the Chief of Staff of Jack Pershing.
- 6.11** But that didn't matter because what he was essentially doing was looking at the grand strategy, which countries were going to be invaded and under what circumstances. He was also equipping and training these men and making sure, by the time they went into battle, they were properly equipped and ready for the struggle. We've talked about

hard work. People like Julius Caesar were incredibly hardworking. Napoleon only slept four hours a night, famously. Margaret Thatcher, who we'll be talking about, also only slept four hours a night. You don't get these great leaders who are lazy, frankly. It is very hard work.

- 6.12** I'm going to prompt you on this, actually, in terms of great leaders and laziness. There's one, I believe you've listed in your book, who was indeed lazy. Who was that?
- 6.13** Hitler. Hitler was—it's probably a good thing that he was lazy, actually, when everyone thinks about it. But Adolf Hitler, he liked to get up very late in the morning. He would then amble off. If he was at the Wolfsschanze or indeed at the Berghof, he would then wander off to have long teas. He would spend his time, a lot of the time, just poring over maps, not actually moving anyone around, just because he enjoyed poring over maps. He would try to get his underlings to compete against one another. That would be the way that he thought that he was always going to be able to get the best out of people. But of course, as Napoleon also found out, in fact, when you have people competing against one another, it becomes more important than actually doing the job in hand.
- 6.14** Overall, the key thing with somebody like Margaret Thatcher or indeed, George Marshall, was to be the best-informed person in the room. When you go into the meeting, you know more about the fact of the discussion than anybody else in that room, and therefore, you're going to be in a position to dominate it. Yes, I hope nobody comes away from this series thinking that it's easy to be a great leader. It actually requires—it's a classic example of 90% perspiration, 10% inspiration.
- 6.15** The bit I liked that you mentioned there was around being the most informed person in the room before you go into a meeting. Of course, George C. Marshall would go into many meetings with FDR, who relied heavily on him. What was his relationship like with FDR?
- 6.16** He went out of his way not to become yet another of FDR's cronies. FDR did enjoy having an entourage around him, and some of them were very highly impressive figures, Morgenthau and Ickes and others, but he also quite enjoyed having sycophantic yes-men around him. George Marshall was absolutely certain that he was not going to become one of them. In fact, in the very first meeting, when he chose Marshall, which he didn't need to do, because Marshall was way down the list of generals by seniority to become US Army Chief of Staff. He was about the 12th on the list. But FDR spotted that he had the capacity.
- 6.17** He said, and he ended a sentence with something along the lines of, "Don't you agree, George?" And Marshall said, "Mr. President, you must call me general." It was a good way of just essentially making it clear that there were boundaries, and the President was not to cross them. The President used to invite his friends down to Hyde Park in upstate New York, his country house. But the first time that George Marshall ever went

there was for FDR's funeral in April 1945. He was not going to get sucked in to the vortex of friendship, which he felt might compromise his best endeavors as a general.

- 6.18** One of the things that you point out in writing about George C. Marshall is his seemingly natural gift for delegation. How important is delegation to great leadership?
- 6.19** It's very important. We spoke earlier about how important it is to choose good people, but that's not enough. As well as choosing the good people, you have to know how much leeway to give them. You have to know the extent to which you can trust somebody to act independently. Again, Napoleon is a template for this. There are some generals of his, like Davout and Soult and Masséna, who are able to act independently of the Emperor on a battlefield, and quite a few who simply can't. You have to keep under quite close control. When Marshall was looking for generals, he very much wanted them to be able to act independently and to have important aspects delegated. He knew, for example, that in terms of planning, he could allow Dwight D. Eisenhower to undertake a good deal of the planning necessary for the Second World War. But there are other generals like General Wedemeyer, who was particularly good on small things but could not be let loose on the big issues because otherwise he was going to cause trouble, especially with the British.
- 6.20** You've mentioned a few generals there. What did the other generals think of Marshall, both on the Allied side and the Axis side?
- 6.21** Well, a lot of them hated him, not least because he sacked 64 generals in the course of the Second World War. If a general was not —look at Lucas after Anzio, the general after the Battle of Kasserine Pass was also sacked. If a general is not measuring up pretty quickly, then it's very, very bad for the morale of the troops, as well as obviously for the actual conduct of the operation. Marshall was pretty swift at sacking people. But there were others like Devers and McNair and Eisenhower, as we say, Omar Bradley, who he would bring on pretty much regardless of where they were in the list. It had happened to him. He'd been picked in front of 11 other people above him, and he wasn't scared of bringing on somebody who he recognized had real potential, Eisenhower being the classic example of this.
- 6.22** Are there any generals that clashed with Marshall?
- 6.23** Actually, the biggest clash came from Douglas MacArthur, of course. He's always clashing with everybody. But he had a respect for Marshall because he knew that Marshall had the President's ear and that he didn't. There was a political reason why MacArthur admired and respected Marshall. But no, the person he clashed with most was Ernest J. King, the admiral who was the US Navy Chief of Staff. On the joint chiefs, you have these three men, Arnold, supporting Marshall against, essentially, King. They were not over trivial issues. The great discussion was over where the major response was going to take place, because, of course, on the 7th of December 1941, the Japanese attacked the Americans in Pearl Harbor. The Germans hadn't caused any

trouble. They hadn't been sinking American ships, or there was no declaration of war from Adolf Hitler on the 7th of December. It came later on the 11th, but in the immediate aftermath, the American people, understandably, and the Congress and the press, wanted to hit back against the Japanese.

6.24 But the planning that Marshall had been setting in place ever since he'd become US Army Chief of Staff was what was called the Germany First Policy, whereby, under the auspices of the thinking of the great Carl von Clausewitz, if you're in a fight against two opponents, you go for the strongest one first. That 's the key military philosophy. And so, he was very keen to hit Germany with 70% or so of American resources, leaving 30% for the Pacific War. Now, Admiral King, of course, because the Pacific War was going to be a naval war, apart from anything else, wanted to hit the Japanese first. And so there was this huge clash of strategies, and Marshall got it right.

6.25 I think that it was the Germany first policy was pretty much the greatest act of statesmanship, of foresight and statesmanship, of that part of the 20th century, because it meant that the United States was committed, and would commit, to clearing the Germans out of North Africa, which was done by the May of 1943, then jumping over onto Sicily in the July of 1943, then the mainland of Italy in September, which knocked Italy out of the war, and then going up the boot of Italy and capturing Rome the day before D-Day on the sixth of June 1944. So you have this Mediterranean strategy, which Marshall didn 't support much at the beginning, but nonetheless, he knew that you had to take on Germany, and Japan could pretty much take care of itself later on in the war. It was a massive act of statesmanship, really.

6.26 You mentioned Ernest King. We spoke a bit about Patton, and there's, of course, MacArthur. These are individuals with quite a large ego. Marshall himself was a very humble individual. How important is ego management to great leadership?

6.27 Not humble. He wasn't humble, but he was a confident in his own abilities. He was able to deal with the egos of, these raging egos of some of these people. A classic example, obviously, being Monty and Patton, who hated each other and who were in constant races, races across to Messina and Palermo in Sicily. Then obviously, once D-Day had taken place, with Monty going north and Patton going south, and both of them putting enormous pressure on Marshall and Eisenhower to try and draw the largest numbers of resources off into their sectors. Sometimes, when one looks at what they were saying about one another, they, and also Omar Bradley, are more reminiscent of squabbling schoolchildren, frankly, than great generals who were trying to extirpate Nazism.

6.28 These decisions about the allocation of resources have to be made by Marshall in Washington, but also, of course, by Eisenhower in the SHAEF command. They are life-and-death, make-or-break decisions, and they have to be taken on a regular basis. But when you look at the really big grand strategy decisions, those are not taken by Eisenhower; they're taken by Marshall. He is the key figure. What he manages to do is to usually persuade King, sometimes he would slam his fist down on the table. He

didn't do it often, but when he did, Ernest King took notice. The key thing was, of course, for the joint chiefs to speak in a single voice when talking to the President and when talking to the British, because they couldn't afford to allow the joint chiefs to look split, because if that happens, the great advantage would be taken of that. But his support that Hap Arnold gave him on the Joint Chiefs was essential.

- 6.29** How important was George C. Marshall to the creation of the Allied grand strategy?
- 6.30** Very important indeed, even though it wasn't his strategy that initially got adopted. The great debate, really, between the British and the Americans was over the timing of D-Day. When do you cross the Channel? When do you unleash Operation Overlord? Do you do it as early as the fall of 1942, as Marshall wanted, or do you wait until 1943, or as was eventually obviously the case, is it unleashed in the June of 1944? This is the swirling argument that's taking place. The way to see these arguments is through the prism of the four key figures who were going to make the ultimate decision. George Marshall, President Roosevelt, the two Americans, Winston Churchill, and General Alan Brooke, the Chief of the Imperial General Staff and the Chairman of the British Chiefs of Staff. These four men dance a minuet around each other for the key periods.
- 6.31** Sometimes Marshall is—for most of it, actually—Marshall is in favor of an early trans-Channel crossing. But Churchill, who remembers the catastrophe of Gallipoli, of course, and the German capacity for counterattack, and also Brooke, who fought in the great battles of the First World War, including Vimy Ridge, and was present as a general at the time immediately after the retreat from Dunkirk, when the second British Army had to retreat from Cherbourg, he was very conscious—both of the Britons were very conscious—that an overhasty return to the continent could actually elongate the war if the Germans flung the Anglo-American force off the northwest French littoral.
- 6.32** You have this innate disagreement. Fortunately for the British, FDR came down strongly on the side of the British against his own chief of staff, against George Marshall. And that is why you don't get a cross-Channel attack in 1942. What you do get instead, in the November of 1942, is about a quarter of a million American troops landing in North Africa, at various beach points in North Africa, and very quickly establishing a strong foothold there that they're able then to expand. That is the result of partly FDR wanting to get troops actually fighting in Europe before the midterm elections, and also, of course, a hope that this is going to draw down German forces away from where the major fighting is going on, which is in the Eastern Front.
- 6.33** It's very important that we remember—I would say one of the most key statistics of the whole of the Second World War is that for every five Germans killed in combat in the Second World War—I don't mean killed by aerial bombing, I mean actually fighting on battlefields—for every five German soldiers killed on battlefields in the Second World War, four die on the Eastern front. What the Western power is doing, what Britain, America, and Canada is essentially doing, is killing the fifth German. The task is to establish this second front in such a way that it's going to draw troops away from the

Eastern Front. Marshall appreciates this, but he's constantly pushing for an earlier second front in Northwest France than the President, Prime Minister, and Brooke want.

- 6.34** The key moment comes at the conference in Quebec in the May of 1943, when FDR essentially changes sides and insists on there being a date set for D-Day. The date they set is first week in May. It has to be put back five weeks, May 1944, of course. It has to be put back five weeks for the landing craft. There was an issue with the landing craft, and then one extra day, one 24-hour period for the weather. That explains why it was on the 6th of June 1944. The question, of course, has to be, could it have been done earlier? Could this great Clausewitzian battle, this decisive battle, have been fought in northern France between the Germans and the Allied forces, and the whole war essentially shortened by two years? The answer, most historians, certainly my answer, is no.
- 6.35** The fact is that D-Day itself was a risky enough maneuver on the actual day itself. But the idea of doing it before you have the pipeline under the ocean, which created the capacity to refuel the army in France. Before you have the Mulberry harbours, they weren't ready either; before you have victory in the Battle of the Atlantic; before you have the P-51 Mustang fighter, which was able to clear the Luftwaffe from the airs in 1944, early 1945. There's an amazing statistic. On the day of D-Day itself, the 6th of June 1944, when the Luftwaffe were able to fly 318 sorties over Normandy, the Allies were able to fly 13,688. So it was a complete air domination of the Allied forces that day. And that was necessary, if you're going to defeat the Germans. And so anything earlier, I think, than summer of 1944, ran a really serious danger of being defeated and thrown back into the sea, whereupon it would have taken years for the Allies to have got back into a position to cross the Channel.
- 6.36** Of course, in the East, in the August and late summer of 1944, you have the Soviet Army unleashing Operation Bagration, which was able to kill, wound, or capture no fewer than 510,000 Germans in Belarus. So, over half a million Germans. So what's to stop, essentially, Stalin from taking Berlin and then going on? There was nothing between there and Paris. So it was absolutely essential that the Western Allies got the timing right, which they eventually did.
- 6.37** How important was Marshall to the success or the successful operation of the combined Chiefs of Staff?
- 6.38** He was essential. He really was essential because he was able to—first of all, as I say, he's primus inter pares on the Joint Chiefs. He's not the chairman of the Joint Chiefs. That's Admiral Leahy, who is a friend of FDR's, but he has the auctoritas. He is the figure who has this natural authority who can keep Admiral Ernest J. King under control and concentrating on the Pacific with his 30% of resources, whilst the army and air force fight in Europe with the 70% of forces. Then at the same time, he's friendly with Field Marshal Dill, who was the British liaison on the combined chiefs, which is the name given to the chiefs of staff committee of both the Americans and the British. This is the

first time in history that there has been an interwoven, combined chiefs. You don't see it in the First World War or indeed any other earlier war, where two countries essentially get together and have a chiefs of staff committee of all of them, all six of them.

- 6.39** There were rows, huge rows. There were moments where the room would have to be cleared. You'd have a meeting, a classic example being in the Chateau Frontenac in Quebec in 1943, where you would have vice chiefs and assistant chiefs and deputy chiefs. You'd have about 60 people in a room, as well as the actual combined chiefs, the six of them. If they just couldn't agree, the atmosphere would get worse and worse, and sometimes you'd have shouting and so on. It was a Field Marshal Dill who poured the oil over the cranking, crank shafts of the the meetings. He was the person who was able to get people to agree. But there were some times when Brooke and Marshall just said, "Well, clear the room." And so, all of the assistants and vice and deputy chiefs just had to leave the room and stand outside whilst the chiefs of the staff got down to it, essentially.
- 6.40** And the great thing, though, was that it was, although voices were raised, and on one occasion, Wedermeyer said that he wanted to lean across and punch Brooke in the jaw at one point. Overall, this way of being open and arguing it out with the facts and the figures and the logic and so on, that was a far better way of coming to an overall strategy than what was going on in the Wolfsschanze, 1,800 miles behind the Russian front, where the Führer would listen to his various generals, people who, by the way, had far better strategic sense than he. You have men like Guderian and Rommel and Rundstedt and Manstein. These generals, they 'd fought in the First World War, they'd gone to Staff College, they understood grand strategy. And yet they had this corporal who was overruling them.
- 6.41** But what Hitler would do was, and we know exactly how these Führer conferences worked, because after the Reichstag fire, all the stenographers who had been taking down every word that was said in the Reichstag instead were moved into the Führer conferences, and they took down everything that was said there. So you have volumes upon volumes of every word that was said. And it's clear from them that what would happen is the Führer would listen to any one of these generals who, as I say, were far better qualified to speak on strategy and grand strategy than him, and would listen for maybe up to an hour. Then at the end, he would say, "Thank you very much indeed. No, we're actually going to do what I said at the beginning."
- 6.42** That's a pretty terrible way of—it's not interacting. I mean, it's the classic dictator's way of deciding strategy. The interesting thing is that what Stalin was doing at the same time, after having suffered something approaching a mental breakdown at the opening scenes of Barbarossa, where he went off to his dacha outside Moscow, and and was unable to act, it was only once the politburo had gone to the dacha and said, "No, you are our great leader and you must lead us," that he adopted a much more Western

view of how to run grand strategy. So he listened to Marshall's, Zhukov, and Konev, and Rokossovsky and others, and actually allowed them to take most of the big strategic decisions. Obviously, they couldn't take any political decisions because he was a paranoid dictator. But with regard to the military decisions, Stalin acted much more like the combined chiefs of staff than what was going on in East Prussia with Adolf Hitler.

- 6.43** What you just spoke about here, it elicits a classic question within political science and international relations. The question is, are democracies better at waging war than dictatorship?
- 6.44** They are not better at starting wars because, of course, dictatorship have got the advantage of being able to undertake surprise attacks. When one looks actually also in the postwar period, in the 1940s, you've got —the incredible thing is how many surprise attacks there are in military history. 1940s, you have Pearl Harbor. 1950s, you have the North Vietnamese attack over the 38th parallel into—sorry, not Vietnamese, North Korean attack on South Korea. The 1970s, you have the Arab attacks on Israel in Yom Kippur. 1980s, the Falklands invasion comes out of a clear blue sky in 1982. You have 9/11, of course. Most recently, these monstrous attacks on southern Israel from Gaza. All of these surprise attacks, all of them coming from authoritarian or totalitarian regimes.
- 6.45** But what they tend to do, historically, is to light a fire under the country that has been subjected to the surprise attack. It usually doesn't work out very well for the attacker. There is one great exception to that rule, which is, of course, Israel's attack in the Six-Day War in 1967, which is a democracy that carries out a surprise attack, but only because it was quite clear that they were going to be attacked themselves.
- 6.46** There's a marvelous line from Paul Wolfowitz, who said that "surprise attacks happen so often in history that the surprising thing is we're still surprised by them. " That very much is the case. The reason, therefore, that totalitarian countries aren't so good at winning wars as democracies is that, at least not so far in history, thank God, is that the decision-making process tends to be much better in a democracy where it's more rational, it's more logical. You see this very much with the combined chiefs of staff. Yes, they do have rows, but in the end, the decisions that are taken are taken as a result of the interaction between military experts and elected politicians, and they tend to be much better.
- 6.47** Now, we spoke about Marshall as a logician, understanding the logistics of operations with the relation to the Second World War, but of course, managing the egos of generals. Another bit we could also talk about is his role in dealing with politics within the US. How did he deal with Congress?
- 6.48** He had a rule that whenever a politician came to him and asked him to be put in harm's way, he said yes. Whenever a politician came to him and asked that his cousin or nephew or son should be taken out of harm's way, he said no. He was very tough on

that. He despised those politicians who tried to use their political position to either advance their friends or family. It's extraordinary how often this happened, in fact. Now, there had been a long history, of course, in American politics, of being involved in military affairs. General Grant, of course, was President. But it was not something he encouraged. He very much thought that Congress should be reported to, but shouldn't actually have a major say in what the strategy was going to be. He was very good at basically keeping politicians arm's length. Yes, he would turn up to the Senate hearings, and he would tell them as much as he possibly could that wasn't operationally sensitive. He was a proper democrat in that sense, but he wasn't going to allow political pressures to decide what American strategy was going to be.

- 6.49** Now, the thing about Marshall is that he could have been promoted to Allied Supreme Commander, but he turned it down. Was he disappointed?
- 6.50** Yes, he was, but he recognized that he had to stay in Washington. The President actually said to him, FDR said to him, that he didn't think he could sleep with Marshall no longer in Washington. Whether or not that's a bit of hyperbole on FDR's case, I wonder. But nonetheless, he was persuaded that his position was indispensable as US Army Chief of Staff in DC. That's how Ike got the job. Now, there was a slight complication in that Lord Alan Brooke was, he thought at least, offered the job at least three times by Winston Churchill. But the trouble was that, by the May of 1943, that Quebec conference that I mentioned to you, by that stage, the job had to go to an American.
- 6.51** The statistics are remarkable. In the calendar year 1944, when the British produced 28,000 warplanes and the Russians and Germans produced 40,000 warplanes each, the United States was producing no fewer than 98,000 warplanes, almost as much as the whole of the rest of the world put together. They were churning out Liberty ships at the rate of one a day. They had an extraordinary industrial capacity that essentially meant that they were producing four times the amount of material as Britain. Of course, it was going to ultimately be an American, plus they were going to be more Americans than Britons and Canadians put together in the Overlord operation. So quite how Brooke persuaded himself that he was going to be asked to command it, I still haven't quite worked out, even though I've written a book on the subject. But it wasn't going to happen, frankly. It was either going to be Marshall or, in the case of Marshall turning it down, it was going to be whoever Marshall wanted it to be. And that was Eisenhower.
- 6.52** One of the rather unique things about Marshall is—
- 6.53** Sorry, can I just butt in? Of course, the result was that not only that Eisenhower eventually became President, but also when one thinks of the number of streets and malls and towns and golf clubs and any number of things that are named after Eisenhower—had it not been for FDR, all of those things would have been named after General George C. Marshall.

- 6.54** Now, it's funny you mention that. I think that's a great segue into the question I was going to ask you. Marshall is incredibly unique for this seemingly obliviousness to fame. Can you speak more to that and the role it plays in great leadership?
- 6.55** Yes. I mean, quite a lot of these world leaders who we've been talking about are obsessed with fame. They want to be famous for all time. With people like Julius Caesar and Napoleon, of course, they're right. They are, and will be. But it takes a particular type of greatness not to worry about that thing, but to concentrate entirely on the job in hand, which is what George Marshall did. He didn't really care about whether or not he was ultimately going to be famous. What he cared about was winning the war and bringing the war to a conclusion as quickly as possible. And there's a true greatness in that. Of course, there is. And it's one that I think ought to be emulated.
- 6.56** So he's the type of individual that wants to be in the right place at the right time to do the job that he's meant to do.
- 6.57** Precisely, yes. He had an ego. Of course, he did. You don't get to be US Army Chief of Staff during the second, the entirety of the Second World War and deal with the press and deal with the Congress and deal with the President of the United States, and then afterwards, obviously, also with President Truman, unless you've got a pretty good, strong, powerful ego. But what he wasn't obsessed with was being on the front page of Time magazine or being Time Man of the Year or any of that thing, which is quite ironic because ultimately, he did, in fact, get the Nobel Peace Prize, which he fully deserved, although it wasn't for his command in the Second World War. That was for something else.
- 6.58** Yeah. Just touching on that now, he won the Nobel Peace Prize in 1953 for something called the Marshall Plan?
- 6.59** The Marshall Plan, yes, exactly.
- 6.60** Or at least the award was largely given to him because of the Marshall Plan. Could you explain what that is?
- 6.61** Well, he became Secretary of State in the post-war period. He had a very, very difficult time of it because he was there at the time of the Chinese Civil War, and he recognized that the Guomindang Nationalist Forces were not going to win under Chiang Kai-shek. Therefore, he pulled the support for, American support, from them, which, of course, helped the Maoist Communists to win. But he only did it at the stage where he recognized that Chiang Kai-shek didn't have a chance of winning. But it was held very much against him for that. He's supposed to have let the Chinese win, which was held against him. He was criticized for it, not least by Senator Joe McCarthy.
- 6.62** But he was also responsible for this, in 1948, this very far-sighted plan, the Marshall Plan, which was basically to give Western Europe—Russia was offered it, but Stalin turned it down—give \$15.5 billion, which is worth about \$173 billion in today's money,

to Western economies in order to strengthen them, of course, in the terrible austerity of the immediate post-war period, to thereby create employment, and therefore, hopefully and successfully, stop communism, stop the spread of communism in Western Europe. It was a huge investment. There were a lot of people who were very much against it. The American Firsters thought it was a bad idea to essentially transfer American cash to German, Italian, French, and British governments. But it did what it was intended to do. It also actually, as part of the plan, they broke down various tariff barriers and made free trade easier, which ultimately worked enormously to the United States' advantage.

- 6.63** One of the unique roles of a historian is to think about counterfactuals. What do you think the world would have been like had the Marshall Plan not been implemented?
- 6.64** Well, I love counterfactuals. They're a bit of a parlor game. Of course they are. You can't prove whether you're right or wrong. But I do think that they're worthwhile because they remind you that there are lots of ways that history could have gone differently, and that very often these great leaders who we're talking about are not making choices of two easy choices. They're usually two very difficult choices, and they are often taken to stop the worst-worst option as opposed to the second-worst option. I think with regard to the Marshall Plan, Italy came very close to having Communist governments in the immediate post-war period. As we know, it's had over 70 different governments in that 80 or so years, anyhow. And so the instability of Italy would have been hugely increased.
- 6.65** The other danger was France, frankly. France came close. There were several ministers, and they were very fortunate to have de Gaulle, who was, of course, very anti-Communist, but France had several ministries where there were six or seven Communist, openly Communist, cabinet ministers. So, I think that if there had been a general economic collapse in Western Europe in the late 1940s, early 1950s, then Communism, which, of course, had a very good name at the time because of all the blood that the Russians had shared defeating the Nazis. There are 27 million or so Russians that died in the Second World War. It would have been extremely difficult to have saved Western capitalism and essentially Western civilization.
- 6.66** I think that's a really great answer. In terms of—
- 6.67** Thank you.
- 6.68** Phenomenal details. Excellent. Historians and counterfactuals. Just moving back now to Marshall. Is there anything else that he's known for doing in the post-war period?
- 6.69** Well, he got his Nobel Prize for the Marshall Plan. As I say, he was attacked by Joe McCarthy. President Eisenhower could have actually done more to stick by his old boss. And there's one moment where he gave a speech during the 1952 presidential election, general election, where he cut out a paragraph in support of Marshall, which, considering everything that Marshall had done for him over the years, I think was a low

moment for Ike, who otherwise was a great man, as we're going to be discussing soon. But yes, Marshall was a giant of the day. He was the organizer of victory, and he definitely earned his place amongst the great leaders.

- 6.70 What was the rationale for Eisenhower cutting out that paragraph?
- 6.71 Because he feared that Joe McCarthy was so popular, especially in the Midwest, in the 1952 election, that he might be turned on by McCarthy just when he needed Republican votes.
- 6.72 Given Marshall's understated nature and the fact that he is not as well-known among the eight that we're going to discuss over the course of this course, is that because he was a logician? Is it the case that individuals that focus on strategy and logistics are more reserved or downplayed?
- 6.73 Well, no, he just didn't push himself forward. Also, in a sense, yes, I mean, battlefield commanders are always more well-known than the people who are choosing where the battlefields are going to be, which countries are going to be invaded. But there is a struggle amongst the staffs. There's a marvelous line from the historian called Lewin, a British historian, who says that "there is no law of war that says that men can die in battle, but the staff officers should not be vexed." Ronald Lewin. Staff officers were vexed. You did have these great clashes deciding, and of course you did, because the decisions they were taking could lead to the deaths of thousands or even tens of thousands of men. It's right that they should all be putting that amount of work in, and that they should be passionate, and that they should be arguing their cases. But luckily, it was ultimately a logic and rationality that saw the decisions that were ultimately taken, which is simply not the case in dictatorships, and especially not in Adolf Hitler's.
- 6.74 We can title this session, "George C. Marshall and the Genius of Organization." He was indeed a genius of organizing things. What does it take to be a master logician?
- 6.75 Immense hard work, of course. High intelligence. A lot of experience. He'd been doing this since the First World War. It takes a great deal of teamwork. He had around him a brilliant set of people. Actually, funny enough, when you visit his grave in Arlington Cemetery, many of the key figures who he worked with in the Second World War and before the Second World War to carry out this amazing organization are buried around him. There's a group of brilliant generals who decided that they wanted to be buried in the same area as General Marshall.
- 6.76 That's a wonderful detail. Now, moving to the final question of the session, what is the single greatest lesson we can take away from George C. Marshall?
- 6.77 This concept of organization, that in order to have an army fight a battle, especially overseas, you have to have a Rubik's cube of a brain, constantly working out how to get the men from their villages and towns all across the United States, how to physically get them into camps that you have to build, how to train them, how to take troops

from out of the regular army in order to do the training, how to make sure that they have the right uniforms, the right number of boots, the equipment, the right number of weapons, and the ammunition for that, and to bring that all together, without even regarding things like feeding them and so on. Then you've got to get them abroad and have the transport to do that with regard to defending it from submarines and the enemy. Then you've got to get them actually onto the beaches successfully. We see in so many amphibious operation, after amphibious operation, it's the most difficult thing to do in war. Look at Anzio, look at Salerno, look at Gallipoli, how difficult that is.

6.78 Then once you 're there, you've got to be able to provide them with the fuel and the ammunition and so on. You've got to do this whilst you're under attack. It 's just the most difficult thing to do in warfare. And yet, Marshall was able to ensure that by the time that actually did take place, with the hundreds of thousands of people—there was 1.1 million troops were ashore by D+30 in June 1944, in this case, early July 1944—they did so with complete air superiority, with the minimum number of people drowning in the Atlantic because the Battle of the Atlantic had been won. What essentially happened was that, in December 1942, the Germans added an extra router to the Ultra machine, the decrypting, sorry, the encryption machine, which was being decrypted, of course, at Bletchley Park. Suddenly, therefore, the whole of the—sorry, this was the January of 1942—the whole of the decrypts that they'd been getting up to that point just turned into complete gobbledygook.

6.79 It wasn't until the boffins at Bletchley Park were able to break back into the German Shark code in the December of 1942 that you could work out where the German wolf packs, U-boat wolf packs, were in the Atlantic. That's what allowed them, therefore, to win the Battle of the Atlantic by the summer, late summer, of 1943. Until that point, there was no point in trying to conduct a cross-Channel attack, because if you did get the army across into northwest France, you wouldn't necessarily be able to resupply it. The whole of southern England, by 1944, was one massive supply dump for D-Day. This all had to come out of the brain of the the D-Day planners, of course, in London under Eisenhower, but also in the big picture, from the mind of this extraordinary organizer of victory, General George C. Marshall.

6.80 Extraordinary. Thank you. We can move now to the audience for questions.

6.81 You outlined that George C. Marshall had both a remarkable ability, a detail-oriented ability, to pay attention to those details and to organization, and that he was quite deeply involved with broader strategy and so, basically, a vision for how to conduct the war. Could you speak more to the relationship between those two different abilities, both being detail-oriented and having a vision, and whether, for example, both are necessary to be a great leader?

6.82 Oh, yes, they certainly are. There's not a lot of point in having a great vision and then not being able to see it through, or not knowing how to begin to see it through. Equally, there's very little point in being absolutely brilliant at seeing something through and

not knowing what it is that you want to see through. So, no, in each of these leaders that we talk about, especially people like Caesar, Napoleon, and Churchill, you have to have the big picture, as well as the capacity to see it implemented.

6.83 You see this, by the way, in the Belfer Center at Yale, which has a leadership study program. General David Petraeus, the former commander of coalition forces in Iraq and Afghanistan, has formulated a four -part study of strategic leadership, of what you need to do. The first one is to get the big idea right. The next thing is to be able to communicate it throughout the length and breadth of the organization. Then it's to see the implementation of the big idea by everybody. Then, crucially, because the enemy has a say, to continually refine it, and to keep refining it again and again and again, until victory is won. And so, yes, it's fine to be good at numbers one and two, but you also have to be good at three and four.

6.84 Hi, Dr. Roberts. I was just wondering if you could speak a bit about what his opinions regarding American foreign policy towards the Soviet Union in the immediate aftermath of the war, where I 've read it was rumored that Patton, for instance, favored a far more openly belligerent stance towards the Soviet Union right after Germany was defeated. Did Marshall also have similar opinions to that?

6.85 George Patton went a bit mad, frankly, at the end of the Second World War. It was obviously a great, tragic moment when he died in the traffic accident in December 1945. But by that stage, he had become so virulently anti-Russian that he was all set for a full-on war against the Russians, which would have been catastrophic because the Russians had 13 million men under arms. There is simply no way in the political sense of the day that nuclear weapons could be used against them. Patton really was, essentially, pretty much out of it. A much more sensible containment policy was the one that the West agreed on, which Marshall was very much in favor of. He wasn't as anything like so far advanced as Winston Churchill was, who obviously in March 1946 started warning openly against Stalin and the Soviet Union. That was a tremendous act of foresight and statesmanship. Marshall wasn't there.

6.86 What he was much more concerned about, of course, as I mentioned earlier, was China. He was criticized heavily for having essentially pulled the American support for China. But actually, historically, it's very rare that outside efforts affect civil wars to the degree that they actually change who's going to win or lose. Spanish Civil War, yes, the Condor Legion and the Italians helped General Franco, but they were not a decisive factor. The Russian Civil War had interventions, major interventions, from 17 different countries to try to strangle Bolshevism in its cradle, and they all failed. You can mention several other ones as well. I don't think the Chinese Civil War, even if you'd had American troops on the ground, which was never in the offing, would have gone the other way. There are lots of reasons, and we were just mentioning earlier about strategic leadership with that gentleman. In fact, the strategic leadership was so bad by Chiang Kai-shek that, by 1948-49, they had no hope of winning that war.

Lecture 7: Eisenhower's Ethics

At a glance — Dwight D. Eisenhower and the ethics of command.

- 7.1** Now, Dr. Roberts, in this session, we're going to be talking about Dwight D. Eisenhower. And the first question I want to present to you is with regard to having experience in battle. How important is it to have combat experience to becoming a great leader?
- 7.2** Surprisingly unimportant, actually. It's important to have the imagination about what the troops need and want and what you need to give them. But actually, as we've seen with George Marshall, who didn't command troops in combat, and with Dwight Eisenhower, later on we're going to be talking about Margaret Thatcher, these people actually have not done over the top. They haven't commanded a battalion or divisional or corps or army level. The interesting thing is that there are very few great leaders who are good at commanding at each of those levels. We've established earlier that General Grant was one, and the Duke of Wellington was another, but it's a very rare capacity to be able to command at each of those levels. And of course, there are some people who haven't commanded at any of them, but still are extremely important and useful commanders.
- 7.3** And what does that say about Eisenhower, specifically?
- 7.4** Well, that he was an amazing trainer of men, and that although I'm sure, were he to have fought in the First World War, actually in the trenches, he'd have done tremendously well. Ditto George Marshall. But because he was so good at what he did, which was training troops back in the United States, they kept him back.
- 7.5** Do you find that there can be a friction between, let's say, the average line soldier and a general, if the general hasn't had much experience in combat?
- 7.6** Yes, of course, it's something that might be held against them, but if they're staff officers, then that's unlikely to have any actual sort of deep-rooted problem.
- 7.7** What was Eisenhower's great self-realization moment?
- 7.8** Oh, it was Fort Leavenworth when he was there at the staff college and he passed out the top of 245 cadets. I mean, that really is an extraordinary achievement. And that's his moment in his early twenties when he recognizes that he really is destined for greatness.
- 7.9** So you speak about his military experience while in the academy. Could you speak about his childhood or his upbringing?
- 7.10** Yes, well, his mother was a pacifist. This is an interesting aspect in that she didn't want him to go to the army at all and thought that the whole thing was monstrous. And he struck out and essentially went his own way. There's a magnificent presidential library that he has in Abilene and it's well worth visiting. And you can see the hardscrabble

existence that the Eisenhowers had, as a family when he was growing up. But he was, largely through sports, able to carve his own way and make a name for himself, even before he joined the army.

- 7.11 What sports exactly?
- 7.12 He was football, was his big—
- 7.13 This is not the UK or the European football.
- 7.14 This is American US football.
- 7.15 For international audience.
- 7.16 Yes. No, absolutely, yes. No, in Kansas, they didn't play much soccer in the 1890s. It was a—he was an extremely useful player, but he was also an inspirational coach. And, of course, that is just full of leadership lessons, isn't it?
- 7.17 Yes. So you can see that there's a foundation here, at least you're drawing a foundation between his participation sports and then his participation as a war leader. Do you trace a line between those two?
- 7.18 It's possible to, yes. I mean, the concepts of leadership do overlap. The way in which one tries to enthuse a team, of course, is not a million miles away from when you're trying to enthuse a military unit.
- 7.19 Right. Why don't we delve into the strengths of Eisenhower? What do you identify as his key strengths?
- 7.20 The people liked him. One of the—that really does help. It's not just by luck that, when he ran for president, people wore buttons saying, "I like Ike." They did. And they had a good reason to, as well. I mean, he was a hugely likable person, and this was invaluable in the diplomatic side of his job. One thinks, of course, with these military leaders, about the military side of it. But if you're fighting coalition warfare, you have to be a diplomat as well. Going back to the concept of the strategos, who was a soldier, a politician, and a diplomat, and the strategi were expected to go off and make peace treaties and threaten war and so on. It's an important part of one's duty, and it was certainly a very important part of his duty as commander-in-chief of the Allied forces in Europe.
- 7.21 You touched on an important concept there, coalition fighting. Could you talk a bit more about that, as it relates to Eisenhower? How did he pursue coalition fighting during the Second World War?
- 7.22 Well, he basically told his staffs that it was all right to say that somebody was a son of a bitch, but you couldn't say that he was an American son of a bitch or a British son of a bitch. The key thing was that he was constantly playing down the inevitable frictions that one would get in coalition combat. There's a great line from Alan Brooke's diaries, where he says that "there's only one thing worse than fighting with allies, and that's

fighting without them." And that became very true at key moments of the Second World War. But overall, when one thinks about it, to have two countries work in such close proximity, and to have got on quite so well, and obviously, partly it was because the alternative was so horrific, but nonetheless—both the fascist and the communist alternative—but there was something innate, even by 1941, about the special relationship. It had existed for over 40 years, since the Hay-Pauncefote Treaty of 1900. So you did have a sense of these two peoples being able to get on, but that had to work on the personal level as well.

- 7.23** And the thing about Eisenhower was that he wasn't just liked in America, but he was liked in Britain as well. Alan Brooke, who is rude about him very often in his diaries, always says, but nonetheless, "He is a charming gentleman, and I like him personally." Winston Churchill got on very well with him as well. He had that capacity, even though he had to bang heads together on a regular basis. And you have men like George Patton, who called him Deedee. He was annoyed, really, Patton, that he had fought so much, in both the First World War and the Second World War. And here was this person who was appointed above him, who had only really fired a shot in anger when he shot a rat at his headquarters in Caserta, in Italy.
- 7.24** So in terms of the Allied war effort, the coalition between the British and the Americans, would you say that not having an Eisenhower there would have been disastrous for the Allies?
- 7.25** It would have been, yes. Which is why, say, if George Marshall had taken on that job of Operation Overlord, he would have had to have done the same kind of thing in terms of diplomacy as Eisenhower did. And it was also the reason why, frankly, you couldn't have Montgomery, who was too anti-American, and you couldn't have George Patton, who was too anti-Montgomery. And Omar Bradley didn't quite also fit the overall picture either. Mark Clark was a perfectly competent general, but he wasn't of that level. You had to have somebody who clearly was above the others, otherwise they wouldn't take orders and follow the Supreme Allied Commander. So it was a sort of Eisenhower-shaped job that he was sort of destined to fill.
- 7.26** Interesting. Now, there's a name that you touched on there, who was the last great leader that we just spoke about, this being George C. Marshall. What is the relationship like between George C. Marshall and Dwight D. Eisenhower?
- 7.27** Well, it starts off as very much a protégé one, a mentor-protégé. And so, what happens is that Marshall appoints Eisenhower to, in vertiginous speed, he goes up several levels in only two years. And he sent off, of course, to command in Gibraltar, to oversee the North African campaign. And so Eisenhower establishes himself very early on as being the top American commander. And, you know, there are some nasty reverses. The battle of Kasserine Pass, for example, is an American defeat, and it's the first of the major battles in North Africa. But nonetheless, Eisenhower learns very quickly on the job, as does the whole of the US army.

- 7.28** Now, you mentioned there that Eisenhower climbed the ranks fairly quickly. He was promoted from, essentially, from the very bottom to the very top in a short period of time. Why was that the case for him, specifically, that he was promoted so quickly?
- 7.29** Because he was very good. You know, he had a very good, strong strategic sense. He also was very fortunate, a little bit later, on to have Walter Bedell Smith to, or "Beetle", as he was nicknamed, Beetle Smith, to be his chief of staff. And here we go back to Napoleon and Berthier and, to a sense, General Pershing and George Marshall, being able to choose a really good chief of staff, somebody who is able to turn your thoughts and your plans into actual orders, written orders, that go to the right person at the right time. That is an essential prerequisite of leadership. You get it with Winston Churchill as well, with Pug Ismay, his military chief of staff. It really does, it speaks to what we were mentioning earlier about choosing good people, but it's an absolutely key role. And Beetle Smith was first class at it.
- 7.30** Now, I want to shift gears and talk about his participation in the Second World War. Now, the force under his command was daunting, wasn't it?
- 7.31** It was huge. I mean, the size of the overall command that he had was 91 divisions. He had 28,000 warplanes under him. He was in charge, ultimately, of 4.5 million men, of whom 3.5 were American and the rest were British, Canadian, and so on. These are vast multitudes. And as well as all of that, of course, he was in charge of making sure that the stores that were kept throughout southern England were able to be deployed in the right places for the attack. He had to consider the overall strategy of what's called narrow thrust versus broad front. Do you go forward into Germany on a very broad front, which is necessarily going to be slow, or do you have certain narrow thrusts that push deep into Germany? And, of course, Patton and Montgomery both wanted narrow thrusts commanded by them. But Eisenhower had to consider the dangers of German counterattack.
- 7.32** When I went up to Cambridge University and was taught by Professor Norman Stone, he said that there's nothing inevitable in history. It's very important one should, when writing history, thinking about history, nothing is inevitable because anything happened. Nothing is inevitable, except for German counterattack. That really is inevitable. And when one looks at Caen, when one looks at Anzio, of course, again and again in the Western desert, a lot in Russia as well, the capacity for the Germans to effect a strategic withdrawal and then a counterattack is pretty extraordinary. And you do see this with the one attempted narrow thrust, which is, of course, Operation Market Garden, the bridge too far at Arnhem, which Montgomery was very much behind, and which failed. And so, as a result, Montgomery's demand for narrow thrusts was weakened, and Eisenhower's belief in the broad front strategy was advanced.
- 7.33** That itself, in a sense, came from one of the all-time great German counterattacks in history, which, of course, is the Battle of the Bulge, where the Germans instituted a 39 divisional surprise attack. Back to this thing about totalitarian powers being able to

carry out surprise attacks, they didn't, the Germans didn't vouchsafe any of the orders over the airwaves because they had clocked that the Allies were able to listen to their communications. They didn't know that they were able to break, that they'd broken the Ultra code, but they guessed that they could listen to things over the radio. So all orders were handed physically by motorbike, rather than put over the airwaves. They attacked in deep snow, at night, using searchlights to beam light off against the clouds. They did it when the weather was so bad that the Allies couldn't carry out reconnaissance and then also couldn't carry out bombing.

- 7.34** And they managed to push almost as far as the Meuse River. I mean, they were within reaching distance of the Channel. And this was in December 1944. This was five months, six months after D-Day. The capacity of the Reich for counterattack was extraordinary. It was going to be the last one, of course, but nonetheless, it was something that threw the Allies, and obviously Eisenhower, off-balance for a matter of weeks.
- 7.35** Now, the Battle of the Bulge, as you're describing here, was a very messy affair. How exactly, or did it, test the limits of Eisenhower's leadership capabilities?
- 7.36** No, he was up to it. In the short term, he did give the command over to Montgomery and allowed Montgomery to command American troops, and Montgomery did manage to essentially halt the attack. And, of course, once the weather cleared and the Allied bombers were able to pinpoint where the Germans were, they were pushed back. And ultimately, it was a costly defeat for the Germans. But no, Ike stayed calm. And this is one of the things that was very much part of his persona, the calmness. And we've spoken a lot about calmness in crises and the importance of that to great leadership.
- 7.37** Even though he had a quite extraordinary heart rate. It was running at 176 over 110, which is very, very high. It's essentially stage two hypertension. He was smoking 40 cigarettes a day. He was, therefore physically under immense pressure, but he didn't show it. The calmness, the good nature. When he got together with the paratroops before they left for D-Day, you see this smiling, confident figure which, as I say, it's the quintessence of leadership.
- 7.38** Yes. Now, just touching on that point, why exactly was he selected as the supreme commander in Europe?
- 7.39** Well, you couldn't select any of the others because they all hated each other and that's not a good way to run a war. He was considered to have done well in North Africa. He wasn't too heavily involved in the Sicily, Italy side of the Mediterranean. The British alternative, General Jumbo Wilson, wasn't the right man for the job for one reason or another. And all in all, it was going to be Ike, not least because George Marshall believed in him. So there were political reasons. And also he was well-known to the British because, of course, he'd been on the planning side in the Pentagon for years, where he'd been interacting with the British, and everyone liked him. And so, as a sort

of chairman of the board, and this is how he described himself, as a kind of chairman of the board, he was the ideal person at the ideal time.

7.40 What can you tell us about Operation Overlord and Ike's role in it?

7.41 That he was absolutely central to it, that it was he who had to take the key decision for it to go on the 6th of June. So he put back the whole expedition by 24 hours because of the weather. But he had to take that key decision for it to go. And he actually had written a resignation letter which he kept in his pocket. And it was only at the end of the success of Overlord that his ADC, Harry Butcher, found it in his pocket and gave it to him. And it's quite a moving resignation letter because he takes the entire responsibility for the defeat onto his own shoulders. And it was an honorable thing to have done, but nonetheless, to have coordinated all of those troops, and as I say, the statistics are amazing — 28,000 planes, nearly a million vehicles, 18 million tons of kit.

7.42 They had bombed Normandy throughout the April and dropped 81,400 tons of bombs on Normandy, killing, unfortunately, an awful lot of French civilians. And, of course, they also had to bomb Pas-de-Calais because if they only bombed Normandy, it would be clear to the Germans that that was where the attack was going to take place. So there's heavy bombing of Pas-de-Calais as well, where the attack was not going to take place. And so, yes, he was, although he didn't do the very initial planning, he was the person who oversaw it and, ultimately, obviously, saw it through once they landed.

7.43 You mentioned this idea of responsibility and him having this letter in his pocket and bearing the weight of responsibility. Are there any politicians, or even just thinking of politicians just in general, that bear that weight of responsibility and are able to take on full responsibility in today's political world?

7.44 Today's political world? Well, responsibility does tend to go up and up the line. I think today, though, if somebody had been defeated in a massive military operation, they would be either forced out of office or resigned. One still has a sense of that. You do also in business, of course, as well. You see resignations because of complete screw-ups in business. It's just rare in politics, which is the place, actually, by the way, that most people want to see resignations take place. But, yes, I think a sense of personal responsibility for mistakes and errors is an important aspect of leadership as well, of course.

7.45 And under that, or within that notion of responsibility, he was indeed a man that bore the weight of great responsibility, as I said. I want to read a quote, in fact, a letter, an excerpt from a letter he wrote to his wife, Mamie. And it goes, "How many youngsters are gone forever? A man must develop a veneer of callousness that lets him consider such things dispassionately," unquote. Can you speak to this quote, particularly the words there around callousness and dispassionate?

7.46 Yes. A lot of his most inner feelings are either to be found in Harry Butcher's diary or in his letters to Mamie Eisenhower. And there is a strong sense of the need not

necessarily to show callousness, but not to sort of break under pressure, not to—Winston Churchill can burst into tears. President Eisenhower absolutely could not. It would not be what one expects from your Supreme Allied Commander. And I think, but I think callousness is a surprising word for him to have used in that sentence because people don't think of him as a callous figure. But these decisions that he's taking can lead, or did lead, to massive loss of life. It was inevitable as part of the job.

7.47 And so you do get this amongst some of the chief staff officers in the Second World War, both the British and the American ones, where you have to put on a carapace. This was something that you see occasionally in the Alan Brooke diaries. He kept a daily diary throughout the Second World War. And there were some times when his friends were being killed, when, of course, George Marshall lost his own stepson, his beloved stepson, in a tank battle in Italy. And the emotions are there. They are human, they are natural, but they can't be allowed in public to be seen to master the individual. That's where the kind of Victorian stiff upper lip thing comes in.

7.48 You see it a lot, of course, also in the First World War. There's a terrible moment where Ambassador Page, the American ambassador in, I think, 1917, says that he had large numbers of people come to him. This is before the Americans entered the war in April 1917, of British people come to him and ask whether or not they could, through the good offices of the American consulate in Germany, find out what happened to their sons. And he said that mothers would visit him and say, "Could you find out what's happened to the son?" And Page was absolutely devastated by this job. And he said that nobody cried. Although they were obviously under immense emotional stress, these sort of Edwardian matrons held themselves because they didn't want to be seen to be crying in the presence of a stranger.

7.49 A remarkable quality to have in a leader. But it seems that you're identifying a very thin line here between being truly callous and not appearing to be callous. And how does one cultivate that?

7.50 Well, I mean, by not being callous. It does help enormously if these people are, in this case with Eisenhower, have a rigid sense of duty, a sense of the code of honor of the United States army, which he was obviously inculcated with from a fairly early age. In his case, also a belief in God was something which was helpful to him. There were a number of things that he could fall back on to ensure that, despite the horrors of what he saw, they weren't going to mean that he wasn't going to be able to operate efficiently, doing the job he knew needed to be done, which was, of course, to destroy the German military capacity in France and later Germany.

7.51 We've spoken about Ike's military career. Why don't we shift to his political career? Can you talk a bit about his role as president?

7.52 Yes. Well, here we go again with the strategos concept. You know, he's the diplomat, he's the soldier, but he's also the politician, and he is, essentially, not in the slightest bit

ideological. You know, he could have run as a Democrat, frankly, just as easily as a Republican. He was the president of Columbia University when he was drafted to be the Republican nominee and candidate for president. And he also very much governed as a centrist. There are many useful and important things that he did. The great highways of America are down to him, for example. But they were never particularly ideological things, you know. That was an aspect of American politics that was not a huge vote-winner back in the 1950s. Not only that, of course, but he was opposed by Adlai Stevenson, who was a hugely impressive, and one forgets him now because he lost on the two occasions that he stood, which were very unfortunate for him, standing against a beloved national figure like Eisenhower in both 1952 and 1956. But he also wasn't a particularly left-wing figure, even in the context of the day.

7.53 Now, we've already established that Dwight D. Eisenhower was a great general, a great politician, and, of course, a tremendous diplomat. Was he the last, or is he the last, great strategos?

7.54 Yes, in terms of being president and a soldier in American terms, absolutely he was. He managed to sort of weaponize his likability, which is, I mean, obviously nobody wants to be unlikable if you're standing for public office. That's not the, that's not the point. But you do have to, as we established earlier, and the fact that he could have stood for either political party is a testament to his auctoritas, that sense of political authority. But he was also somebody who managed to sort of parlay this likability into politics without, at the same time, just going along with the flow and without just doing whatever opinion polls wanted him to. There are some occasions, such as the one we spoke about, where he excised that paragraph about George Marshall in his speech, in one of his electoral addresses, where he certainly did take into account what the voters were thinking in a way that was, frankly, ignoble. But overall, he was a proper leader. He didn't consider his job just to do whatever the opinion polls wanted him to do.

7.55 And in your mind, are there any politicians or leaders that have that natural likability, similar to Ike?

7.56 Likability? It's quite a difficult thing to pull off because, of course, one of the reasons that people liked him was that hundreds of thousands of them had served under him in battle in the Second World War, and they'd won. So it's much easier to like a victorious general who you've served under than just somebody who's thrown up by a political system. So, no, there's nobody really of that level that I can think of, at least offhand.

7.57 Right. When we think about Eisenhower today, and especially within the American context, how do Americans look at Dwight D. Eisenhower? What was his legacy?

7.58 Oh, I think it's tremendously high. He always comes out as one of the most popular statesmen. He was there at a difficult time, of course. He was president when General Nasser nationalized the Suez Canal, when the Soviets put down the Hungarian uprising. It wasn't an easy time. The opening scenes of Indochina and the Vietnam war were

starting to be moved towards. He wasn't in favor of moving large numbers of troops to Vietnam. He asked Winston Churchill about it, and Churchill said he'd never heard of Vietnam and certainly wasn't going to send any troops there. Ditto Cambodia. So he has a high reputation still. And as I said, the number of malls and public spaces named after him. The old executive office building, of course, is called the Eisenhower Wing next to the White House. But the list is really endless, of things that were named after him, and that's a surefire sign of popularity.

- 7.59** Where does the greatness of Eisenhower lie, or the essence of his greatness?
- 7.60** In keeping the allies together. In making sure that the squabbles that broke out between the generals didn't actually affect operational efficiency. A classic example, of course, being the moment that he slapped the soldier—sorry, that George Patton slapped the soldier in the face. The soldier was suffering from what we would today call PTSD, which, as far as Patton was concerned, was a lack of moral fiber. And he took it out on this poor infantryman, who he assumed was essentially a coward. And there was a huge backlash against him, against Patton. And Eisenhower came under a good deal of pressure from Congress and the press to essentially sack the most impressive American fighting general of the war. And so he actually sent Patton off to—he wasn't going to sack him—he sent him off to command FUSAG, the First United States Army Group, which was a sort of phantom army that was kept across in southern Britain, across from the Pas-de-Calais, in order to keep the Germans thinking that that's where the attack was going to take place.
- 7.61** And Patton had to cool his heels there until such time as the Operation Overlord had been a success, and they got ashore, and then he was allowed to go and take over his army group again. So that's a classic example of a leader not giving in to public pressure, but instead using his best sense to basically get what he needed. And there are lots of other examples of that, actually. And he was also a bit like George Marshall. He was a good sacker of generals who weren't—and colonels—who weren't coming up with the goods.
- 7.62** We could call this session, or you've called the session, in fact, "Dwight D. Eisenhower and the Power of Diplomacy." Could you talk about the role of diplomacy in being a great leader?
- 7.63** Yes. Well, what he had to do, as well, of course, as dealing with the British and the Canadians, was also to deal with the French in the shape of Charles de Gaulle. And that was a very difficult thing to do because Charles de Gaulle recognized that he personified, in a way, the honor of France, because he had left France in the June of 1940. He'd only been a deputy war minister. He wasn't a major political figure, but he was the only political figure of any note who actually left France to go and live and work in Britain. General Giraud came over later, after he'd escaped from prison, but that was much later. And so, in a sense, standing up for the Free French, even though there weren't very many of them, they didn't have any money, they were under threat of

death from courts in France, and they didn't have much of a fleet. They were not allowed to use the French colonies, the French empire. So actually, de Gaulle was fighting from a very difficult position.

- 7.64 And yet, Eisenhower recognized the importance of having a Free French operation and also a resistance movement in France that would ultimately be immensely helpful, and was immensely helpful at the time of Operation Overlord, in interdicting German troop movements. So he had to put up with de Gaulle. And he did that in a much better way, frankly, than either Churchill or Roosevelt. Roosevelt thought of de Gaulle as an incipient dictator who he worried, wanted to become dictator of France. Churchill recognized that de Gaulle was a great man, but constantly made jokes about de Gaulle. The classic one is about having to, that his cross, the cross he had to bear was the cross of Lorraine. He said that de Gaulle reminded him of a llama surprised in her bath. There was one moment where he was, somebody equated de Gaulle with Joan of Arc, and Churchill complained that the bishops, his bishops, wouldn't burn de Gaulle in the way that the bishops burned Joan of Arc. It was just a stream of gags, essentially, that he deployed against de Gaulle.
- 7.65 But he recognized, Churchill recognized, that de Gaulle was a great man and so did Eisenhower, although they would have absolute stand-up rows, because de Gaulle, especially, the closer that D-Day came, the more difficult de Gaulle became over every issue, such as currency to be used and how quickly he was going to be installed as the ruler of France and so on. So, yes, diplomacy was vital. He also, of course, Eisenhower had to get on with the Soviets because they had to demarcate the lines where the two armies were going to stop at the Elbe, as it turned out. But there wasn't very much to stop the Soviets if they wanted to, steamrolling across western Germany. And the demarcation line were set out, of course, with regard to Berlin. Eisenhower didn't want to lose the 80,000 or so dead that the Russians had lost in taking Berlin.
- 7.66 And so that also required pretty steely and determined negotiations. And so, yes, he was a diplomat, and one can see also from his presidency, especially his final address, his presidential farewell address, in which he famously criticized the military-industrial complex, that he was willing to say things that only he could say. Essentially, you know, if you criticize the military-industrial complex and you're anyone less than Dwight, President Dwight Eisenhower, you come over as a sort of lily-livered communist. No one is going to say that, though, of the former Supreme Allied Commander.
- 7.67 We did the same for Churchill, and we'll do it for now Eisenhower. Are there any US politicians in the modern day that can hold a candle to Dwight D. Eisenhower?
- 7.68 I don't know enough about American politics today, I'm afraid, to make such a, to make such a controversial statement that would be absolutely, inevitably irritate at least 50% of my audience.
- 7.69 Is the mark of a great scholar to be able to state publicly that they don't know?

- 7.70 Well, I don't know, in that case.
- 7.71 Well, final question now to wrap up this session, as we've done before, the capstone question, what is the single greatest lesson we can take from Dwight D. Eisenhower?
- 7.72 That he was a great diplomat. And that that side of being a strategist is as important as the others. That he was also, had an element of humility. And if I can just quote a single sentence from his, from Abilene, where his birthplace was, and also where his rather wonderful presidential library is. And it says that "humility must always be the portion of any man who received acclaim, earned in the blood of his followers and the sacrifices of his friends." I think those are tremendously noble words.
- 7.73 Absolutely. Fantastic. Now we will turn it to the audience now for questions.
- 7.74 Hi, Dr. Roberts. I just wondered, how crucial do you think Eisenhower was to the successful denazification of Germany? And was there any sort of historical precedent he looked to in terms of the measures that were taken for it?
- 7.75 Yes, the denazification process was a vital one, for obvious reasons. And Eisenhower was very much behind all of the work that the Allies put into it. And he was a true believer in it. And one of the things that he did, which I think possibly the most impressive thing and influential thing that he did, was to make sure that German civilians were taken to the concentration camps and shown around Auschwitz and the other camps, and forced to accept and see the piles of corpses and the horrors of it. And that was a—it was quite a controversial decision at the time because, needless to say, the German civilians didn't really want to go, but he insisted they did. And what that did, I think, was to do, probably more than anything else, in promoting denazification.
- 7.76 On top of that, of course, they also did sack senior Nazis in senior positions, although that didn't go down right the way to the lowest levels in German society. Otherwise, they feared, probably rightly, that the whole of German society would collapse, or at least the organization of Germany would fail. So, yeah, he got that right. It wasn't an easy decision to take. It was highly controversial on both sides of the Atlantic. But it was one of his many achievements in between the surrender of Germany in May 1945 and him giving up his post.
- 7.77 One of the things I am curious about is the fact that America has tended to produce quite a few top military talents, like, for example, Eisenhower, Patton, and in previous generations, Ulysses S. Grant, despite the fact that America is so geographically placed that there aren't really immediate sort of military threats to the United States. And so I was curious, like, what are the ingredients for a country to really produce that top military talent that they can then make use of in these circumstances?
- 7.78 Well, General Patton, of course, came from a military family. There are lots of military families, especially in the south of the United States. And they also have the great

advantage of having a really first-class officer cadet system. You have these staff colleges like West Point and VMI and others that are really first class. When George Marshall went to VMI, he actually, on Sunday mornings, he would go to church and pray in the same church as the widow of Stonewall Jackson. So they really had a sort of apostolic succession from the Civil War all the way to the Second World War, in that sense. And, of course, at West Point, you can see the places where cannonballs were lodged in the walls, still can see them today. So the United States has a tremendously impressive and proud tradition of teaching and training that doesn't require invasions of their land mass to educate their soldiery.

7.79 How do these generals, towards the end of their lives, deal with such weighted decisions they had to take throughout their careers?

7.80 It's a good question. Many of them justified them, with President Truman, for example. He never for a moment thought that he had taken the wrong decision over the destruction of Nagasaki and Hiroshima. Neither do I, I hasten to add. But, of course, there was an awful lot of criticism of him much later on in his life because of that. Winston Churchill didn't really think he'd done that much wrong, either. He admitted that Gallipoli, of course, had been a disaster, but he was able to blame lots of factors beyond himself. Napoleon virtually didn't admit to a single error. He came up with about 40 reasons why the Battle of Waterloo was lost, none of which involved himself. Also, you don't get Margaret Thatcher apologizing for the sinking of the Belgrano, which was the most ruthless thing that she did.

7.81 When it came to Eisenhower, I think probably the most ruthless thing he did was this bombing of Normandy, which killed so many French civilians. It was something that he was so committed to that he threatened to resign if the chiefs of staff stopped the bombing taking place. And he doesn't go into it in any great detail in his very charming memoir. So I think one can, as an overall view, say that they were not nerve-racked or conscience-racked by their decisions. Obviously, some people, like FDR and Admiral Nelson, died before they were able to even get to the old age necessary to look at themselves. But it is very, very rare for a great leader in old age to admit, really, that they got some things wrong, especially when it came to ruthlessness. You get Robert McNamara, of course, in the Vietnam War. He, before the end of his life, very much reneged on the beliefs and statements that he'd made earlier on in that war, but otherwise, it's tremendously rare.

Lecture 8: Thatcher's Tenacity

At a glance — Margaret Thatcher and political tenacity, in the final session.

- 8.1** Lord Roberts, in this final session, we're going to be talking about Margaret Thatcher. Now, the first question I want to present to you is with regard to the Falkland Wars. Why was it such an unusual war?
- 8.2** Well, firstly, the Falkland Islands were 8,000 miles away from Britain. So it's very rare, in fact, I can't think of any actual precedent for a country fighting a war 8,000 miles away from its base. And they were 400 miles away from Argentina, as well. So, that was one aspect that was unusual. They had been in British possession since 1765, and the United Nations had made it clear that they should stay British for as long as the islanders themselves, about 1,800 of them, wanted to stay British. In every election, they 'd voted either 98 or 99% to stay British. And yet, the Argentinians invaded.
- 8.3** And so, it wasn't really a point of great national interest. We didn't get very much out of the Falklands or anything at all, really. Only 2,000 or so people there, but it was the principle. This is the thing that mattered to Margaret Thatcher. Although the great writer Jorge Luis Borges equated the war to "two bald men fighting over a comb," in fact, there was something that really did matter to Margaret Thatcher, and that is that you don't have a foreign dictatorship take over British territory.
- 8.4** Currently, how do we look back at the Falklands war? What is the view amongst the British public with regard to it today?
- 8.5** That it was a straightforward victory. That it was outrageous for the Argentinian junta to have invaded. There are some questions on the left that are still asked about the way that it was fought by Margaret Thatcher. But I think, amongst most British people, it's seen as an example of the British Army doing what it does best, which is traveling long distances and then fighting successfully at the end of it. And Navy, sorry. This is obviously not just an army thing. They were taken there by the Royal Navy, and it was very much a naval engagement as well.
- 8.6** Now, in describing Thatcher's approach to the Falklands War, vis-à-vis other British prime ministers, you wrote, and I quote, "Whereas every British prime minister since Churchill would probably have tried to do a deal with the Argentinians, Margaret Thatcher had the courage to see the conflict in stark black-and-white terms," unquote. Can you explain this statement and why it sets Thatcher apart from other British prime ministers?
- 8.7** Yes, because the person who followed Winston Churchill was Anthony Eden, and he got Britain involved in the Suez crisis in which Britain was humiliated. And although militarily we captured the Suez Canal in pretty short order, we were forced by international, primarily American, pressure to give up the Suez Canal and escape with

our tail between our legs. From that moment on, there was the underlying assumption that British power was in decline, that there weren't things worth fighting for. We withdrawn east of Suez in the 1960s. Every prime minister from Churchill onwards, when presented with a threat of an invasion or an actual invasion, would have tried to have done some kind of deal. There were deals on the table. The Argentinians were making noises about a condominium deal, whereby sovereignty was pooled and so on. But these were not for her, because she saw these issues in a Manichaeian sense of good and evil, and of British territory remaining British, and certainly not being given up to the threats from a foreign dictatorship.

- 8.8** Where did Margaret Thatcher's moral courage and political conviction come from?
- 8.9** Her parents, specifically her father, who was a Methodist lay preacher, somebody who would go from town to town in Lincolnshire and beyond, essentially preaching the Christian gospel, of which she was also a strong believer. He was also a grocer. He actually had his own small shop. This was also a source of pride to her that he was a small businessman and somebody who, of course, essentially, put capitalism into action every day. These were things that left her with a profound moral sense.
- 8.10** Now, you mentioned that her father was both a preacher and a grocer. So that, I suppose, implies that she came from a very modest background. Now, what role does social class play, or even indicate, in the likelihood of one becoming a great leader?
- 8.11** Well, in her case, it obviously wasn't that significant. As you say, she came from Grantham in Lincolnshire, very middle -class background. But look at some of the other people that we've had. Both actually Eisenhower and Marshall came from middle-class backgrounds, but Pericles and Julius Caesar and Winston Churchill all came from aristocratic backgrounds. I don't think it is that much of a key indicator, so long as the education that these people have is grasped by them. And if they don't get a good education, then they jolly well make their own through self-education.
- 8.12** And why don't we talk a bit about Margaret Thatcher's education? One thing that is quite interesting about her in that she noted that she was more happy to have been the first British prime minister that was a scientist than she was about being the first British prime minister that was a woman. Could you talk a bit about her role or her upbringing as a scientist, I should say?
- 8.13** Yes, she read chemistry. She was a chemist at Oxford, which, as you know, is the second best university in England.
- 8.14** Which was the first? So everyone knows. That's your —
- 8.15** Ours, wasn't it, I think?
- 8.16** That's right. Cambridge University.
- 8.17** But she had a very good education at Oxford. She did immensely well. She got a first class honors degree. She then went into a job as a chemist. It was only after that that

she became a politician. She had been chairman of the Oxford University Conservative Association, so she was always interested in politics. But no, I think the chemistry side of her education, the scientific side, was something that she took enormous pride from. And of course, later in her premiership, it was one of the reasons that she was the first, really, major British politician to understand the environmental movement, the threat of global warming, and so on, was something that she actually grasped early on in a way that other figures, especially politicians on the right, didn't.

- 8.18** Now, the other question that could be asked about that notion of her caring more about being a scientist than a woman, was her view on, I suppose, gender politics and being a woman in a seat of power in a very powerful Western nation. Did she have any thoughts on this?
- 8.19** Yes, she did. They were not—I mean, she was in no sense feminist. She did not think that that was the way forward. She thought that, she would make jokes against men occasionally, but they were funny jokes, rather than being made because of any great political point that she was making. It was frankly time, by the late 1970s, for there to be a woman prime minister. They'd been in politics for 60 years plus. It was pretty—and they'd had cabinet ministers, including important ones. The time had come for this. Admittedly, in lots of other countries, they still had to wait some time before it happened. But in Britain, we were a mature enough democracy to have a prime minister in the late 1970s.
- 8.20** Now, I like the point you mentioned there around jokes. Is sense of humor something that's important to leadership?
- 8.21** No. I wish it were, but no. Much as I loved and admired Margaret Thatcher, no one would ever accuse her of having a sense of humor. It's, of course, true. I mean, it's quite nerve-racking. You go to one of her drinks parties and you'd expect to make small talk and have a chat. She'd say, "So what do you think of NATO, Andrew, at the moment?" You'd think, "Oh, my gosh, there's not even two words of, 'Hello, what about the weather?'" That kind of thing, let alone joshing and joking. There was absolutely no point in trying to do that with Margaret Thatcher. But who cares? You're talking to a world historical figure, and you don't really expect to have too much chitchat at the best of times.
- 8.22** With other leaders, yes, you can have very funny leaders. Napoleon—I think there are about 80 Napoleon jokes in my book. He was a very funny man. People who were around him looked forward to listening to what he had to say, not just because he was immensely powerful, but because he was also funny. There was a moment when the Cardinal Archbishop of Rheims wrote to him an incredibly sucky-up, oleaginous letter saying how wonderful Napoleon was. Napoleon writes in the margin of the letter. He says, "Please send 6,000 francs to the Cardinal Archbishop out of the theatrical fund."

- 8.23** Churchill, of course, could hardly open his mouth if he wanted to say something funny and witty, a brilliant riposte, a put-down, a joke. My favorite one at the moment—my favorite Churchill jokes change a lot, as you can imagine—my favorite one at the moment was something that he said to Jock Colville, who, as I mentioned earlier, was his pretty much favorite private secretary. Colville told him that their cook had been made pregnant as a result of a nocturnal assignation with a man in the street in Verona. And Churchill replied, "Obviously not one of the two gentlemen."
- 8.24** Is there another Churchill joke that you have that you really like?
- 8.25** OK, yeah, of course.
- 8.26** [inaudible] I want to hear a few more.
- 8.27** There's the moment when the German ambassador, Joachim von Ribbentrop, later the Foreign Minister, goes up to Churchill at a party in Whitehall, St. James's, before the Second World War. And in a threatening manner, says, "You do realize that in the next war, Italy will be on the side of the Third Reich?" And Churchill replied, "Well, it seems only fair. We had to have them last time."
- 8.28** That's great. Well, he's quite a Silly Billy. He's funny. Why don't we move now to religious faith? In the last session, you spoke a little bit about Dwight D. Eisenhower's religious conviction, and you'd mentioned now that Margaret Thatcher had a father that was a preacher. Can you speak to the importance of religious faith in general, as it relates to great leadership?
- 8.29** Well, and also actually, whilst we're talking about the individuals, Admiral Nelson's father, of course, was also a vicar, and George Marshall was a believer as well. I'm not saying that Eisenhower was an evangelist or anything, but he believed in God. Whereas the others—Julius Caesar was Pontifex maximus, which is a very important religious, indeed, the important, religious position in Rome. But it was also quite a political position. He did rather disgrace himself because he was very interested in sleeping with other men's wives. Had a great reputation for doing that. That's not what you were supposed to do when you were Pontifex maximus. But it didn't really mean that he was a tremendously religious figure. As we know also, Pericles wasn't. So, no, I don't think that there's any automatic sense that because somebody believes in a god, that they're more or less likely to be successful leaders.
- 8.30** Now, Margaret Thatcher bears the moniker of the Iron Lady. Can you explain why this is and maybe how she got that name?
- 8.31** Yes, it was originally a term of abuse by the Russian media. They were trying to be sarcastic and critical and somewhat sneering and said, "This woman, the Iron Lady." Of course, she loved that. Grabbed it, kept it, burnished it. It actually turned into one of her propaganda coups, to be called this. It's not unusual, by the way, in history, for people to be given a throwaway or negative name, and then for it to be picked up.

Tory, for example, which means essentially British conservative, originally meant Irish horse thief. The term Whig also wasn't particularly nice, either. But once they're picked up and made something of, and they're given the pattern of history after 250 years, then nobody really remembers the original meaning.

- 8.32** Are there any monikers that you also like or enjoy from other leaders?
- 8.33** Julius Caesar was called Old Baldy, but I don't think that was particularly witty, is it? I don't suppose you think it's particularly witty?
- 8.34** It's OK.
- 8.35** I'm thinking less and less that it's particularly witty.
- 8.36** OK, I catch your drift. Let's move on. Was Margaret Thatcher ruthless?
- 8.37** She wasn't a ruthless person. We've used this trope before. I know she wasn't a ruthless person, but she had the capacity for ruthlessness —the classic example, of course, being the sinking of the Argentinian cruiser, the Belgrano. The General Belgrano was moving in and out of a total exclusion zone, a 12-mile zone that Britain put around the Falkland Islands and ordered—I'm so sorry, 200-mile zone—and ordered the Argentinian navy not to cross. Well, it was crossing it, and it zigzagged in and out of it. And she sank it, gave orders to HMS Conqueror, a British hunter-killer, a submarine, to sink it with the loss of 323 Argentinian sailors. She's been criticized a good deal on the left for having done that. But frankly, what it did do was to keep the Italian navy in port. It never came out after that, during the rest of the Falkland's War, which ultimately saved quite a few lives because the Conqueror would have taken out a good deal, a good proportion of the Argentinian navy, if it had.
- 8.38** Now, did her contemporaries, that is, fellow leaders during that period of time, view her as ruthless? What was their perception of Margaret Thatcher?
- 8.39** Well, I think she actually went up in most people's estimation. It certainly was something that made it clear to the Americans, to President Reagan, Caspar Weinberger, and others, that we were serious, that we were going to fight and kill for the sovereignty of the Falkland Islands. So, yes, in that sense, I don't think it damaged her international reputation. It was just on the left that this ruthlessness was heavily criticized.
- 8.40** And what was Margaret Thatcher's great self-realization moment?
- 8.41** It was at Deptford when she was 24 years old in the 1950 general election, where she cut the Labour majority from 19,000 to 13,000. Now, that doesn't sound necessarily like a great thing. But nonetheless, it was an important election that it was the one that essentially rubbed out the great 1945 Labour landslide victory that we were talking earlier, with regard to Churchill. So, under Churchill, she managed to get essentially within striking distance, although she didn't get into the House of Commons until 1959. But it taught her that she had the capacity to be a successful politician. As we know,

again and again, that moment in the early to mid-20s, or in Stalin's case, with the bank robbery, 28, these are the times that the people have a sense of themselves as having capacities for leadership. That's the moment that it happened for her.

- 8.42** What was Margaret Thatcher's view of women in politics at that point in time? Politics is, again, historically perceived to be a very gendered profession, if we can call it that. Did she have any thoughts on her role as a woman in a powerful seat of office?
- 8.43** Not too much. She certainly didn't think it was her duty as a woman to promote other women in politics. There were relatively few in her cabinets. She wasn't a feminist in that sense. She recognized that her example was pretty impressive, and in as far as many European countries at the time, pretty extraordinary. But she wasn't somebody who had a driving sense that women needed to be advanced artificially beyond their own capacities, because that had not happened with her. She knew that she had the capacity to be a very successful prime minister.
- 8.44** Today, within the British public conscience, how do we view Margaret Thatcher?
- 8.45** Again, it's rather like Napoleon Bonaparte in the French concept. Those on the right, those in the Conservative party, still look up to her as having been an absolute beacon for moral leadership. On the left, they still very much remember the crises of the miners' strike, for example, of 1984 to 85, which she defeated. They remember the sinking of the Belgrano, as I mentioned earlier. They remember the dislocation of British industry, deliberate dislocation, because she didn't believe that a lot of the manufacturing industry that we had in this country was going to be able to survive in the long term. She was proved right of that, but it didn't mean that there wasn't a lot of heartache getting from there to here, as it were. Yes, she's still a controversial figure as a political figure.
- 8.46** However, I think she's very much admired, first of all, for being the trailblazing woman prime minister and also for the way in which she was able to articulate politics in a moral sense. She absolutely believed in what she said. She was rather like these great leaders of the past. She wasn't afraid of saying things that were unpopular if she believed them. Very unusual in modern-day politics, but something that an awful lot of people yearn for, frankly, in politics. And so, I think she's very much admired as the original conviction politician.
- 8.47** Now, you alluded to this in a segment a little back, but you knew Margaret Thatcher very well. In fact, my understanding is that she would invite you to dinner parties, and you would do the same. In fact, I believe that she personally appointed you as the replacement for her in the Margaret Thatcher Archive Trust. What was Margaret Thatcher like?
- 8.48** Well, utterly wonderful. Of course, when you came away from an evening with her, you felt as though you had been with a world historical figure, undoubtedly. Partly because she didn't want to do all the jokes and the small talk and the lightweight stuff, she

would go straight into the big issues. Then you would have an insight into the thoughts of somebody who had been prime minister for 11.5 years in very turbulent times. So there was, I don't know, there was a real sense that you had been conversing with history. As a historian, obviously, that 's something that's very exciting. She also had a wonderful husband in Denis Thatcher, who was fascinated by people like Lord Alan Brooke and the general staff of the Second World War. So I would talk endlessly with Denis. He was a lovely man. And so, yes, I think I counted as one of the great privileges of my life to have known her.

- 8.49** Wonderful. Suffice to say, she was not much of a party animal.
- 8.50** She gave parties and she went to parties, but she wanted to have serious conversations at parties. You weren't going to get some lightweight social chitchat at all. It was going to go straight into, with a NATO.
- 8.51** OK, how about this? Of the eight we've looked at so far, is there any in particular that you would have liked to party with? Who would have been good fun? Maybe I'll phrase it in that way.
- 8.52** I think "party with" has a different connotation in America, doesn't it, than England? I'm not sure. We stand around with a glass of champagne chitchatting. Is that roughly what you mean?
- 8.53** Why don't we go with that? As a statistician, we have a tendency of defining things very clearly. So let's use that definition of chitchat.
- 8.54** I would, right now, if you had a small guillotine, I would give you my little finger to be able to spend an evening with Winston Churchill. I appreciate that he wouldn't be terribly interested in me or the —actually, knowing that actually I was his biographer, he probably would be interested in me, but I recognize that he'd do most of the talking, but I'd want him to do most of the talking. I'd let you chop off my finger right now in order to spend an evening with him.
- 8.55** All right. Well, who in the modern world do you see as exhibiting good leadership today?
- 8.56** I think Volodymyr Zelenskyy has exhibited great leadership. I think that that statement about needing ammunition, not a ride, staying in Kyiv when it 's under attack, when he knows that there are death squads out to try and kill him, keeping his family in Kyiv, not allowing Ukrainian males of military age to leave the country, but instead making it clear to the world that he was willing to fight to the death to protect his capital, that is pure Churchillian leadership. In fact, he's been called Churchill with an iPhone, which I think is a very telling phrase and a very good one. So yes, as far as he's concerned, the way in which he differentiated himself from the Afghan president, who basically just filled up his suitcases with dollars and tried to get a—and did get—a helicopter out of Kabul. That's the lack of leadership that could have led to the absolute extirpation of

Ukraine as an independent country within days. Instead, you had that extraordinary leadership of President Zelenskyy's that meant that his country was, and is being, crucified—20% of it under foreign occupation, but they are fighting for their lives.

- 8.57** Now, one thing that you talk about as it relates to Margaret Thatcher was her ability to imbue morality in leadership. Is the capacity for leadership in and of itself a good thing, morally?
- 8.58** No, it isn't, because you do see leaders like Stalin, like Hitler, who are thrown up by events and by the, very often, the dark side of the human soul. I think it's a morally neutral thing, like nuclear fission, which can be used for good and obviously also used for terrible ill. Or the sea. There are things that are there that aren't morally good or evil, but can be used for either. That's certainly the case, I think, with great leadership.
- 8.59** Now, thinking about Margaret Thatcher once again, what is the single greatest lesson we can learn from her?
- 8.60** It's very much the same one as Winston Churchill's, I think. Moral courage. Having the ability, the will, to say pretty much the opposite of what other people have been saying for years and years, which is what she did at the time of the Falklands, and in many other ways as well, actually. It takes guts. You are going to be ridiculed. You are going to be lambasted. You're going to have lies told about you in the press and elsewhere. But ultimately, if you do believe in what you're saying, if you do have that conviction like Churchill did, like Margaret Thatcher did, and you're ultimately proved right by events, then it's the apogee of leadership. It's what Pericles was trying to do. It's what the strategos should do. And when you can pull it off, then it really is the greatest thing in the world.
- 8.61** Excellent. Now, as we conclude this session, I want to move to some concluding questions, wrapping up the eight lectures that have been done now. So, looking at modern-day leaders, what quality do you think that they lack that the eight leaders that we've discussed have in great abundance?
- 8.62** I think quite a lot of modern leaders do put in the time, the hard work. That is obviously an important one that we've seen again and again in the course of these 8 hours. The vital importance of self-education, of constantly trying to learn from your mistakes and to teach yourself, especially, obviously, learning from the past, is something that we see in pretty much all of these leaders. The capacity to deal with setbacks. Stalin, Hitler, Winston Churchill, in fact, Charles de Gaulle, they all went to prison at some stage in their lives, and they managed to turn it around and actually become a great leader instead. So even that—Nelson losing his arm and his eye —terrible, massive personal setbacks are things that you deal with and you get over and you learn from and you fight back. And that's something that you see again and again in these leaders.
- 8.63** There is, of course, an element of ruthlessness that we've seen in almost all of them. There's also the self-realization moment where, because of something they've done,

they do recognize that they have the capacity to be unusual. Just to put it at its most basic, that they are not like everybody else, essentially. Then there's the great issue of combining physical bravery and moral bravery, and to be able to put those two together as well, at the key moment in the key place —the *schwerpunkt*, as we talked about earlier, that point d'appui that means that the moment is grasped.

- 8.64** If you have all of that, if you have the kind of foresight that Winston Churchill had, of course, as well, so you're constantly looking at the events of the world, about what's going on around you, and seeing that moment. And again, this doesn't have to be politics, it doesn't have to be war. This can be a business moment. You see that opening, and the opportunities, really, to grasp it as well. All of these things come together, and all of these things and more come together. When they do, you have an opportunity where you can essentially defeat what T.S. Eliot called the "vast impersonal forces," and actually mold events to your will.
- 8.65** Now, you're obviously well-read on many, many great leaders. This course could have easily been 40 hours with each hour focusing on a great leader. And among these vast panoply of great leaders, why exactly did you select these eight?
- 8.66** Simply because I thought I knew about them enough to be able to talk for hours about them and not either bore myself or hopefully the audience. There are people who, I don't know, well, I was seven years old when my dad took me to watch the Waterloo movie. I've been a historian for most of my life. I read history at university and have written 20 books now over the last 30 years. So, yes, I wanted to choose people who I thought I could draw certain common threads from in a useful way that would explain something about leadership.
- 8.67** I suspect I already know the answer to this question, but I will ask it nonetheless. Of the eight that we've looked at, who do you most admire?
- 8.68** Winston Churchill. Yes, I do. I've written five books with him in the title or the subtitle, so I imagine that you did know that that was what the answer was going to be. But he's just so endlessly fascinating. Even the most boring speeches he gives, the budget speeches when he's Chancellor of the Exchequer, for example, are really well worth reading because he will always have some fascinating *aperçu*, some jokes, some witticism, some aspect that you're not expecting. The depth of his knowledge, that Macaulay-esque turn of phrase, it's an Augustine style, which, of course, has gone out of fashion, but still looks as good on the page as it does when you hear it, especially in that wonderful voice of his. Yes, I still have a fascination for him.
- 8.69** Could you tell us another Churchill joke?
- 8.70** I'm not going to do that, but what I am going to do is just end with a quotation from Thomas Carlyle, which is about, and in a sense, and lots of your questions have been implying quite correctly, I think, that we are essentially living in a post-heroic world. That we don't look up to heroes in the way that we used to, and that there are fewer

heroes, anyway, genuine heroes, for us to look up to. If we're looking for heroes now, they seem to be sporting heroes or pop stars or whatever. They're not people who have the positions and capacity and wherewithal to make our lives better. But Thomas Carlyle said this, and I think it's very important. He said that "no sadder proof can be given by a man of his own littleness than disbelief in great men." Let's take that away, and maybe that, and also Napoleon's statement that "one must speak to the soul. It's the only way to electrify the men."

- 8.71** Who of these eight leaders do you think is best positioned to solve the world's problems today?
- 8.72** Margaret Thatcher. I'd love to have her back. She, of course, died in 2013. It was a powerfully emotional moment at her funeral. I did feel at the time that we have been followed by minnows, politically, I'm afraid. Very little has happened since then to make me change my mind.
- 8.73** When we look at these leaders, one might notice something of a chronology of sorts, in the sense that Napoleon saw Julius Caesar in himself. Dwight D. Eisenhower was a protégé of George C. Marshall. Of course, Margaret Thatcher took great inspiration from Winston Churchill. Is it the case—
- 8.74** Who himself took inspiration from Julius Caesar, who himself took inspiration from Alexander the Great. Yes, there is an apostolic succession.
- 8.75** Natural chronology here. So is it the case that great leaders beget other great leaders?
- 8.76** Well, at least learning about them, knowing about them, reading about them, trying to understand them. Yes, absolutely. I think if you try and go through life without taking any instruction or example from anybody else before you, I think you're in danger of doing exactly what Thomas Carlyle said. You're in danger of showing your own littleness.
- 8.77** Now, upon closer observation, one thing that we can notice with all of these leaders is that they faced some major martial conflict. They were involved in planning a war or overseeing a war. Is it the case that good leaders become great leaders because of war?
- 8.78** It does help. I'm afraid part of the human condition that we are fascinated by death and killing. It's obviously a weakness in the human soul, but it's there. As I mentioned right at the beginning of this series, it's very difficult to be a very great historical leader if you're prime minister of Luxembourg in a time of peace. That ain't going to cut it. So that is the case. However, as I also have, I hope, got through, you can be a great leader without being a soldier or a statesman. You can be a great leader in business. You can be a great leader in your community. But no, your name isn't necessarily going to resonate down the ages alongside Dwight Eisenhower and Pericles.

- 8.79** Now, this is my final question to you. How would you sum up the message of these eight lectures?
- 8.80** Golly. Well, with regard to all of these things to do with hard work and foresight and self-education and trying to be as morally brave as you are, physically brave and so on—all of these, I think, come together in the realization, the expectation, at least, that you can change yourself, you can change society, you can change history. It can be done by the individual. Don't believe that vast impersonal forces are controlling your world. They're not. It's up to you, ultimately, to become the master of your soul.
- 8.81** The Earl of St. Vincent had an interesting quote with regard to Horatio Nelson, "imbuing one's soul in other people." Is that the essence of great leadership?
- 8.82** Yes, and Napoleon had it as well. I think that that 's a very good way of putting it. He knew Nelson well. He didn't think much of Nelson morally, of course. As we 've established, sexual morality does not particularly overlap one way or another. It's a line of David Lloyd George's when he was asked by a journalist, presumably very much off the record, whether or not he was going to take Mrs. Lloyd George to the Paris Peace Conference, Lloyd George replied, "Would you take sandwiches to a banquet?" Which is a pretty terrible thing to say, needless to say, about one's own wife, and slightly does underline my argument about morality and leadership, not over sexual morality, at least, not overlapping. But nonetheless, we've seen other examples, obviously, of people like Winston Churchill and Margaret Thatcher and George Marshall, who were very much in love with their spouses throughout their lives.
- 8.83** On that note, I think we'll end there. It's been a pleasure speaking with you. Thank you.
- 8.84** Thank you.
- 8.85** Why don't we open it now to the audience for final questions?
- 8.86** OK.
- 8.87** Lord Roberts, you were speaking earlier about challenges that people turn to their advantage. I wanted to ask you, what you thought was, which of the two you thought were the greatest challenge for Margaret Thatcher within the Conservative party, not with the electorate. Was her class or her sex? And then because she probably wasn't that interested in that type of identity politics, I also wanted to ask what you thought is her enduring legacy on Britain today?
- 8.88** Yes, I think that, as you say, she wasn't that interested in identity politics. She didn't see herself primarily as the first woman prime minister. She thought of herself as somebody who desperately needed to change the trajectory of her country, which was in very serious danger of slipping into the second rank of nations. The threat to her from within the Conservative party, really, in the late 1980s, you saw it more and more. It was from people who, of course, wanted to stay in the European Union. That was a growing and large group of Conservatives who didn't like her brand of Euro-skepticism,

and that was ideological. There were also people who, frankly, didn't like her because, not that she was a woman, but that she was exhibiting a style of leadership that they didn't like. They wanted to have a much more corporate concept in cabinet. They wanted to be kowtowed to a little bit more than she was willing to do. She wasn't suffering fools gladly.

- 8.89** By the end of her time as prime minister, which is always dangerous because you are always going to have quite a few fools in your cabinet, however well you've chosen. So, yes, it was a rebellion that eventually was successful in November 1990. I would argue that the Conservative party has hardly ever been happy, had a happy day since, frankly. So bringing her down was quite self-defeating in a way, although they did, of course, win the subsequent general election.
- 8.90** Thank you, Lord Roberts. From all the study that you've done of all of history's great leaders that you've read about, what is one attribute that you've noticed connects them all, that perhaps we, each of us, could model in the lives that we individually lead as earthly mortals?
- 8.91** Oh, that's an easy one. That's the first easy question that I've been given. Thank you. On the day of the Queen's coronation, on the 2nd of June 1953, Winston Churchill was crossing Westminster Hall, and there was a young American who asked him for some life advice. And he said, Winston Churchill said, "Study history, study history, for therein lies all the secrets of statecraft." And that's the answer to your question. All of us in this room can do it. I love doing it, and I've loved doing it for around the last 40 years or so, but we can all do it tomorrow. Just study history, and that will, again and again, give you hints about and signposts to the future.
- 8.92** Margaret Thatcher being the key female example, even though that wasn't the role that she'd like to describe as most important to become prime minister, do you think the traits that make successful female leaders are different to the traits that make successful male leaders? Or do you think perhaps it is the traits embodied across that are more prevalent in one individual than the other? My second question was, you said history is incredibly important, and as a common phrase, "those that don't know history are condemned to repeat it." And yet, looking at the climate today, do you think that's not been heeded well and that we are, in fact, regardless of how well one can know history themselves, because of a wider culture, you are destined to continue making the same mistakes?
- 8.93** I think that when one looks at female leaders in history, one sees a common trait being that as Rudyard Kipling, Margaret Thatcher's favorite poet, put it, "The female of the species is deadlier than the male." You see Boadicea, Elizabeth I, Catherine de Medici, Catherine the Great, Maria Teresa, Indira Gandhi, Golda Meir, we could go on. They are just as likely to launch wars and fight wars and win wars, by the way, including Margaret Thatcher, as their male counterparts. People who say that what we need is a

world ruled by women because they will abolish war are talking absolute rubbish, as far as I'm concerned, historically, at least.

- 8.94** With regard to learning the lessons of history, actually, I think we do quite a lot. I think that the, certainly, the American army, for example, learnt a lot of lessons from the Yom Kippur War that they were later able to put into operation in the first Gulf War. The Pentagon sent out 36 commissions to write reports about what we can learn from this war to help us with the next war. But I think on a deeper level, what you were saying is how to not have wars at all. That would be the real way for humankind to advance. And yet, I don't think we really, in terms of human nature, have moved on hugely since the days of the Peloponnesian War and the way in which the Thucydides wrote about it.
- 8.95** Given Britain's diminished status as an imperial power in the mid-20th century, how did Margaret Thatcher envision Britain 's role in the world in the sense of grand strategy?
- 8.96** Very much as part of NATO. She was a huge believer in NATO. She saw NATO as keeping the Americans in the tent, ensuring that the Germans didn't dominate Europe again, and keeping the Soviet Union behind the Iron Curtain, as she knew it, obviously up until it fell at about the same time as she did. So she saw Britain's strategic and security place in the world as being a linchpin of the Atlantic alliance. She believed in the special relationship. She personified it in many ways, actually, with her friendship with Ronald Reagan, which was on a personal level, as well as an ideological and political one. So, she had a strong sense of Britain 's place in the world, as well as, obviously, with regard to the Security Council of the United Nations being a nuclear power, and the Commonwealth as well. Yeah, this was an area where she had no doubts.
- 8.97** Looking at all these great leaders, what can we learn when we have to discern between following the rules and, I guess, thinking outside the box or taking the unusual path?
- 8.98** Well, I think the best leader to follow there is Admiral Nelson, where he very much thought outside the box when he was ordered to break off the attack in the Battle of Copenhagen in 1807, and took no notice and ignored it, and carried on to win the battle. If, on the other hand, he had failed to win the battle, he'd have been court-martialed, and rightly so. So ultimately, the thing you can take from that is that success is its own reward, and try not to fail.